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THE NEW YORKER



by et

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Goings On

- [A Wondrous Array of Boundary Pushers at SummerStage](#)
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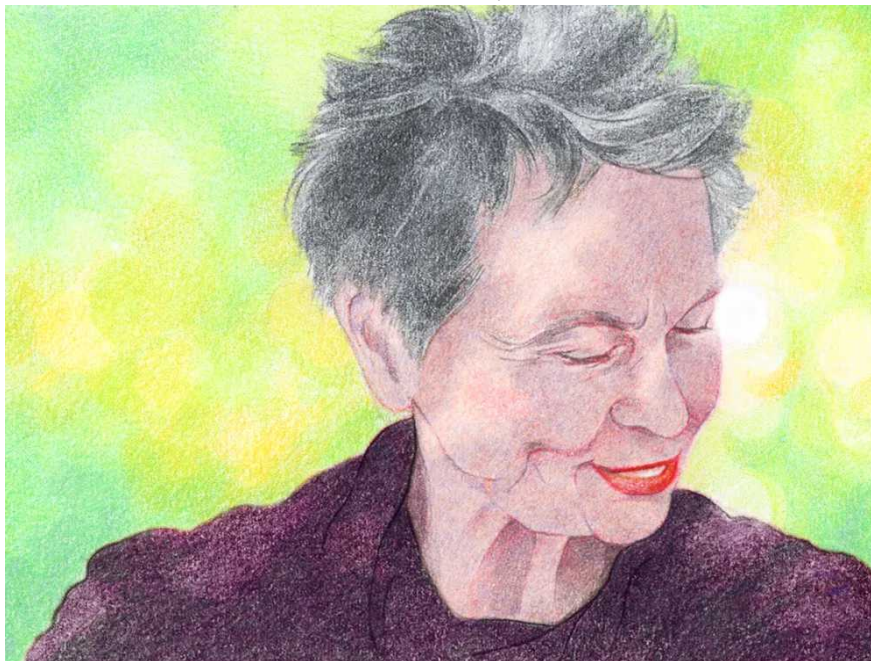
Goings On

A Wondrous Array of Boundary Pushers at SummerStage

Also: Lucy Sante's poignant humor, American Ballet Theatre's summer season, the incisive melodrama of Satyajit Ray, and more.

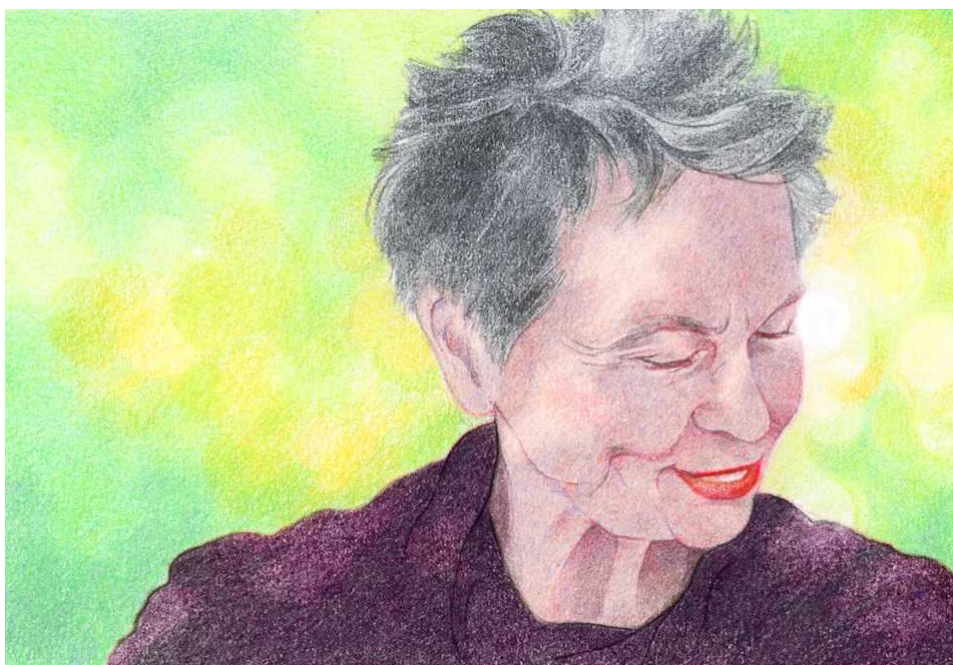
By Sheldon Pearce, Inkoo Kang, Marina Harss, Richard Brody, Hilton Als, Rachel Syme

June 12, 2026

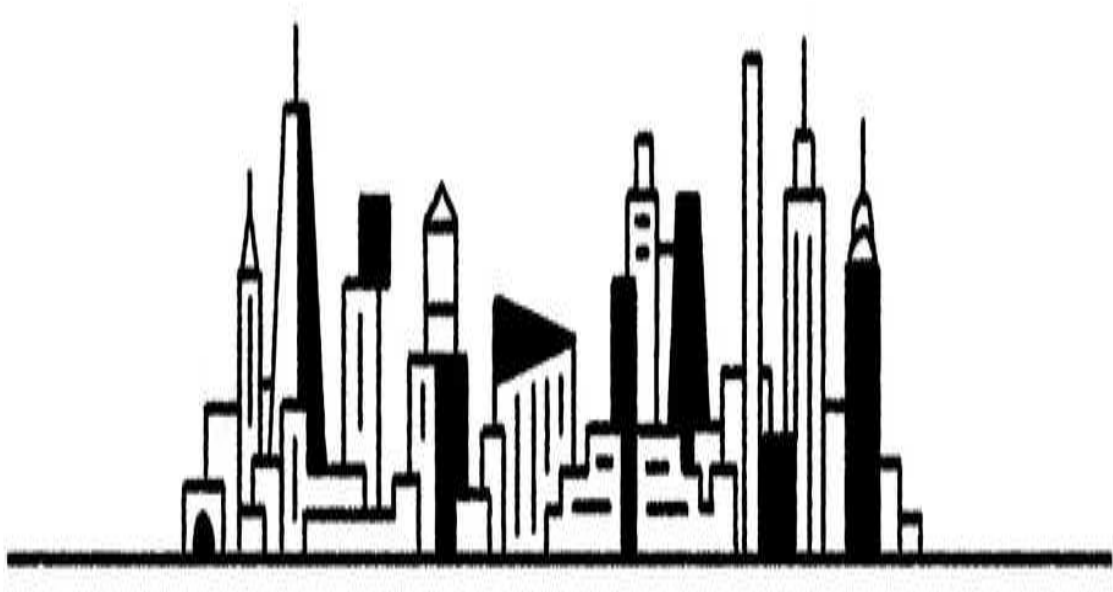


This year, [City Parks Foundation SummerStage](#) celebrates its landmark fortieth anniversary by bringing a wide and wondrous array of free shows to more than a dozen parks across the five boroughs, including Central Park. With the festival already in full swing, many of the most exciting acts are yet to come. Kicking off an exceptional run of shows is the avant-garde artist Laurie Anderson (June 26), backed by the jazz quartet Sexmob, for the multidisciplinary performance “Republic of Love,” presented as a meditation on the state of the union and doubling as a reimagining of key Anderson works. Other boundary pushers join the festivities: the soul

revivalists Bilal and *GENA* (July 12), the American fixture Mavis Staples (July 16), the West African icon Angélique Kidjo (Aug. 23).



Throughout the summer, audiences of diverse taste gather in collective support of a rich, collated music scene. In jazz, the mavericks *SHABAKA* and Kokoroko break the ice (July 1), before several shows held in conjunction with the [Charlie Parker Jazz Festival](#): the Jazz at Lincoln Center Orchestra (Aug. 28); the saxophonist Joshua Redman with the pianist Nat Adderley, Jr. (Aug. 29); and the saxophonist Ravi Coltrane, the drummer Kassa Overall, and the vocalist Vanisha Gould (Aug. 30). In rock, the Austin indie band Spoon is co-billed alongside Ratboys (July 8), and Andrew Bird performs with the Wordless Music Orchestra, for the twentieth anniversary of his album “The Mysterious Production of Eggs” (Aug. 6). And, in hip-hop, such home-town m.c.s as *MIKE*, Max B (July 11), De La Soul (July 17), and Doug E. Fresh (July 31) lead homages to rap mecca.—*Sheldon Pearce*



About Town

Television

The new dramedy “**The Audacity**,” on AMC, offers a panoramic critique of Silicon Valley’s particular form of trickle-down rot. Duncan Park (Billy Magnussen) is the C.E.O. of a data-mining startup called Hypergnosis, whose latest project—a program described as “God’s eye”—collects intimate details about people, including the man whom Duncan’s wife, Lili (Lucy Punch), just slept with (they have an open marriage), and Duncan’s financially strapped therapist, JoAnne (Sarah Goldberg), who rationalizes her insider trading. The tech is terrifying, but it’s treated matter-of-factly, played for barked laughs. “The Audacity” ’s focus on data harvesting gives the show its strange verve, born of a conviction that it can make this perpetually overlooked issue an object of emotional investment. Its satirical aim feels spot-on.—*Inkoo Kang (Now streaming.)*

Alternative Rock

The modern pop paradigm has been greatly influenced by Jack Antonoff, the producer du jour who cut his teeth in such bands as fun. and Steel Train. He has been prolific and versatile, with a robust set of credits: the singer-songwriters Taylor Swift and Lana Del Rey, the art-rockers St. Vincent and the 1975, and the rappers Kendrick Lamar and Doja Cat. When he isn't on call for culture-shifters, he maintains his creative autonomy as the front man of **Bleachers**, a solo project turned full band that has furthered his indie-rock bona fides. On the heels of its confessional new album, "everyone for ten minutes," Bleachers takes the stage with the special guest **Wednesday**.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([*Madison Square Garden*](#); June 23.)

Dance



American Ballet Theatre brings out its biggest, most lavish productions to fill the giant stage at the Metropolitan Opera House. Its season opens *and* closes with the biggest of them all, "Swan Lake," to be performed by a slew of its ballerinas, including the young, but already stunningly refined, Chloe Misseldine. (The fiery Catherine Hurlin is her antithesis, all boldness and power.) Then comes "Onegin," John Cranko's opulent and fussy take on Pushkin's novel in verse. The Russian powerhouse Natalia Osipova returns for a single performance of "Don Quixote," the same ballet in which she

emerged with an explosive stage presence and a jump like a colt, with her first company, the Bolshoi. But the pearl of the season is “Sylvia,” Frederick Ashton’s tongue-in-cheek gloss on Greek mythology, to a glistening score by Léo Delibes.—*Marina Harss* ([Metropolitan Opera House](#); June 17-July 18.)

Movies

As the writer and director of “**Maddie’s Secret**,” John Early parodies previous generations’ disease-of-the-week TV movies with forced antics that play like a comedy sketch inflated to feature-film length. His ingenuity, however, is on bold display in his performance: he stars as Maddie Ralph, a food magazine’s test-kitchen dishwasher who aspires to be a great chef. When her worshipful husband (Eric Rahill) posts videos of her home cooking online, she becomes famous overnight, and the magazine makes her its video star. But colleagues’ cattiness and her own insecurity dredge up traumatic memories and send her spiralling into bulimia. Early portrays Maddie with earnest intensity that yields authentic emotion, but the movie’s satire is meek and its sense of style is both bland and slapdash.—*Richard Brody* (*Opening June 19 in limited release.*)

Art

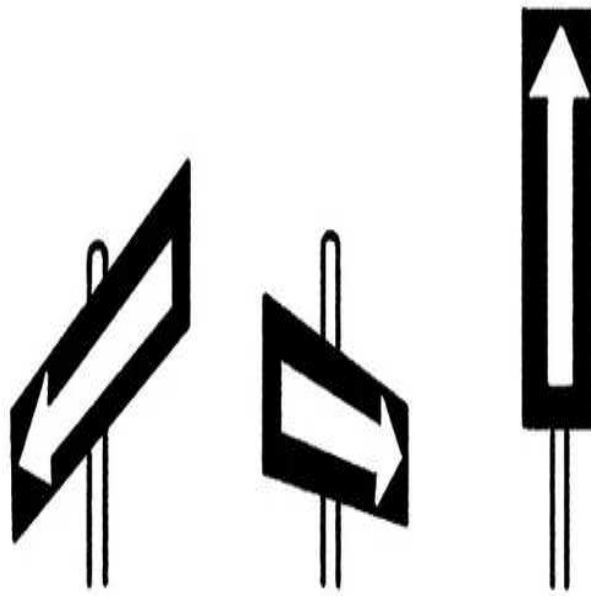


There's a lot of poignancy and humor in "Knots," **Lucy Sante's** show of collages, which are beautifully displayed in one of the Academy's stately libraries. Actually, the subversive images, which often feature a female protagonist standing amid world history—one of the strongest shows a chic woman in profile with pursed lips, blowing on an image of Haussmann's Paris being blown up—are wonderful examples of instances where writing is made visual, and where the visual is a form of writing. Another especially strong piece shows the words "*DE LA*" and features a man examining a woman's back, where a large hand print has been left. In these various worlds, Sante focusses on the body, and what history and collage can make, and have already made, of it.—*Hilton Als* ([*American Academy of Arts and Letters*](#); through July 3.)

Movies

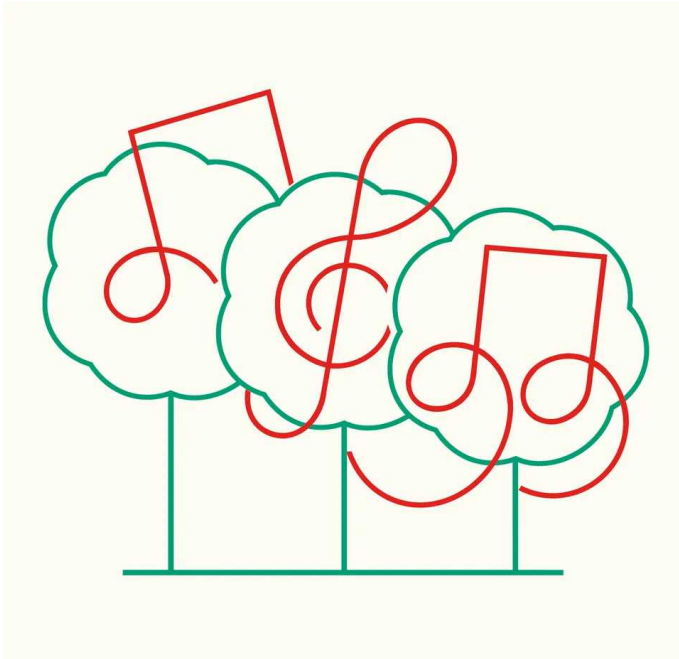
In Satyajit Ray's emotionally harsh and finely observed melodrama "**Days and Nights in the Forest**," from 1970, four educated young men from Kolkata, staring grimly into the maw of middle age amid frustrations in love and work, drive to a remote rural zone for a few days of uninhibited machismo. They flash their cash amid the peasantry, bribe a gatekeeper for use of a bungalow, and drink themselves silly. Then they meet the local

gentry, including an unmarried woman of poetic refinement and a still youthful and desperately lonesome widow, and the story of unstrung dissolution turns rapturous and scathing. Ray's incisive view of the gross inequities of the caste system, a stifling bureaucratic order, and rigid traditions reveals the societal roots of intimate misery.—*R.B. (Film Forum; through June 18.)*



Pick Three

Rachel Syme on summer cultural happenings.



1. I have lived in New York City for twenty years, and yet there are still parts of it that feel completely foreign to me, one being Roosevelt Island, a two-mile-long slice of fertile land plopped into the East River. Formerly Blackwell's Island, it was the original home of the city jail, a giant tuberculosis ward, and a crumbling mental asylum (where the journalist Nellie Bly reported her 1887 exposé, "Ten Days in a Mad House"). The modern island still has a strange vibe: there is a tramway, a Gothic lighthouse, and a huge cat sanctuary. And now another mystical attraction: inside Four Freedoms Park, on the island's southern tip, is a wonderful sound installation by the Finnish artist Hans Rosenström, called "[Out of Silence](#)" (through June 21). At the top of every hour, a recording of the Estonian choir Vox Clamantis singing a haunting song a cappella, inspired by the composer Arvo Pärt, plays throughout the park. Listening to eerie harmonies while watching ships sail past is, for this New Yorker, worth the tram ride.

2. I'm lightly ignoring most two-hundred-and-fiftieth anniversary revelries, but I'll make an exception for the Museum of the Moving Image's new series "[By the People, for the People](#)" (through July 5), which highlights American films that focus on marginalized communities. I'm particularly excited about "Salt of the Earth" (July 5), a radical drama about a mining strike in small-town New Mexico.

3. Nothing screams summer like a big, boisterous, campy musical. And a fresh Encores! revival of “[**La Cage aux Folles**](#)” (City Center; June 17-28), with an all-Black cast fronted by Billy Porter and Wayne Brady, will be just that.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Weather as a Rothko](#)
- [A new bombshell has entered the ocean](#)
- [In other tiny news](#)

An earlier version of this article incorrectly suggested that Arvo Pärt had died.

The Food Scene

All That Glimmers at Ambassadors Clubhouse

Theatricality goes only so far at the ambitious new restaurant from the group behind London's Gymkhana.

By Helen Rosner

May 31, 2026



There is perhaps no restaurant in New York City right now more comprehensively opulent than Ambassadors Clubhouse, the ultra-luxurious Punjabi spot that occupies the ground and subterranean floors of the film company [A24](#)'s NoMad headquarters. The original restaurant, which was opened in Mayfair, in 2024, by the siblings Jyotin, Karam, and Sunaina Sethi, was declared “a maximalist sanctuary” by the *Standard*. It was a return to big swings and mega-production by the Sethi's J.K.S. group, which operates some thirty-five venues internationally, including their crown jewel, Gymkhana, the first Indian restaurant in London to hold two Michelin stars. The New York opening of Ambassadors Clubhouse—talk about your big swings and your mega-productions—is the group's third play in its ongoing,

multipronged bid for America: an outpost of Gymkhana opened last year, at the Aria hotel in Las Vegas, and a line of shelf-stable Gymkhana-branded sauces recently appeared on Whole Foods shelves nationwide. Ambassadors Clubhouse, with its extravagance and its storytelling, seems to be where the ambition lives.

The inspiration is the party mansions of northern India's Punjab region, and more specifically the summer house of the Sethis' grandfather: an ambassador, *the* ambassador, the restaurant's namesake and patron saint. His portrait, stern and majestic, hangs broodingly over the stairs; elsewhere on the walls, the art ranges from the Baroque to the bro-tinged, with turbaned figures sharing space with Ryu from Street Fighter. The effect is dizzying, and certainly immersive: part colonialism reclaimed, part very good joke; a little bit garden party, a little bit sex party. Since its opening, a few months ago, the restaurant has been nearly impossible to book, though if you're particularly lucky, and you nail the timing, you might be able to get a walk-in seat in the bar area. It's at street level and, while still atmospheric as hell, slightly less dripping in ambience than the subterranean dining room. Downstairs is the sanctum: a dark-walled room of such operatic elaborateness—tiger-print curtains, Lincrusta ceilings, Tiffany chandeliers, paisley carpeting in profusion—that the eye struggles to alight. The governing logic is spectacle: the room, the menu, the entire experience.



The menu is vast, and somewhat conceptual—dishes are divided, at times, by type (a section for *papads* and chaat), but then also by size (“bitings,” or finger foods), or by cooking method (baked in the tandoor, grilled over charcoal, crisped up in cast-iron tawa skillets, and so on)—and the food is specifically, celebratorily Punjabi. This restaurant, like so many recent high-profile openings, is part of the genuinely thrilling wave of South Asian restaurants arguing for regional precision, pushing back against decades of commodity Indian cuisine, the culture- and geography-flattening tikka masalas and garlic naans. Still, it was primarily immigrants from Punjab, and the restaurants they opened in neighborhoods like the East Village, or Richmond Hill, in Queens, who set the standard for what are now New York City’s Indian-restaurant clichés. The result is that much of the menu at Ambassadors Clubhouse is familiar in description, if not always in execution. The restaurant is particularly proud of its tandoor, a coal-burning oven that is, it turns out, the only one of its kind in the city (most tandoors ’round these parts run on gas). The oven lends an exquisite depth to everything that passes through it—a roundness and tang, a kiss of smolder. It’s there in the tiles of paneer, house-made from buffalo milk and springy-soft, bathed in a tomato-and-cashew sauce. It chars the shells of prawns, slightly husky with the scent of carom seeds and so spectacularly massive that, as they were set on the table, I briefly, disorientingly thought they were boneless chicken breasts.

The kitchen extends the room’s theatricality to the plate: each dish, almost without exception, is presented as an event. A tangy *kachori* chaat, bright with beetroot yogurt, arrives inside a semolina puffball the size of a regulation slow-pitch softball, which cracks open at the lightest spoon whack; a deftly spiced *paan patta* chaat with fried betel leaves and tender black chickpeas is piled high as a haystack and glimmers with sauces. Even the breads—various naans and rotis, a flaky whole-wheat *lachcha* paratha—are gorgeous, chewy and yeasty, many of them slick with clarified butter, presented, almost sculpturally, in oval baskets. A “seafood tower” involves seafood, and is certainly a tower, but, unlike the chilled-shellfish subtlety of the American steak-house staple, here it’s more of a vertical sampler of dramatic, snacky appetizers: shrimp kofta pressed around soft-boiled quail eggs; a crab-and-egg scramble folded in a savory lentil pancake; gently cooked scallops served in their shells, under herbaceous lashings of parsnip chutney. None of your standard-issue tetrahedral samosas here: they’ve been

reimagined as “seven layered” things—the layers are wings of crisp pastry, which radiate out from a pocket of spiced aloo-and-pea filling like sunbeams, or the ruffled pages of a book.



But the samosa, for all its beauty, didn't quite land for me as a samosa: it was so much wrapper, just a little dribble of filling. Nearly every dish was nice, and quite a few were wonderful, but it felt weighty—in a moral-of-the-story sort of way—to realize that the most marvellous, by a mile, was the relatively humble black-lentil dal, which simmers for hours with aromatics and is finished with oodles of butter and cream. It arrives in an unadorned bowl, ungarnished, without flourish or fanfare. Gold leaf appears often: a square of it floats atop the exquisite sauce of a veal-cheek korma, it gilds the whole-cooked lobster, it speckles the surface of the postprandial masala chai. And yet, the lighting in the room is so warm, the air itself so aureate, that the gold nearly vanishes into it—I only noticed the garnish, really, when reviewing my photographs afterward, my iPhone camera's automatic color correction revealing all the luxury that the room swallowed whole.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

At one point, I asked a server about Patiala Chicken Pakode, a dish listed under “Bitings” and described as arriving with something called Punjabi ranch. His face brightened; this, he confided, leaning in, was one of the most underrated, most slept-on items of the entire menu, and he only wished more people would order it. What arrived was chicken nuggets with ranch dressing. Delicious, to be sure—the buckwheat-flour breading was complex and savory, and beautifully spiced; there was a bright chutney on the side, and a vivid-red *tadka* chili oil—but boneless bites of fried chicken with a dipping cup of ranch can really only ever be one thing. Spectacle, in the end, is both an invitation and a sort of armor. Our server had steered us, from the start, toward the reassuring and the familiar: butter-chicken “chops,” legs partially deboned and dramatically presented in a mild cashew cream sauce; a basket of garlic naan. Neither was anything less than good. But in a moment when New York’s South Asian restaurant scene has never been more interesting or more varied—including, but in no way limited to, Semma, by now practically old guard, or the newer Musaafer, recently arrived by way of Houston, which makes a comparably enormous investment in design—Ambassadors Clubhouse, which has staked its identity on the grandeur of regional conviction, seemed to guide me persistently toward its most generic gestures. Was our server having us on, with the chicken pakode? Was I, so fixated on ordering both correctly and adventurously, just not thinking critically? The fault, I suspect, belongs to all of us. ♦

The Talk of the Town

- [Why Todd Blanche Should Not Be Attorney General](#)
- [ICE's8ee7d6d7acd163c3c0e369c2b0ccb294.html">On the Front Lines of Delaney Hall, ICE's Newark Prison](#)
- [Melanie Hamrick Is Still On Pointe](#)
- [Jackie Gleason's Paranormal Activity](#)
- [Beyond Banners](#)

Comment

Why Todd Blanche Should Not Be Attorney General

In a Senate that took its constitutional role seriously, Blanche would not win confirmation a second time.

By Ruth Marcus

June 14, 2026



Shortly before midnight on April 27th, two days after a gunman disrupted the White House Correspondents' dinner, the acting Attorney General, Todd Blanche, submitted an extraordinary petition to a federal court that had blocked the construction of the White House ballroom. Despite the late-night filing in the case, which had been brought by the National Trust for Historic Preservation, there was no actual emergency; rather, the Department of Justice seized on the moment to make its case that security required the construction to proceed. Attorneys General do not ordinarily put their names on such filings, as Blanche had. But more astonishing was the language of the document: the United States speaking in the unmistakable voice of Donald Trump.

The motion began mid-rant: “ ‘The National Trust for Historic Preservation’ is a beautiful name, but even their name is FAKE.” It said that those seeking to stop the ballroom “suffer from Trump Derangement Syndrome” and “are represented by the lawyer for Barack Hussein Obama, Gregory Craig.” Then it shifted to praising Trump’s brilliance—“a highly successful real estate developer, who has abilities that others don’t”—and to arguing that the ballroom was “being given FREE OF CHARGE AS A GIFT TO THE COUNTRY!” This claim was dubious; the President has unsuccessfully sought a billion dollars in government funding. Yet it was also unfiltered Trump, a Truth Social post in the guise of a legal document, and it was met with predictable failure. But although the document was submitted to Richard Leon, the U.S. district judge who had issued the injunction, Blanche was targeting a different audience of one.

In Trump’s Washington, subservience works. Last Monday, the President formally nominated Blanche to be the nation’s eighty-eighth Attorney General. Blanche, who had represented Trump in his criminal trials and was confirmed as Deputy Attorney General last March, has served in an acting capacity for more than eight weeks, since [Pam Bondi](#) was fired. He professed equanimity about getting the job permanently, announcing that, if Trump “chooses to nominate somebody else and asks me to go do something else, I will say, ‘Thank you very much. I love you, sir.’ ” But Blanche used the intervening weeks to engage in what has looked like a manic spree of auditioning for the top job.

Blanche has touted one flimsy indictment (of the former F.B.I. director [James Comey](#), for posting on social media a photo of “86 47,” written in seashells) after another (criminal charges against the Southern Poverty Law Center, for allegedly defrauding its donors). He ramped up a seemingly stalled criminal investigation into the former C.I.A. director John Brennan, enlisting Joseph diGenova, who had represented the Trump campaign in challenging the 2020 election results, to lead it. And he presided over the creation of a nearly \$1.8-billion “anti-weaponization” slush fund, supposedly to settle the Trump family’s lawsuit against the I.R.S., for a private contractor’s leak of tax records. This looting of the Treasury has apparently been averted, following a rare revolt by Republican lawmakers. But, for the Trumps, the most valuable benefit of the deal remains—a Blanche-signed addendum stating that the federal government is

“FOREVER BARRED and PRECLUDED” from pursuing an I.R.S. audit that, according to the *Times*, could have cost the family some hundred million dollars. (Asked about Blanche’s tenure, a Justice Department spokeswoman offered a list of “key accomplishments,” including a decrease in the national murder rate, the arrest of numerous alleged cartel members, the filing of multiple fraud cases, and the hiring of additional immigration judges.)

The Senate vote on Blanche’s nomination to be Deputy Attorney General last year was 52–46, along party lines. But that was when his background offered the hope that he would stand up for the norms of Justice Department independence. He had been a registered Democrat until 2023, the *Times* reported, and had worked for years as a prosecutor in the Southern District of New York, the flagship U.S. Attorney’s office. He was, former colleagues have said, no superstar, but he was reasonably well regarded and even better liked. The optimism that Blanche would be a moderating force, though, seems to have underestimated the corrupting power of ambition. News reports suggest that Blanche has at times urged restraint; if so, his successes appear to have been few, if any. He tolerated the firing of a respected prosecutor, Maurene Comey, for no other reason than her last name. In March, at the Conservative Political Action Conference—not normally a venue for a Justice Department official—he boasted of the wholesale ouster of F.B.I. agents who had worked on Trump prosecutions, saying, “There isn’t a single man or woman with a gun, federal agent, still in that organization that had anything to do with the prosecution of President Trump.”

Last month, a federal judge in Tennessee, citing “Blanche’s vindictive motive,” ordered dismissal of the indictment of [Kilmar Abrego Garcia](#), whom the Justice Department had prosecuted after it removed him to El Salvador, his home country, in violation of a court order, and was forced to return him to the U.S. This month, in a podcast interview with Sean Hannity, Blanche not only discussed ongoing grand-jury investigations into a supposed “grand conspiracy” among government officials to go after Trump but played along as Hannity named potential targets, from James Comey and John Brennan to the former director of National Intelligence James Clapper and President Joe Biden. “All those folks were certainly part of it,” Blanche said. This is the antithesis of how prosecutors are instructed to behave. On

Wednesday, the conservative *National Review* came out against his nomination. “Todd Blanche has been everything President Trump wants in an attorney general, and that’s the problem,” the editors wrote.

A year ago, senators uncomfortable with the idea of Trump’s criminal-defense lawyer becoming the department’s No. 2 could point to Blanche’s testimony before the Judiciary Committee, where he said that “political prosecutions should never happen, period” and that, if pressed to bring a bogus case, “I will follow the law.” Now they have a record against which to judge those assurances. Will any of this matter to Republican senators—perhaps to members of the growing “wounded-bear caucus,” who have been the targets of Trump’s fury? A no vote from a single Republican on the committee could block the nomination. On the floor, just four Republican no votes could doom it. In a Senate that took its constitutional role seriously, Blanche would not win confirmation a second time. But, as John Thune, the Majority Leader, observed, “obviously most of our members are pretty deferential to who the President wants.” Like the nominee it will consider, this Senate is more inclined to consent to Trump than to advise him. ♦

Newark Dispatch

On the Front Lines of Delaney Hall, *ICE's* Newark Prison

The detention center was the first new facility to open under the second Trump Administration. Protesters won't stop until it is shut down.

By Ian Frazier June 15, 2026



Delaney Hall, a thousand-bed privately owned *ICE* prison in Newark, is in the city's industrial lowlands. Its address, 451 Doremus Avenue, makes it seem like an entity with physical limits, but that's not how it looks to passersby, unless they are in the air, taking off from or landing at Newark Airport. Delaney Hall occupies tens of thousands of square feet enclosed in chain-link fencing that bulges outward like the front end of a whale, if you can imagine a whale also crisscrossed with razor wire. To a person at ground level, Delaney Hall seems to go on forever.

Trucks travelling between the Port of Elizabeth and Interstate 95 use Doremus Avenue. They are forced to kind of creep along, because it has so many speed bumps. As they creep, they shift gears and rev engines, sometimes at a complete standstill. You can see the logos from the curb—J. B. Hunt Intermodal, Costco Shipping, Tiamar Transport, Penn's Best, Evergreen, Owens Truckmen, Hapag-Lloyd, Maersk Line, Bold Disposal, Hamburg Süd, China Shipping, and more.

When the trucks pass the crowd that is protesting the treatment of the detainees the facility now holds (it is the largest *ICE* prison on the East Coast), some of the drivers honk in support. The horns are incredibly loud. Now and then, a driver will blast his horn for what seems like minutes. Amid the protesters facing off with the *ICE* agents, the volunteers there to help the detainees, the banks of media cameras on tripods, the planes and helicopters overhead, the pipelines, train tracks, telephone poles, and the vast bulk of the prison itself, a long blast from a truck sounds satisfying and right.

On a recent Sunday, some of the volunteers and protesters came from churches or synagogues in the metro area. A parishioner at St. John's Episcopal Church, in Montclair, New Jersey, was there and met congregants from Temple Ner Tamid, in Bloomfield, some of whom were distributing clothing to would-be prison visitors who had been turned away because they had on tank tops, open-toed shoes, hoodies bearing banned slogans, etc. A young woman named Gabriela Soto was waiting to be admitted to see her husband. She feared he would be transferred to another prison to retaliate against her for speaking out. As she stood in the crowd, her phone rang. She answered it, then cried, "They're releasing him!" She grabbed Sally Pillay, one of the volunteers, and showed her the caller I.D., which read "Delaney

Hall.” Pillay, wearing black clothing and hot-pink shoes, ran with Soto to the visitors’ gate. A delay followed. Soto became upset. “You gotta be optimistic,” the man at the gate told her. Finally, he admitted Soto and Pillay, who disappeared into a long stretch of barbed wire. But, despite their efforts, Soto emerged without her husband, who was, indeed, transferred soon afterward.

Bad feeling from this development carried over to the next day, when more protesters showed up. Andy Kim, one of New Jersey’s U.S. senators, came to inspect the facility, as federal officials are entitled to do. *ICE* shot pepper balls at the protesters, and Senator Kim was hit in the face by the spray.

On Tuesday, the St. John’s parishioner returned. Now even more protesters, some in kaffiyehs, squared off with *ICE*. The truck traffic had intensified, too. Over and over, horns blew in support, or maybe also in rage. Hundreds of detainees were on a hunger strike, asking for unspoiled food, medical care, and an end to punitive transfers, among other demands. Their first written statement began by apologizing for their having entered the country illegally.

Protesters blocked white *ICE* vans as they tried to come and go. One van was stopped, lights flashing and siren blaring, as protesters surrounded it. The *ICE* guys near the gate were joined by more agents from inside the prison. They wore masks, helmets, multi-pocketed vests, and boots or running shoes. In about seven minutes, with pushing, shoving, and cursing, the agents cleared a path for the van.

Doremus Avenue and the warehouses and tank farms and truck lots and junk yards along it are not far from the Passaic River. This is swampy Jersey, as opposed to hilly Jersey. Next to the prison visitors’ parking lot, a small catchment pond holds runoff. The lawn around the pond had been mowed without anybody picking up the trash beforehand. Two Canada geese and six gangly brown-suède goslings walked among the refuse, while in the near distance the truck horns and the protesters’ chants rose up. The geese had been there off and on for days. ♦

Only Rock and Roll

Melanie Hamrick Is Still On Pointe

Since retiring from the American Ballet Theatre, the dancer has expanded her pursuits—writing romance books and choreographing shows with the help of her fiancé, Mick Jagger.

By Bob Morris

June 15, 2026

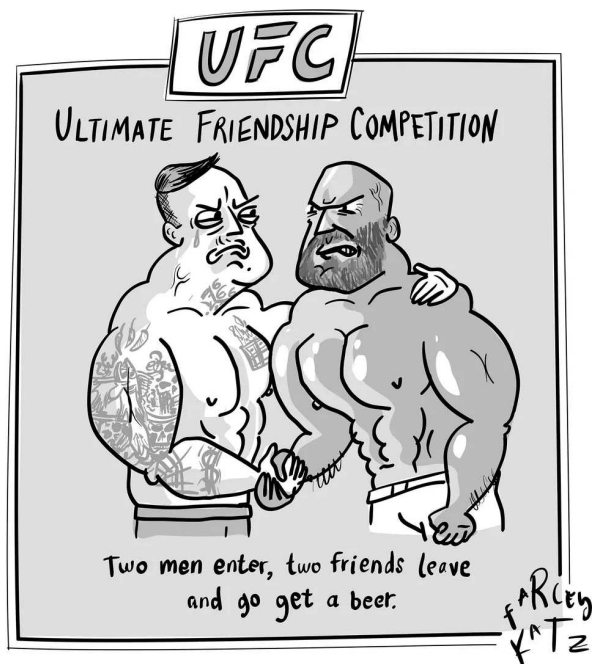


Melanie Hamrick, a former member of American Ballet Theatre's corps de ballet, was leaping down a dingy stairwell in the company's lower-Broadway rehearsal building recently. It was habit. "When you only have a five-minute break from class, you learn to take the stairs and not wait for the elevator," she said. She had just finished rehearsing two A.B.T. principal dancers in "Rainbow," a pas de deux that she choreographed to a 1967 Rolling Stones song written by Keith Richards and Mick Jagger, who has been her romantic partner since 2014.

An AMC multiplex has been next door since Hamrick moved to the city, from Virginia, more than twenty years ago, as a seventeen-year-old, to join A.B.T.'s junior company. Looking up at the cinema now, she thought of

Timothée Chalamet's notorious quip that nobody cares about ballet or opera. "That comment gave ballet a lot of publicity," she said. Hamrick, who was wearing a pair of mannish trousers with a vest and has a mild millennial vocal fry, left A.B.T. in 2019, three years after having a son with Jagger. The two met while touring in Japan. "We're both performers, so we understood each other's lives," she said. A few years ago, they got engaged.

Since retiring from the stage, Hamrick has been busy. She works as a choreographer, runs a ballet-event production company, has published two steamy ballet romance novels, and is executive-producing a film adaptation of one. "It can be overwhelming when you finish, and a lot of dancers lose themselves," she said, weaving through sidewalk crowds and holding a coffee. "I went to the Philharmonic and opera a lot." She also had a son to raise and an image to manage. "I have to keep a social-media presence, but I don't want to put too much of *us* in," she said, referring to her family. Her Instagram shows mostly Hamrick herself, with an occasional shot of her eighty-two-year-old baby daddy and their towheaded nine-year-old, whose set of lips resembles his father's.



"As a kid, I knew 'You Can't Always Get What You Want,'" Hamrick said. But she mostly listened to classical music, "and maybe a little Eminem and Papa Roach." Her parents, an engineer and a health-care worker, often took

her to the Kennedy Center. She met Jagger backstage at a Rolling Stones show. “It was the first rock concert I ever attended,” she said. To bone up, she’d listened to his songs on Apple Music and found them “interesting.” She initially choreographed “Rainbow” as part of a longer work set to Stones songs—the band’s catalogue is valued at half a billion dollars—for a 2019 première at the Mariinsky Theatre, in Russia. Jagger helped edit the music.

When “Rainbow” was performed at Lincoln Center’s David H. Koch Theatre the following night, it went off well, danced by A.B.T.’s Calvin Royal III and Christine Shevchenko, who used to share a dressing room with Hamrick. The occasion was Youth America Grand Prix’s Stars of Today Meet the Stars of Tomorrow Gala, and Hamrick was one of the evening’s honorees. The organization, which is known as the “American Idol” of ballet, distributes scholarships and jobs to worthy students.

“I see a lot of people here tonight that look like they care about ballet—right, Mr. Chalamet?” the dancer Misty Copeland said from the podium, as she gave some introductory remarks. During the dinner that followed, out in the theatre’s sparkling lobby, Hamrick made a thank-you speech from the second-ring balcony, Eva Perón style. Wearing a plunging black gown with peekaboo cutouts that she said was *not* by Tom Ford (though it looked like it was), she extolled the organization and its founder, Larissa Saveliev, who defected from the Bolshoi in 1993. Hamrick’s fiancé, who had seen the ballet already, wasn’t in attendance, but his son (and seventh child) Lucas Jagger, who is twenty-seven, was at her side. He wore silver nail polish, fingerless black gloves, and red glasses, and his hair was as unruly as Hamrick’s was sleek. He noted that it was a good night for ballet, and when the Chalamet remark was mentioned he rolled his eyes: “It would be like me saying nobody cares about rock and roll anymore.” ♦

Jackie Gleason's Paranormal Activity

The “Honeymooners” actor was obsessed with the supernatural—even his house looked like a spacecraft. On a tour of the Mothership, will the author of a new Gleason book come face to face with the extraterrestrial?

By Bruce Handy

June 15, 2026



Here is one thing you probably know about Jackie Gleason, the famously “rotund comedian,” to use an old *Times* description: he was the star and guiding force of “The Honeymooners,” the nineteen-fifties sitcom (and “Flintstones” template) that was spun off from a variety show he headlined in various incarnations from the early fifties into the seventies. Depending on your age, you may also have seen him as Minnesota Fats in the film “The Hustler.”

Here are two things you probably don't know about Gleason: One, he was an avid reader with a lifelong interest in E.S.P., telekinesis, astral projection, clairvoyance, flying saucers—the supernatural works—and amassed a library of some three thousand volumes on these concerns. Two, in the late

fifties, at the height of his fame, he built an extravagant circular house made of wood, marble, and glass which he variously called the Round House, the Round Rock, and the Mothership. The modernist home commands a woodsy eight and a half acres in Cortlandt Manor, a Westchester hamlet, and was more recently dubbed “Jackie Gleason’s UFO-inspired party pad” by a luxury life-style website when the property was listed for sale last summer. (Asking price: \$5.5 million. Listing lede: “Off-the-Charts Cool Cool Cool.”)

Gleason lived in the Round House for only a few years, tiring of it quickly and then fobbing it off on his network, CBS, when he relocated his variety show to Miami Beach, in 1964. His widow donated his library to the University of Miami following his death, in 1987. But, on a recent morning, spooky books and saucerlike home were reunited, after a fashion, when Andrew Lampert, the author of a new book titled “Jackie Gleason: Library of the Paranormal,” stood in front of the Round House. Despite the property’s numerous “*NO TRESPASSING*” signs, the owner was willing to give him a tour.

Lampert’s book is part of a series of monographs that he and a partner, Christine Burgin, publish, devoted to, in his words, “idiosyncratic people” and “niche corners.” “Library of the Paranormal” reproduces several dozen covers from Gleason’s collection, most put out by obscure presses and graced with charmingly awful illustrations. Among the titles: “Is Your Cosmic Radio Working?” and “How to Contact Space People.” Lampert, a cheerful fortysomething with a hipster-dad mien, admitted that his interest in Gleason’s interest was maybe “bizarre” but definitely not “flippant.”

Akie Topal, the homeowner, wore a striped Breton shirt and rolled-up jeans, with an apron tied around her waist. She was accompanied by Heidi Henshaw, her real-estate agent. Greeting Lampert, Topal said, “The architecture here was inspired by the four elements of Gleason’s life—superstition, music, pool, and drinking.”

The entry area was a combination sitting room, library, and command center, with custom-made fixtures: chairs, bookcases, lighting, speakers, and cabinets full of switches, including one labelled “snow melter” and two dimmer knobs the size of salad plates. “Wow,” Lampert said, as Topal twisted a knob. “Those are the best rheostats I’ve ever seen.”

“You will see more switches downstairs,” Topal promised.

“You feel like you’re in a spaceship,” Henshaw said approvingly. That was true: the room looked like the bridge of the U.S.S. Enterprise, if it had been finished in fine, burnished woods. Nearly every surface and appliance was curvilinear, hinting at Gaudí and also at swanky mid-century hotels and restaurants. The architect was Robert Cika, a disciple of a disciple of Frank Lloyd Wright.

Topal explained that her late husband, Ronald Topal, a Manhattan orthodontist, bought the showplace home in 1976. Was he a big Gleason fan? “No,” she said. “He just fell in love with the house.” He kept it largely as he found it. In 1990, Topal moved in, but she’d had a prior relationship with the comedian: she grew up in Osaka, and when she moved to the United States, in 1984, she said, “I learned my English watching ‘I Love Lucy,’ ‘The Honeymooners,’ and those four older ladies living together.” (“The Golden Girls.”)

Topal took Lampert into Gleason’s office, where an organ was built into a wall. There was a drawer with a small jukebox inside and another that once stored a bar and now held batteries. The primary bedroom contained a round bed and a cabinet mounted on the ceiling for a TV set. There were drawers containing another jukebox and another bar.

“How many bars are there total?” Lampert asked.

“Five,” Topal answered, after counting them on her fingers.

“And how many bathrooms?”

“Two and a half.”

Lampert laughed. “The math works.”

The tour descended down a vertiginous circular staircase to the ground floor, which featured a marble dance floor, three marble fireplaces, an indoor koi pond (empty), a game room, and two large bars set within fourteen paces of each other, give or take.

With essentially no right angles or corners—which are thought by some, possibly including Gleason, to attract evil spirits—the architecture had a pleasantly disorienting quality. “Like music, it just flows and flows,” Topal said. “But when everyone comes here they get lost. When they try to leave, they go the wrong way.”

Lampert tried to put himself in Gleason’s shoes. “Navigating this house inebriated—that would be a challenge,” he said. “But that’s why they called him the Great One.” ♦

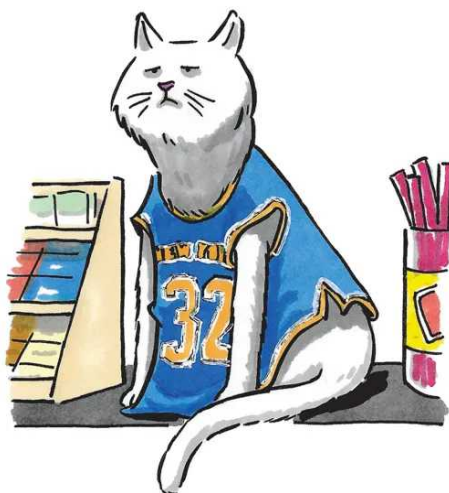
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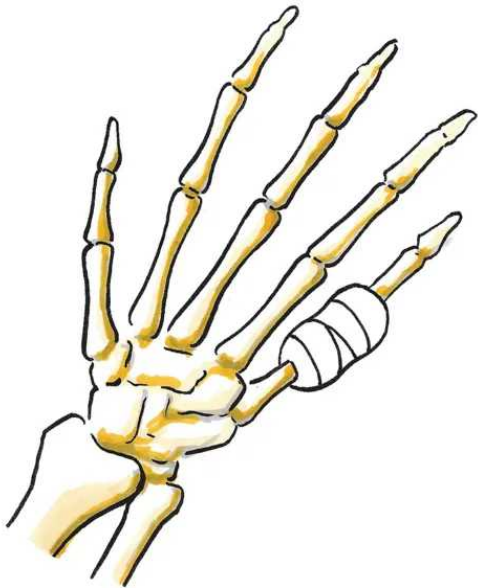
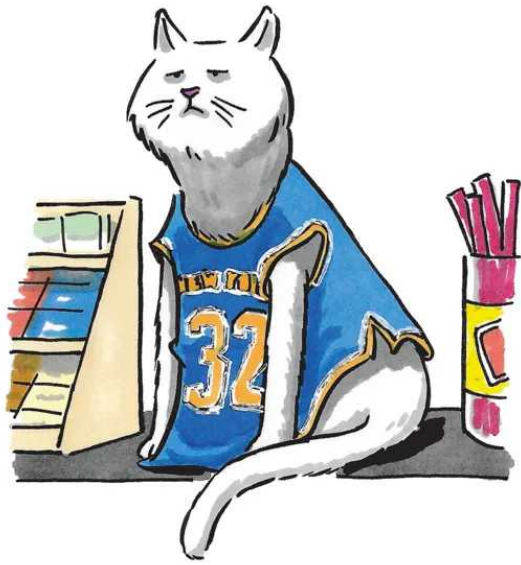
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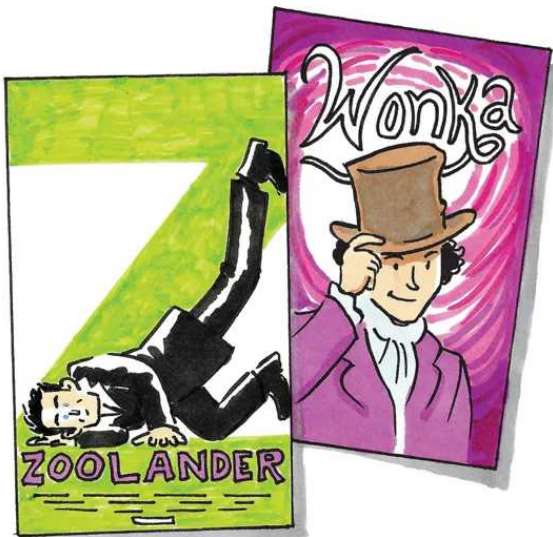
A few things to add to the M.S.G. rafters to commemorate the 2026 N.B.A. Finals.

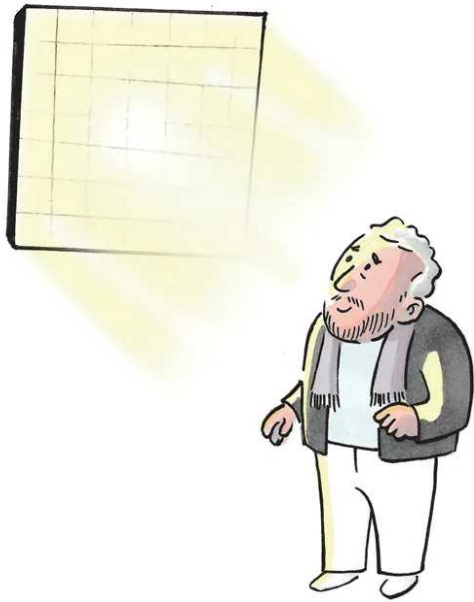
By Benjamin Schwartz

June 15, 2026









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Misery Loves Company—If There Are Snacks

Do “Admin Nights” make people more productive or less lonely?

By Patricia Marx

June 15, 2026



“Bring your laptop and all the boring tasks you’ve been avoiding. Cancel subscriptions, book appointments, clear your inbox, sort bills. Way less painful when you’re not doing it alone.”

The invitation, posted on Meetup, was intriguing, though not entirely persuasive—it felt like being invited to a get-together to floss your teeth. The event was held on a chilly Sunday, from 2 to 7 *P.M.*, in Dumbo, Brooklyn. I came with my to-do list (abridged, annotated, and redacted):

1. e-mail SS, SP, KK, JD, R
2. notarize comptroller form

3. return spray bottle buy other spray bottle
4. Lithgow tix
5. unsubscribe [REDACTED]'s Substack
6. memorize S Amer [*project to memorize world map, one continent at a time; not yet begun*]
7. smell yogurt
8. tell [REDACTED] not to tell [REDACTED] about [REDACTED]
9. smoke detector!
10. turn off airplane mode
11. consolidate to-do lists
12. I prefer UPS less salty [*don't know what this means*]
13. write will [*on list for eighteen years; maybe it's keeping me alive*]
14. write to-do piece!

Each of us has about a hundred and fifty tasks to deal with on any given day. So say the psychologist Roy F. Baumeister and the journalist John Tierney, who have co-written a book titled “Willpower: Rediscovering the Greatest Human Strength.” But not all hundred and fifty make it onto our to-do lists, Tierney—whose to-do list includes a yearly reminder to celebrate Pi Day—told me in an e-mail.

Lists promise containment. Thank God for *Smithsonian* magazine’s “Five Volcanoes to Watch” list—just when you were overwhelmed from worrying about all the volcanoes you needed to monitor. In a 2008 survey by the market-research company Kelton Global, seventy-three per cent of Americans said that they found keeping a to-do list “calming.” O.K., but is it an effective way to get things done or merely a storage unit of guilt? Consider these numbers from the productivity company iDoneThis: forty-

one per cent of items on to-do lists are never crossed off, and only fifteen per cent of completed tasks were ever on a to-do list.

Yes, you could hire an assistant to assist you, but then you'd have a hundred and fifty-one tasks. You could also leave the unwashed dishes stacked in the sink, let the bank foreclose on your house, and tell the dog to walk itself. Or you could do what a growing number of people are doing these days, especially, it seems, Gen Z-ers and millennials: meet up with other chore-beleaguered types as you each grapple with your respective to-do list. Misery loves company—if there are snacks.

These gatherings, like the one in Dumbo, are commonly called Admin Nights, a term coined, in 2019, by the journalist Chris Colin, who began hosting such events for his friends at his house in San Francisco. “We were all lonesome and all overwhelmed, and I saw a connection,” Colin told me. “I realized there’s this new category of busyness. Not work busyness, not domestic-life busyness, but this third thing. This busyness is so dumb and banal that we don’t really talk about it. It’s the way you’ve been meaning to reconnect your Bluetooth speakers for two months, but you can’t figure that out till you conquer higher-tier items—bank stuff, doctor stuff, phone stuff, car stuff, school stuff, D.M.V. stuff, other stuff—and those require insane hold times, or eye-stabbing chatbot conversations. I felt that if we could tackle this deranged administrative sprawl together, we would hang out more.” (If you have time to read this, you probably don’t need an Admin Night.) Colin also had a political agenda. “I wanted to shine my light on what’s happening—that life has become unsustainable,” he said, “and have people talk about why this is happening and who profits.”

In the past few years, Admin Nights have been proliferating, sometimes christened with new names that try to jazz up drudgery: Get Shit Done Days, Motivation Madness, and Death, Documents, & Donuts. (Purpose of that one: getting one’s “affairs in order.”)

Are these Admin Night-like gatherings as productive as attendees claim? (“I answered my aunt’s text I’d been avoiding for weeks!” “I created a list of ‘Valentine’s Day Gifts Your Boyfriend Would Get You If He Hates You’ for my TikTok feed and wrote a screenplay!” “I filled out Form 86B!”) To find out, I sampled a bunch.

Ten millennial moms sat around the kitchen island of a town house in Carroll Gardens, eating crudités, nachos, and popcorn. They'd brought their chores: medical bills to be paid, shopping lists (one woman's son had just told her he was supposed to wear a purple shirt to school), and children's birthday parties to be planned, including one for a six-year-old girl who'd requested that the theme be a combination of rock climbing and American Girl dolls. One woman intended to use the time to order electrolytes online, another was seeking earring backs, and a third needed to find a male babysitter, as well as a summer swim program, for a four-and-a-half-year-old who is afraid of the water. (What luck! Someone had a lead on a nanny.) There was discussion about the price of helium-filled party balloons (four-fifty each). Only one man was present. He'd come with his wife on a fact-checking mission: "The idea of a party where you'd actually bring health-care forms sounded so absurd. I thought she was joking." The night was organized by Laura Cunningham, a co-founder of a startup called Ava, a name that focus groups found evoked "happy, useful emotions." Ava's mission, Cunningham said, is to "tackle the mental load of motherhood." Besides sponsoring free "community building" events such as this Family Admin Party, the group was developing an A.I.-enabled app that will fill out forms, schedule medical appointments, and handle other administrivia that we'd rather avoid. For many of the attendees, the ninety minutes in Carroll Gardens was also a rare opportunity to see friends. "It's so hard to schedule a social dinner, but this doesn't seem frivolous," one woman with perfect teeth said. "I can justify it. While I'm being productive, I can have wine and decompress." She divided her admin time between finding female-founded ventures to invest in and looking for programs to enroll her kids in "during the one-day school break that comes annoyingly a week before the long school break."

The Brooklyn evening was raucous compared with the San Francisco Community Nights' Zoom session I attended next, which was like the quiet car of Admin Nights. For most of the online session, Geo Morjane, a director at the software company Kaseya, and a woman named Natasha sat in companionable silence in their Zoom squares, parallel-playing like an old married couple, as I scribbled notes. Natasha spent the two hours trying to switch her QuickBooks account from annual to monthly billing, while Morjane worked on his taxes and edited a podcast. Toward the end of the evening, they compared tax-filing systems and discussed C.S.V. files—text-

based files with comma-separated values. (Do you want to know more? I thought so.) When I asked Natasha if I could schedule an interview with her to talk about why she liked the concept of Admin Nights, she declined, saying, “I came here to get things done, not to add things to my to-do list.” I might as well have brought a boom box to a Quaker meeting.

If a study hall had a soundtrack, it would be Focus Lab. At this co-working session, held in the back lounge of FourFiveSix, a groovy Williamsburg restaurant that could be the set of a Brooklyn-based sitcom, Akshay Bhasin blended synthesizers and ambient noise to create live music. Attendees could listen to these “sound journeys” (his term) through headphones, available free of charge to anyone who signed up. (Sessions have a sliding-scale cost of around fifteen dollars.) Periodically, Bhasin interrupted the sounds of birds, rain, and jungle life to offer encouraging words to his audience—a small group, nestled on mismatched sofas and chairs, and a couple who’d wandered in for some soup. “Maybe let’s just do a quick little check-in with ourselves,” he murmured after thirty minutes. “Are we still working on what we want to be working on?” Rachel Lee, a twenty-six-year-old community organizer and artist, was working on job applications, a task that was higher up on her to-do list than drawing the family dog for a poster that her mother plans to hang in the family bathroom. (Caption: “Welcome to the bathroom. A dog will be with you shortly.”) Daniel Gomez-Seidel, a thirty-eight-year-old self-described freelance “post-disciplinary strategist” who keeps bilingual to-do lists, was preparing material for a media aggregator that he is creating aimed at the Latin American diaspora. He has not missed one of the four Focus Labs held to date. “Knowing my friend Julia’s over there gives me the serotonin of belonging without us having to interact,” he told me.

Before there were Admin Nights, there was body doubling, a productivity technique that keeps you focussed and motivated by having another person close at hand. The term was coined in 1996 by Linda Anderson, an A.D.H.D. coach, and inspired by the experience of one of her clients. In an article Anderson wrote at the time, she said that the client had told her, “You know, it seems that, sometimes, if I just have my wife sitting in a chair nearby, I can accomplish more than if I’m alone.” The idea has caught on. One woman on a Reddit forum about A.D.H.D. said that she asks her work-

from-home husband to bring his laptop into whatever space she's organizing. Once, he fell asleep in a closet.

Why does body doubling work? Anderson offered a few explanations, among them: the body double functions as an "improved mirror" reflecting a less anxious version of the self; the distracted person may feel obligated not to waste the body double's time; and, borrowing from Eastern philosophy, the body double "contains the flux of energy and thought in the A.D.H.D. brain at risk of spilling out into the chaotic universe." Or take your pick from other theories: dopamine surge, the audience effect, polyvagal calm. Let's go with "they don't know," shall we?

Before there was body doubling, there were quilting bees, Trappist monasteries, and, presumably, colonoscopy-prep parties.

And, before there were those things, there was Leonardo da Vinci, who left behind notebooks full of notes to self: "Describe the tongue of a woodpecker"; "Calculate the measurement of Milan and suburbs"; "Get the master of arithmetic to show you how to square a triangle." Michelangelo's to-do lists, on the other hand, were really get-the-servant-to-do lists. And, because the servant could not read, the artist illustrated the lists. For instance, a grocery-shopping list consisted of a sketch of stewed fennel, four anchovies, and other must-haves.



At twenty, Benjamin Franklin set out on a “bold and arduous project of arriving at moral perfection,” striving to attain one virtue a week for thirteen weeks. He ultimately failed; humility was virtue No. 13 (“Imitate Jesus and Socrates”). A list that Thomas Edison made titled “Things Doing and to Be Done” totalled a hundred and eight items, among them “Ink for blind” and “Butter direct from milk.” One of John Lennon’s to-do lists included a desire to purchase “Swedish bran bread,” a request that his assistant “check my hair dryer for cancer,” a reminder about Yoko’s dentist appointment, and “shave your legs for the U.N. ‘Year of the Child.’”

Of the Admin Nights that I sat in on, here in 2026, the ones that felt least like excuses to hang out were the three at which most of the attendees were neurodivergent. All three were over Zoom, and all were tightly structured. Meredith Schultz has been captaining virtual “Body Doubling Sessions” every weekday morning, from eight to nine, for the past four years. “I do it because I need it,” Schultz told me, from Denver, explaining that although she’d been diagnosed with A.D.H.D. only a few years ago, her mother had figured it out early on. “If she sent me to my room to clean it, I’d make it worse,” Schultz recalled. “But, if she lay on my bed reading her trashy romance novels, I’d dutifully clean everything up.” Of her own Zoom sessions, she said, “I would never be in my chair at 8 *A.M.* if I didn’t have twenty-five people waiting for me.” (The Weight Watchers effect?)

One morning several weeks ago, I shared the gallery view with, among others, Janine, who wanted to use the session to request death certificates for her grandparents; Jeremy, who needed to research out-of-body experiences and eat lunch; and Charon, whose first task was to put on her socks so that she'd remember to put on her shoes so that her back wouldn't hurt.

"We're going to stay onscreen, on mute, in focussed attention together," Schultz said, with a smile that seemed permanent. "I will stop us midway through for that mandatory two-minute break, and we will meet up at the end." Schultz set a timer for twenty-five minutes. This kind of interval training for accomplishing whatever you're avoiding derives from the Pomodoro Technique, from the late nineteen-eighties, which was developed by Francesco Cirillo, a university student who named it after the red tomato-shaped kitchen timer he used. During the session, I set about doing my taxes, which required me to sit on the floor and sort my big jumble of papers into smaller jumbles of papers. When I returned to my computer, there was a stern note to me in the chat from Schultz: "Hi Patty! Staying on screen is part of the social contract! Message me when you're back :)"

Cameras were optional at the next two sessions I attended, the Procrastinatables Productivity Party, led by Tracey Young in Essex Junction, Vermont, and the Get Stuff Done Party, run by Christie Flora in Melbourne, Australia. But most participants chose to keep their cameras on. At both meetups, there was a preponderance of tidying—children's rooms, offices, spare rooms, digital photo libraries, inboxes. "People do tend to suddenly feel the urge to clean up their cat boxes when someone else is around," Young told me. But one man at Get Stuff Done devoted two hours to painting a miniature Warhammer action figure, not even stopping during the break. "Kyle's still got his head down working on his Warhammer piece. Looking good!" Flora said, as if she were an announcer at a sporting event.

Flora noted that, during a previous session, one woman had painted a room in her house. "Things aren't as scary as we think they will be," Flora told her group, reassuringly.

"Sometimes they are," an attendee named Terri replied. She'd been going through a backlog of e-mails.

The idea that people work better when other people are around is called social facilitation. As early as 1898, the American psychologist Norman Triplett observed that children working in pairs wound fishing reels faster than children working alone. If you'd rather ignore and be ignored by just one person, instead of by a group, the video-based platform Focusmate will match you with someone somewhere in the world so that the two of you can work together online on mute. (Three free sessions a week; after that, it's eight to twelve dollars a month.) Could it be that George Orwell was too gloomy about Big Brother?

"You know how people get that groove between their eyebrows when they're stressed out?" Young asked. "When the hour is over, you can see the relief on their faces. I call that the Botox of completion." The converse—that we remember and are tormented by unfinished tasks more than finished ones—is also true. It's called the Zeigarnik effect, first studied by the Soviet psychologist Bluma Zeigarnik in 1927, after her professor observed that waiters remembered the details of unpaid orders but forgot orders whose bills had been settled. One recent theory posits that uncompleted tasks live on in our short-term memory, where they linger and kvetch.

If you can't make a dent in your to-do list, it's not you, it's the list—or so say time-management experts. To-do lists, they argue, are too long and not prioritized, so you knock off the trivial tasks and leave behind the more important but complicated projects. What's the fix? (1) Break down formidable tasks into smaller, concrete steps. (Example: rather than putting "Invade Iran" on your to-do list, begin with the more feasible "Notify allies.") (2) Set a fixed time in your calendar to do a particular task ("1:00–1:10 P.M.: Learn Mandarin"). (3) Accomplish one big task, three medium tasks, and five little tasks each day ("The 1-3-5 Rule"). (4) Narrate your efforts as if you were on a cooking show. ("O.K., let's rinse the mug—excellent technique!")

"A lot of what's getting covered in the press are these large Admin Nights where adults pay bills, call credit-card companies, and sort out insurance," said Carolyn Lanford, then a senior at Columbia University who has since graduated and who, with a handful of her classmates, has been meeting monthly at bars or in dorm rooms for the past year, in order to "wrestle with the minutiae of being an almost adult." She typically uses the time to fill out

job applications, though something else always comes up. “Students nowadays are inundated with e-mails ranging from somebody offering you a five-per-cent student discount to contracts relating to your scholarship that ask you to promise you won’t get expelled,” she said.

On a Friday afternoon a few months ago, I audited one of Lanford’s meetups, at the Arts and Crafts Beer Parlor, near campus (plant-based comfort food, exposed brick, Wi-Fi password: tipthebartender). Also in attendance were two students, Liam Downey and Rocky Rub. This would not be an ordinary meetup because, besides sundry individual tasks, the three had important business to accomplish together—namely, chartering a day-boat cruise in Puerto Rico for spring break.

From my notes:

1. boat booked, helmed by Christian
2. reviews of Christian read aloud (Rub: “ ‘Christian is a local water enthusiast.’ ” Lanford: “Oh, my God, me, too!”)
3. debate: are sand dollars alive? (yes). does drinking while afloat increase drunkenness by 50%? (unclear)
4. individual projects: Lanford, paralegal job applications; Rub, edit piece he’s writing for the Blue and White Magazine; Downey, jury-duty summons.
5. someone calls credit-card company

My research taught me that there are two kinds of Admin Nights. One is rule-bound and monastic: timers, silence, being alone together. The other is convivial: music, snacks, an excuse to get out of the house. I attended another one in Brooklyn that was the convivial kind. It was arranged by Women in Games N.Y.C., a group of “female-identifying and femme” gaming-industry workers, and organized by Yiyi Zhang, a game developer and human-rights lawyer. Ten or so attendees in their twenties and thirties settled across sofas, while a lo-fi YouTube music video was projected on a large screen, which mostly seemed to display a kitten wearing headphones. A few worked solo; most mingled as they plugged away—the Montessori

approach to busywork. Why had they come? Hamna Faisal, the director of business management at Women in Games, told me, “I crave human connection, especially post-*COVID*, but I also need to get things done.” Alexandra Palocz, an adjunct professor of media technology at City Tech, said, “I think people feel a greater sense of existential dread now. It feels futile to order a phone case or make a big grocery list when Iran is being bombed and there’s an *ICE* presence in American cities. In a group like this, even if you don’t know anyone, you feel like you can keep moving forward.”

Zhang’s seven-year-old daughter, Kainen, was at the meetup. She told me, “I found out that grownups have homework, too, which is kind of funny.”

Progress Report:

~~Write to do piece!~~

Previous items: pending ♦

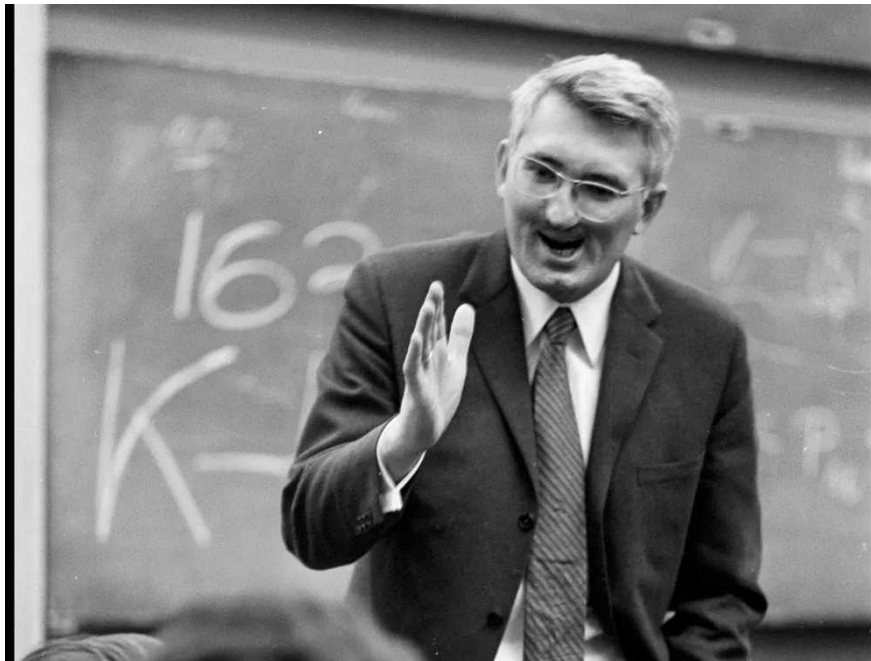
An earlier version of this article misspelled the name of Yiyi Zhang’s daughter.

Jürgen Habermas Defended Reason in a Darkening Age

The great German philosopher, who died in March, understood how much depended on a principled public sphere.

By Alex Ross

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You wake up and brace yourself for the barrage of toxic gibberish that constitutes the modern public sphere. Your e-mail is overrun with spam, scams, and smut. There are voice mails from no one about nothing. A glance at the news reveals that the President is continuing to spew lies and obscenities; that a trillionaire is peddling white-supremacist propaganda on a social-media platform he owns; that a chart-topping musical artist is praising Hitler, or apologizing for praising Hitler, or praising Hitler once again. Publications from the *Times* on down employ clickbait headlines that treat you like a starving rat in a Pavlovian experiment. A.I. systems simulate the experience of talking to an arrogant ten-year-old boy who knows far less than he thinks he does. When pressed, the chatbots admit that they cannot

“naturally understand human morality, dignity, culture, or meaning.” It all adds up to a continuous discursive tinnitus—a buzz of random, fake, stupid, sinister chatter that nobody wants and nobody can stop.

The person who should have been best able to explain how we got here was the great German philosopher Jürgen Habermas, who illuminated how a feisty, principled public sphere is integral to democracy. But Habermas died in March, at the age of ninety-six, and, although he remained active until his final months, commenting on Ukraine, Gaza, and Eurobonds, he struggled to understand the turn history had taken. As a teen-ager in 1945, he had witnessed American soldiers enter his home town of Gummersbach, near Cologne, carrying messages of freedom and openness. Eight decades later, he watched American voters choose a leader who had advertised his fascistic bent in blood-and-soil rhetoric, fantasies of punitive violence, and a taste for bombastic architectural kitsch. The far right was making inroads across Europe, including in Germany. The print-based media culture that once anchored Habermas’s public sphere had devolved into a digital sludgefest that proved better at circulating racist memes than at fostering morality and dignity. A couple of years before his death, in a conversation with the historian Philipp Felsch, Habermas said that his world was being dismantled “step by step.”

None of this would have surprised a previous generation of German thinkers—the group known as the Institute for Social Research, or the Frankfurt School. The institute emerged in the nineteen-twenties, went into exile during the Nazi period, and returned to Germany after the war. Its leading figures, Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno, saw capitalist society not as the antithesis of totalitarianism but as its more affable, aw-shucks twin. Citizens become commodities; technology increases the power of an already powerful few; pop culture serves up mechanized slop; truth and lies commingle. Their default mode was apocalyptic: “The fully enlightened Earth glows under the sign of triumphant disaster.” Now, with gig workers frantically self-branding, tech barons amassing unthinkable wealth, algorithms dictating consumption, A.I. infecting reality, and Earth itself turning feverish, Horkheimer and Adorno’s worst-case scenarios begin to seem overly optimistic.

Habermas started out under the aegis of the Frankfurt School, serving as Adorno's assistant. Yet the group's fatalism eventually struck him as a repudiation of social purpose—a “strategy of hibernation,” he called it. He similarly resisted the truth-clouding rhetoric of French post-structuralism. He was not ready to give up on the concept of reason articulated in the writings of Immanuel Kant, whose ideal of *Menschenwürde*, or human dignity, is enshrined in the first lines of the German constitution. Habermas made it his mission to elaborate a modern philosophy of reason, rooted in dialogue and debate, attuned to a pluralistic world. He took his project out of the seminar room and into the political arena, defending democracy, embracing the European Union, and denouncing any resurgence of German nationalism. As a result, he became a cynosure in German politics and a resonant voice abroad. At his peak of influence, around 2000, it was as if a secular pope had been anointed: *Habemus Habermas*.

An infinite scroll of evidence suggests that Habermas's last-ditch defense of reason has failed. On both the right and the left, positions are hardening; each tribe has its truth. In a broader sense, Habermas's death might mark the end of a mode of main-stage philosophizing that, in the German-speaking world, reaches back, by way of Adorno, Heidegger, Nietzsche, Marx, Schopenhauer, and Hegel, to Kant himself. The age of the Germanic male genius delivering edicts from on high has run its course. Habermas sensed this: he was attempting to move past his discipline's oracular tradition and encourage a new model of public deliberation, one in which the philosopher serves as mediator, interpreter, conciliator. At the heart of Habermas's omnivorous, at times contradictory, body of work is an idea as simple as it is profound: in adopting the perspectives of others, we learn to become ourselves.

Triumphant disaster was the sign under which the members of the Frankfurt School lived their lives. In addition to Horkheimer and Adorno, the group included Herbert Marcuse, Friedrich Pollock, Erich Fromm, Leo Löwenthal, Franz Neumann, and Walter Benjamin. Most were born around the turn of the twentieth century, into well-to-do, assimilated Jewish families, and their early adulthoods were marked by the bloodbath of the First World War and the revolutionary mayhem that followed. As Philipp Lenhard writes in “Café Marx,” a recent German-language history of the Frankfurt School, these

thinkers learned in their youth that “war and barbarism were no ‘workplace accident’ of bourgeois society but instead the result of its intrinsic logic.”

The Institute for Social Research was formed in 1923, under the auspices of Goethe University, in Frankfurt. Early meetings occurred at the Senckenberg Natural History Museum, beneath a diplodocus skeleton and other prehistoric relics. At first, the institute concentrated on earnest Marxian research projects. Then, in 1930, Horkheimer, a brilliant, turbulent man with a melancholic streak, became director and instilled a more intransigent perspective. He took his lead from Pollock, who believed that the modern capitalist state had advanced to the point where its overthrow was no longer a likely prospect. Social-welfare programs had kept the working classes from becoming restive. In the absence of a revolution, Horkheimer called for scholars to focus on the intersection of capitalism, science, technology, and mass culture. He dubbed this new mode of engaged philosophy “critical theory.”

As Lenhard notes, Horkheimer “avoided the term ‘Marxist’ as the Devil avoids holy water.” Still, he retained many of Marx’s core concepts—above all, that of the dialectic. Since Socrates, dialectical thinking had been a method of eliciting truth through questioning and refutation. Hegel redefined the dialectic as a process of assertion, negation, and synthesis that gathers force through history. Marx, in turn, cast the dialectic in economic terms, establishing the emancipation of the proletariat as history’s goal. Horkheimer, amid the wreckage of world war, lost faith in progress; his dialectic negated one construct after another. The liberal order, to begin with, was diseased: “The bourgeois economy was so arranged that individuals maintain the life of society by looking after their own happiness. Inherent in this structure, however, is a dynamic that ultimately accumulates fantastic power on one side and material and spiritual weakness on the other, to a degree that recalls the old Asiatic dynasties.” The bureaucratic coldness of Bolshevik Communism and the violent regressions of Fascism were yet worse. The value-neutral positivism of modern science cast its nerve-rattling accomplishments as something inevitable and irrevocable—a “further extension of nature.”

Adorno internalized and perfected Horkheimer’s implacable voice. One of the youngest members of the original Frankfurt School, he had studied both

music and philosophy before turning to the latter in the late twenties. He won lasting notoriety for his diatribes against commercial jazz, though his assessments of the classical-music industry were equally acidulous: “The type of conductor who wallows insatiably in the glories of the Adagio of Bruckner’s Eighth acts like a capitalist magnate, bringing as many organizations, institutes, and orchestras as possible under his control.” Adorno was not yet thirty when Hitler took power. The institute, alert to what was coming, had already moved its financial resources out of the country and opened a subsidiary office in Geneva. By 1934, it was putting down roots in New York.

Disaster glowed ever brighter. Benjamin killed himself at the French-Spanish border in 1940, having despaired of his chances of escaping the Nazis. Horkheimer and Adorno ended up in Los Angeles, where, under the ironic glare of a perpetual sun, they co-wrote “Dialectic of Enlightenment,” the most extreme of Frankfurt School tracts. Their primary target was the sainted Kant, who had defined enlightenment as “the human being’s emancipation from its self-incurred immaturity,” with maturity consisting of the resolve to act freely and independently. This sounds glorious, and yet, Horkheimer and Adorno observe, freedom falls to those who are best positioned to grab it. They show how the proud autonomy of the bourgeois individual can degenerate into lawless self-aggrandizement—the Marquis de Sade and Nietzsche are leading examples—and, eventually, totalitarian megalomania. *Herrschaft*, or domination, is the principal theme: domination of nature, domination of people, domination of culture.



Adorno assails the last topic in a chapter titled “Culture Industry,” which has few rivals in the annals of *élite dyspepsia*. “All mass culture under monopoly is identical,” he notes. Consumers have the “freedom to choose what is always the same.” He is arguing with the absent Benjamin, who saw liberatory potential in Charlie Chaplin movies. Until recently, Adorno seemed to have lost the debate. Generations of readers rejected his snobbery, his prejudice, his tendency to write sentences such as “The same babies grin endlessly from magazines, the jazz machine endlessly pounds.” But the underlying ideas sting harder now. Adorno sees mass culture as a pivotal component of the capitalist scheme to mollify the populace with calculated compensations. It claims to be serving the public while inventing needs that the public had been happy to live without. The façade is democratic—Hollywood stars are just like us!—yet the structure is authoritarian, training us to bow down before celebrity gods. The birth of a fascist President out of the spirit of reality television could be seen as a Q.E.D. for Adorno’s thesis.

The question, of course, is what we are supposed to do with these bourgeois jeremiads against bourgeois civilization, beyond enjoying them as high-end primal-scream therapy. Members of the Frankfurt School were prey to what Habermas’s colleague Karl-Otto Apel called the “performative contradiction”: if you have used the tools of reason to dismantle reason, your own work might be compromised in turn. The Marxist theorist Georg

Lukács complained that Adorno and company had taken up residence in what he called the Grand Hotel Abyss—“a beautiful hotel, equipped with every comfort, on the edge of an abyss, of nothingness, of absurdity.” Habermas wished, in a sense, to vacate the hotel and traverse the abyss outside.

In sharp contrast to the first-generation members of the Frankfurt School, Habermas came from a petit-bourgeois, culturally conservative Protestant milieu, his family name going back to sixteenth-century Thuringian cobblers. His father, Ernst, led the local chamber of commerce in Gummersbach. The elder Habermas signed up for the Nazi Party in 1933, and Jürgen was required to join the Hitler Youth. Only by chance did he escape being drafted into the Army when teen-agers were forced to defend the Third Reich in its last months.

Cosmopolitan and anti-sentimental, Habermas generally avoided talking about personal matters, but, when he received the Kyoto Prize, in 2004, he delivered a speech that gave glimpses of a strange and difficult youth. He was born with a cleft palate and underwent several operations to address the condition. The experience gave him, he said, a sense of his “dependence and vulnerability.” In school, he had difficulty making himself understood and was mocked for his nasal tone. He was also vulnerable in another sense. Stefan Müller-Dooch, in his 2014 biography of the philosopher, notes that Nazi racial science considered a cleft palate a “sign of degeneration.” A decade later, a number of children born with this condition were murdered by the Nazis as part of their so-called euthanasia program.

As a young man, Habermas threw himself into the rapidly reopening culture of the new West German state. He consumed the modernist canon that had been forbidden during the Nazi period: abstract art, Expressionist and Brechtian theatre, Italian neorealist cinema. Politically, he aligned himself with the left wing of the Social Democratic Party. He studied philosophy in Göttingen, in Zurich, and in Bonn, where he received his doctorate. At first, he revered the arcane thought of Martin Heidegger, who, despite his initial support for the Nazi regime, remained a formidable figure in the postwar era. In 1953, Heidegger republished his 1935 lectures on metaphysics, and Habermas was shocked to find that the bard of Being had not only kept pro-Nazi sentiments in the text—one lecture speaks of the “inner truth and

greatness” of Hitler’s Germany—but also refused to admit that anything had been amiss. In an article for the *Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung*, Habermas asked, “Is it not the noble duty of thoughtful people to clarify the accountable deeds of the past and to keep knowledge of them alive?”—those deeds being the “planned murder of millions of people.”

That brash attack caught the attention of Adorno, who had returned to Germany and was working alongside Horkheimer at the reconstituted Institute for Social Research. Three years later, Habermas took up an invitation to assist Adorno at the institute. Unfortunately, Horkheimer was less enthusiastic about the new recruit. At the height of the Cold War, the institute’s director wished more than ever to avoid any taint of orthodox Marxism, and he got it into his head that Habermas was a revolutionary subversive. In a nine-page letter to Adorno in 1958, Horkheimer grumbled about the “dialectical Herr H.” Adorno, who generally deferred to Horkheimer, stood by his assistant. Still, the atmosphere was uncomfortable enough that Habermas left the institute a year later, to write his *Habilitation*, or second dissertation, a requirement for qualifying as a professor in German universities.

What resulted was “The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere,” Habermas’s first major work, and still his most famous. It is a potent mixture of critical theory and social history, tracing the evolution of public discourse and media culture from the eighteenth century to the present. We follow the inception of a space between private and political life where open debate is possible—that of *Öffentlichkeit*, which can be translated as “public” or “publicness” but is usually rendered as “public sphere.” The concept was not new: Hannah Arendt, in her 1958 book, “The Human Condition,” had described the development of the “public realm” or “the common.” Yet Habermas’s approach was exceptionally rigorous and precise. He had a flair for folding masses of literature into fluid narratives.

“Structural Transformation” is, essentially, a story of rise and fall. At first, the public sphere was reserved for displays of power by the ruling classes. Then, as the bourgeois classes prospered under capitalism, they began to exercise their own kind of *Öffentlichkeit*. Periodicals first presented mundane merchant reports, then ventured to publish observations on arts and literature. This shift became a dry run for the discussion of heavier matters:

“Critical debate ignited by works of literature and art was soon extended to include economic and political disputes.” Habermas also lavishes attention on coffeehouses, reading clubs, salons, and other in-between places where new ideas were taking shape. Although he is aware of the darker side of the rising bourgeoisie—notably its links to economic exploitation—he insists that the bourgeois mentality was never *just* ideology: it offered a blueprint for a truly free society.

In the later chapters of “Structural Transformation,” the influence of the Frankfurt School is unmistakable. In the late nineteenth century, the media became increasingly preoccupied by profit. Newspapers fell into the hands of magnates who advanced their own interests. With the entrance of radio and television, information was transmitted instantaneously and universally, yet the public grew passive, absorbing news without necessarily acting on it. As media monopolies gained control of discourse, a new feudalism arose. Habermas is particularly acute in showing what the modern media landscape can do to politics. Candidates must position themselves as entertainers, performing for voters rather than persuading them. Each campaign season is a *Neuinszenierung*—a new theatrical production. Decades before anyone talked about filter bubbles, Habermas wrote of a “homogeneous opinion climate,” of “fictional consensus.”

“Structural Transformation” had a triumphant reception when it was published, in 1962. Two years later, once Horkheimer retired, Habermas assumed the archtheorist’s post at Goethe University. (Horkheimer, to his credit, had dropped his objections to his younger colleague.) Stepping into the public forum mapped out in “Structural Transformation,” Habermas wrote prolifically for newspapers, often commenting on growing student protests. For the most part, he defended the students, but he recoiled when a few activists raised the possibility of violent action. In 1967, he made an off-the-cuff remark about “left fascism,” which he soon retracted, although he was never able to regain his standing among the radicals.

Chaos engulfed the institute at the end of 1968. Students occupied the building and hung banners with mocking quotations from Horkheimer. In January, 1969, Adorno and his colleague Ludwig von Friedeburg called in the police. Although Habermas did not take part in that decision, as Frankfurt police records indicate, he did publicly defend Adorno’s actions. A

few months later, three women staged an infamous *Busenattentat*, or “breast attack,” baring their chests during an Adorno lecture on the dialectic. One student leaflet read, “Adorno as an institution is dead!” The man himself died, of a heart attack, that summer. Habermas remembered him as “the only genius I have met in my life.”

Habermas would have been Adorno’s natural successor at the institute, but, after the tumult of the student protests, he stepped back from the public fray. In the seventies, he immersed himself in multidisciplinary research projects at the Max Planck Institute for the Study of the Scientific-Technical World, in Bavaria. In 1981, he emerged with “Theory of Communicative Action,” a two-volume treatise that attempts to renovate the meetinghouse of reason. This is the moment when Habermas breaks from the Frankfurt School. Adorno’s climactic philosophical work, “Negative Dialectic,” invoked the Shoah as the black hole of the Enlightenment: “After Auschwitz, our feelings reject any claim for the positivity of existence as sanctimony, as injustice to the victims.” Unwilling to renounce positivity, Habermas returns to the old Kantian problem: How, in an age of bewildering change and undeniable catastrophe, can rational individuals build a more humane world?

Kant unveiled a transcendental dimension in which we can hold fast to universal concepts, even if we cannot verify them. His “categorical imperative” was an Enlightenment revision of the Golden Rule: follow only those maxims that you believe could apply to all. Habermas shares Horkheimer and Adorno’s doubts about such a scheme, which puts too much faith in individuals’ ability to divine truth on their own. Instead, reason should grow from the quotidian mechanics of human contact, as we learn by trial and error what it means to be human and humane. In “Theory of Communicative Action,” Habermas lays out a master synthesis of analytic methods, including Marx’s critique of capitalism, Émile Durkheim’s depiction of collective consciousness, Max Weber’s sociology of power, systems theory, speech-act theory, and psychoanalysis. The book is so encyclopedic that it becomes unwieldy, even by the standards of European philosophy. By the same measure, it feels like a faithful mirror of our hyper-complex world.

At the heart of the scheme is American pragmatism, which older schools of German thought had considered unserious. Habermas leans heavily on the

Chicago-based social philosopher George Herbert Mead, who declared that the act of communication is essential for the formation of both society and the individual. We find our identity through interaction with others, and we must be prepared for anyone to question our claims, whether on the grounds of truth, sincerity, relevance, or coherence. Merely using the pronoun “you” presumes an exchange of roles and risks rebuttal. Each time we step outside our egoistic frame, we undergo a course of dialectic. This quest for consensus is so significant that it is endowed with a slight mystical tinge: “The very medium of mutual understanding abides in a peculiar *half-transcendence*.” Later, Habermas called that process “transcendence from within”—a merging of the self with the other.

“Theory of Communicative Action” stirred vigorous debate, in keeping with its theme. Many critics said that its picture of discourse was too becalmed, resembling a university seminar. Habermas makes little allowance for humans’ tendency to shout down one another, for men’s tendency to shout down women, for lies and manipulations, for the twisting of reason into its opposite. In response, Habermas maintained that communication is impossible unless people at least assume that consensus is possible. If you go into every conversation thinking that your counterpart could be a sociopath, you will retreat into paranoid isolation. This is also the fundamental challenge of politics—and, not surprisingly, Habermas turned next to the theory of democracy.

There were always two Habermases: the methodical academic and the nimble public commentator. Peter J. Verovšek, a professor at the University of Groningen, explores that double identity in a new book, “Jürgen Habermas: Public Intellectual and Engaged Critical Theorist.” According to Habermas, philosophers should present themselves not as “teachers of the nation”—the history of intellectuals in Nazi Germany besmirched that role—but as “dilettantes” who “question the demarcation lines between various realms.” His paragon, surprisingly, was Adorno, who, notwithstanding his mandarin prose, often explicated his ideas on radio and television. Habermas preferred to speak through newspaper essays—hundreds of them, on a multitude of topics, from postmodern architecture to genetic engineering. He could be deft, as in his sketch of the mood of the nineties: “somewhat depressed, somewhat clueless, the whole thing washed over by the throb of techno-pop.” There were limits to his hipness, though. Once, he told the

writer Peter Handke that he had never heard the Beatles' "Yellow Submarine," causing Handke to smack him.

Habermas returned to the limelight in the late seventies, when far-left terrorist actions led the conservative Bavarian politician Franz Josef Strauss to accuse the Frankfurt School of having inspired the violence. Habermas wrote in *Der Spiegel*, "Rest assured, we will not accuse Herr Strauss of being a fascist"—while more or less doing so. In the mid-eighties, Habermas went after conservative historians who felt that Germans should no longer flagellate themselves over the Nazi past. The historian Ernst Nolte relativized the Holocaust by saying that the "so-called annihilation of the Jews" was only one of many twentieth-century horrors, the worst of which came from Bolshevism. Habermas responded angrily in *Die Zeit*: "Auschwitz shrinks to the level of a technical innovation and becomes explicable in the face of an 'Asiatic' threat from an enemy still standing outside our gates." He propelled this *Historikerstreit*, or historians' feud, into the mainstream and succeeded, for a while, in discrediting the apologists.

At the time, the conservative critique of the welfare state was gaining ground across the West, not least in the United States. Habermas's admiration for the American prototype waned during the Presidency of Ronald Reagan—when deregulation eroded the independence of the media—and plunged during the Presidency of George W. Bush. Visiting New York shortly after September 11th, Habermas was alienated by an upsurge of patriotic blather and xenophobia. In the face of the "callous superpower," he proposed, the nascent European Union could define itself as a different kind of transnational entity—a federation of peoples that, through hard experience, had moved past the futility of nationalism. In place of tribal notions of folkish identity, the peoples of the world could adopt *Verfassungspatriotismus*—patriotism for a constitution, for a society's collective plan. Habermas's disdain for chauvinist displays was visceral. Whenever the German national anthem was played, he preferred to leave the room.



In “Between Facts and Norms,” published in 1992, Habermas assimilated communicative action to “deliberative democracy”—a term that he had picked up from the American political scientist Joseph M. Bessette. Echoing the political philosophy of John Rawls, Habermas writes that a healthy deliberative democracy must serve multiple nodes of opinion. At the center are the lawmaking and governing institutions. The sheer complexity of large democracies demands such an official apparatus, even if, as Habermas knows, it can become captive to controlling interests. As a counterweight, a periphery of mass opinion—a new version of the public sphere—can force fresh items onto the societal agenda. By way of grassroots organization, civil disobedience, investigative journalism, and the like, it can draw attention to economic inequality, ecological crisis, civil rights, and technological threats. It is a zone of “anarchic, unfettered communicative freedom”—a “warning system with sensors.”

Habermas’s center-and-periphery model gives a persuasive picture of democracy as it currently functions. Is a more inclusive mechanism possible? The political theorist Hélène Landemore has won notice as a champion of direct democracy, which would allow the barriers between center and periphery to give way. In her new book, “Politics without Politicians,” Landemore cites Habermas respectfully but contends that deliberative democracy hardly deserves the name when only a few people

are actually deliberating. The great counterexample is ancient Athens, which was steered by a five-hundred-person council whose members were generally chosen by lot. The best analogy to direct democracy in contemporary life is jury duty, which generally seems to go better than anyone expects. How such a system could be replicated in a nation of tens or hundreds of millions is unclear, although Landemore sees encouraging signs in advisory citizen councils that have been convened in Canada, Ireland, Iceland, and France. To be sure, direct democracy is no guarantee of wise decision-making. Athens was a belligerent city-state that fell victim to its own aggressions. The experiment lasted about two hundred and fifty years.

In his last decades, Habermas added one more link to his long chain of disciplines. The rise of fundamentalism, in the form of evangelical Christianity, Islamist revivalism, and Hindu nationalism, prompted him to consider the “unexhausted force of religious traditions,” as he put it in 2007. Although he was an atheist, he opened dialogues with clerical figures, including Joseph Ratzinger, who became Pope Benedict XVI. Conceding that “enlightened reason unavoidably loses its grip on the images, preserved by religion, of the moral whole,” Habermas said that philosophers should have an “awareness of what is missing” in their thinking, particularly when it comes to moral norms. Religious institutions, for their part, should make peace with the modern state, which cannot choose among competing world views. More than that, they should actively collaborate with secular thinkers to articulate a code of justice that all participants can respect. Benedict wasn’t receptive to that argument, but Leo XIV seems conscious of it.

Habermas’s religious preoccupations yielded a culminating masterpiece, “Also a History of Philosophy,” a seventeen-hundred-and-fifty-page behemoth that appeared in German in 2019, as the author turned ninety. (Polity Press, which has published much of Habermas’s œuvre in English, released a translation, by Ciaran Cronin, in 2023.) It’s more engrossing than you might expect. Habermas was the kind of professor who knows the literature cold yet never tires of bringing it to life, and “Also a History” is an epic theological-philosophical pageant that stretches across millennia, moving from Neolithic ritual and ancient myth to the monotheistic religions and onward to modern secular thought. Kant retains a place of honor; Heidegger gets a few farewell kicks.

At all stages of history, Habermas shows, humanity has been trying to work out codes for the common good, and these surface even in times of dogmatic repression. Buddha offers an egalitarian path to enlightenment; Confucius codifies a religion of learning; Augustine infuses Christianity with Plato and Aristotle; Martin Luther shifts spirituality inward; Duns Scotus separates belief from knowledge; William of Ockham cultivates equality under the law. Rationality lurks in theology from the beginning, just as philosophy never shakes off its yearning for the metaphysical. Perhaps the most ingenious move in “Also a History” is to draft the intractable Adorno onto the conciliatory team. Theological content, Adorno once said, “will have to put itself to the test of migrating into the realm of the secular, the profane.” This is just the sort of translation of the sacred that Habermas traces in his book.

Notably, “Also a History” gives scant attention to Islam. The medieval philosopher al-Farabi, who considered democracy the least imperfect of imperfect governments, is mentioned only in passing. A similar Western bias contributed to one of Habermas’s last, and least effective, public interventions. In November, 2023, after Hamas’s massacre of Israelis and the onset of Israel’s brutal counterstrike on Gaza, Habermas signed a statement that reasserted solidarity between Germany and Israel. After a glancing mention of Palestinian suffering, the authors write, “The standards of judgment slip completely when genocidal intentions are attributed to Israel’s actions.” It’s one thing to deny that genocide has taken place in Gaza; it’s another to imply more broadly that the topic is out of bounds. At a crucial moment, Habermas’s cherished pluralism failed him.

“If no dread remains, the monsters return,” Habermas wrote early in his career. They’re back, on several continents. Earlier this year, in Germany, the Sachsen-Anhalt branch of the far-right Alternative für Deutschland party released a platform containing such demands as “Think German!,” “Promote patriotism—no state money for anti-German art and culture!,” and “Build more beautifully!” This dumbed-down Goebbels gobbledygook revived talking points that Habermas had tried to quash during the *Historikerstreit*. Not surprisingly, AfD representatives could barely contain their glee over the philosopher’s death. Hans-Thomas Tillschneider, one of the Party’s nastier voices, posted a YouTube video in which he said, “Habermas is dangerous. He is one of the greatest enemies of the German nation.”

Tillschneider's inability to put Habermas into the past tense was somehow reassuring.

An equally obnoxious obituary came from the billionaire pen of Alex Karp, the C.E.O. of Palantir Technologies. Before Karp turned to hawking surveillance systems that have assisted *ICE* in its murderous roundups of immigrants, he studied philosophy under Habermas in Frankfurt. In an article for *Politico*, Karp recounted how Habermas provided fierce but fair criticism of his papers: "It was his very willingness to be so productively unsparing that reminds me of what we have lost as a culture." Alas, the losses that Karp has in mind don't seem to involve learning, rigor, or reason. Waving away Habermas's cosmopolitan ideals, he says that discourse "must be rooted in a more corporeal and traditional—and indeed national and cultural—source." This is the language of *MAGA* and the AfD, not to mention Heidegger circa 1935. Karp's ideological atavism is all too typical of the current bent of Silicon Valley.

Habermas was well aware of how the internet had deformed his beloved public sphere. At first, he thought that the digital arena could amplify all those anarchic voices on the periphery. Sometimes it has: think of social-media-driven movements such as the Arab Spring, Black Lives Matter, and #MeToo. More often, though, the indirectness and the anonymity of digital exchanges have sabotaged understanding. If, as G. H. Mead argued, face-to-face interactions facilitate the formation of a mature personality, the internet has enabled a mass regression to adolescent bullying and narcissism. Furthermore, tech companies designed their platforms to heighten conflict and thereby prolong engagement. It's as if they had read "Theory of Communicative Action" and done the opposite. Habermas tried to assess the damage in "A New Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere," which appeared in 2022 and turned out to be his last book. At the age of ninety-three, he couldn't be expected to cover fast-changing terrain, but he got off some crisp shots, writing of a "desolate cacophony in fragmented, self-enclosed echo chambers" and "the libertarian grimace of world-dominating digital corporations."

When the A.I. chatbots march in, the "colonization of the lifeworld," to use another ungainly but apt Habermas phrase, enters a terminal stage. Horkheimer and Adorno had concluded that advanced capitalism, far from

being a technocratic monolith, had an inherent tendency toward chaos and madness. A.I. is at once a consummation of technological control and a new level of cultish delirium. The designers themselves are often incapable of explaining what their systems are doing. Habermas's entire world view was premised on the idea of people learning from one another; A.I. annihilates communicative action in the name of hallucinatory conversations with sycophantic machines. The social effects have proved instantly disastrous: rampant disinformation, mass student cheating, cases of users becoming addicted to A.I. or killing themselves with its help. Meanwhile, to the joy of investors, untold thousands of jobs have vanished. As an added coup, A.I. managed to deliver a personal affront to Habermas a year before his death. In 2024, Google DeepMind unveiled a "Habermas Machine," which has been described as a "scaffolded pair of LLMs designed to find consensus among people who disagree." The philosopher had not given Google permission to use his name, and he was horrified when he heard about the scheme.

In his final book, Habermas spoke of the need to "institutionalize the anarchic power of saying 'no.'" The force of refusal, of Melville's "I would prefer not to," is potentially absolute: slop ceases to exist when we stop clicking on it. Europe, where the Enlightenment first arose and where it met its first demise, is the likeliest place for a concerted rebellion. State funding for media and culture means that the public sphere remains partly intact, and the E.U. has taken steps to regulate the internet and A.I. Moreover, as Habermas saw at the time of the Iraq War, a pan-European sensibility is being bolstered by a cumulative loathing for a long century of American imperialism—military, economic, technological, cultural. Perhaps there could even be a real shudder of self-disgust on these shores—a recognition that our national pursuit of material happiness has immiserated much of the rest of the world and is now devouring itself. Such, at least, is the vibe of our squalid semiquincentennial summer.

Philosophy is a discipline of abstractions, yet it raises achingly elemental questions. The august Kant asks, "What can I know? What should I do? What can I hope for?" The answers are seldom simple or bright. The seduction of despair can be intense, whether on the personal or the political level. But the fact that most of our hopes remain unrealized should not revoke the reality of our fitful, painful progress. This was Habermas's core

conviction; he was an incrementalist, though a radical one. On the other hand, in his almost manic drive toward consensus, he blunted the edge of his critical inheritance. If we are to say no to the monstrosities that we have unleashed, we need the uncompromising fury that the Frankfurt School writers invested in their work. We need Adorno to tell us that the confusion of truth and lies “makes it a Sisyphean labor to hold on to the simplest piece of knowledge.” In the end, we need both voices: the critical and the reconstructive, the savage and the sage. The dialectic moves between crashing despair and hovering hope. ♦

A Reporter at Large

Inside the Ludicrous, Deadly Serious Plan to Take Over Greenland

“We want Greenland,” Trump said. Four men sprang into action to make fantasy a reality.

By Ben Taub

June 15, 2026



On a Saturday afternoon in Nuuk, Greenland, last March, a thousand people walked down toward the harbor, to a small red cabin that bore the Great Seal of the United States—an eagle grasping an olive branch in one foot and thirteen arrows in the other. The air was freezing, and the town was bathed in the crisp Arctic light of a late-winter sun. After almost seven decades with no diplomatic presence in Greenland, the U.S. had opened a tiny consulate in 2020, during the pandemic; now, less than two months into Donald Trump’s second term as President, it was the site of the largest demonstration in Greenlandic history.

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Even before Trump retook office, he had made clear his intent to annex Greenland. But, from the moment that he was sworn in, his fantasies and provocations became American foreign policy. “One way or another, we’re gonna get it,” he told a joint session of Congress. So five per cent of Nuuk’s residents stood before the consulate, beating traditional drums and chanting their country’s Inuit name: Kalaallit Nunaat. “Enough is enough,” they shouted. But no one from the State Department drew the blinds. It wasn’t clear that anyone was even there.

Across town, in the commercial center, a lone American handed out flyers. He wore a cowhide jacket and pants, mirrored sunglasses, and a black leather vest with a patch that read “Bikers for Trump.” He was tall and fit, with gray curls and a short mustache, and presented himself as a kind of unofficial ambassador—not of the U.S. government but of its President, whose cellphone number he claimed to have. “My name is Chris Cox. I’m from the United States, and I have come here to try to make some friends,” he said to an elderly Inuit man. “We are not looking at you like a tiger looks at a gazelle.”

Cox had founded Bikers for Trump in 2015, and the group had provided security at campaign rallies and at Trump’s first Inauguration—“a wall of meat,” as he put it, between protesters and the unlikely candidate who became President. When Trump lost the 2020 election, Cox spoke at a rally to call for overturning the result. “I, for one, will take the first bullet,” he said. “If there’s anybody out there from Antifa or Black Lives Matter, spend your first fuckin’ bullet in my chest.” But in Nuuk he struck a more conciliatory tone. “We are not biting at the chops,” he said. “I just plan on doing the best we can to have an influence here.”

“He wasn’t really breaking any laws,” a senior Greenlandic police official told me later. But Cox’s interactions were inherently provocative. “Without knowing it, a lot of the Greenlanders are living in the Stone Age,” he told an Italian TV channel.

“I’m receiving a lot of death threats as a result of my work here in Greenland,” Cox noted, a few days into his trip. “People are looking at me like I’m a Russian with a machine gun right now, when they see the Trump patch.” By that point, Greenlanders had started wearing red caps with white

text that read “Make America Go Away.” Nevertheless, Cox considered his mission to be fruitful. “I’ve got some suggestions for how we can clean this up,” he said, in a phone call from Nuuk to the *Washington Times*. “We need to change the hearts of some of these Greenlanders.”

Cox left Nuuk for Washington, D.C., where he claims to have briefed the White House and Republican lawmakers on his findings. He also did a prime-time interview with One America News Network, portraying Denmark, whose realm includes Greenland and the Faroe Islands, as an illegitimate colonial power that is committing “atrocities” against Greenlanders and “weaponizing” anti-Trump propaganda to turn people against the U.S. “Unfortunately, the natives, the Inuits and the Greenlanders, in my opinion, are suffering something we call, here in America, Stockholm syndrome,” he said.

According to Denmark’s national broadcaster, while Cox was in Nuuk, he made lists of Greenlanders who seemed open to annexation, and of those who obviously were not. He also solicited information on points of tension between Greenland and Denmark—examples of historical injustices that could be exploited for propaganda—and sought to recruit Greenlanders for a separatist movement, to tear apart the Kingdom of Denmark. Three months later, Trump appointed him to an advisory council at the Department of Homeland Security.

In recent months, the United States has kidnapped the President of Venezuela, launched a war with Iran, threatened Colombia, and started to move against Cuba. Trump’s obsession with Greenland has mostly slipped from the news. But Greenlanders worry that the war in Iran is only serving as a temporary reprieve; influence operations are ongoing, at Trump’s direction, and every so often he blurts out the stakes. During a rant about America’s European allies, Trump emphasized that his antipathy toward *NATO* “all began with, if you want to know the truth, Greenland. We want Greenland. They don’t want to give it to us, and I said, ‘Bye-bye!’ ”

The transatlantic alliance reflected a world that was designed and largely enforced by American power. Now, as American primacy fades, the U.S. government has embraced the predatory world view of its traditional opponents. Firepower matters more than values or alliances, and everything

is in play. In December, the Danish Defence Intelligence Service noted that the U.S. has transformed into a nation that “uses economic power, including threats of high tariffs, to enforce its will, and no longer rules out the use of military force, even against allies.” Weeks later, Danish soldiers prepared to blow up Greenlandic runways, in case of a U.S. invasion.

“If the United States chooses to attack another *NATO* country militarily, then everything comes to an end—including *NATO* and, with it, the security that has been provided since the end of the Second World War,” Denmark’s Prime Minister, Mette Frederiksen, warned. She later added, “The world order as we know it—that we have been fighting for, for eighty years—is over, and I don’t think it will return.”

Around that time, Trump texted the Prime Minister of Norway, Jonas Gahr Støre; since he had not received the Nobel Peace Prize, he wrote, “I no longer feel an obligation to think purely of Peace.” He then pivoted to Denmark’s claim to Greenland, which predates the founding of the U.S.: “Why do they have a ‘right of ownership’ anyway? There are no written documents, it’s only that a boat landed there hundreds of years ago, but we had boats landing there, also.” The message concluded, “The World is not secure unless we have Complete and Total Control of Greenland.”



During Trump's first term, "Make America Great Again" primarily meant that the U.S. would withdraw from the world and shield against what he and his supporters perceived as external threats. But in his second term Trump has looked outward. In his Inaugural Address, he pledged to expand U.S. territory and to carry "our flag into new and beautiful horizons." It is harder to remake what is already America into Trump's vision of "greatness" than it is to make America merely bigger.

Greenland is the largest island in the world, but it has fewer than fifty-seven thousand residents, who are mostly scattered among settlements and towns along its western coast. Although it belongs to the Kingdom of Denmark, it lies to the west of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge, and is part of North America. The latest articulation of the U.S.'s National Security Strategy, published in November, frames Trump's imperial ambitions as an extension of the Monroe Doctrine, the assertion by President James Monroe, in 1823, that any attempt by European powers to further colonize the Americas would be treated as "dangerous to our peace and safety." Under Trump's leadership, the N.S.S. says, "we will deny non-Hemispheric competitors the ability to position forces or other threatening capabilities, or to own or control strategically vital assets, in our Hemisphere."

But the elevated language of the N.S.S. obscures the fact that Trump's pursuit of Greenland has always been in the hands of a few ideologues and opportunists. Along with Cox, the Danish government has identified two other Americans as running private "influence operations" in Greenland: a former venture capitalist and pecan farmer named Tom Dans and a former Army Special Forces commander named Drew Horn, who has sought to dominate Greenland's rare-earth-mining sector. Both men served in Trump's first Administration—Dans at the Treasury, Horn in the Office of the Vice-President, the Office of the Director of National Intelligence, and the Departments of Energy and Defense. But the Danish and Greenlandic governments were unaware that, during Trump's first term, they had also represented their respective agencies on a secret National Security Council task force whose focus was the acquisition of Greenland.

A fourth man, Jørgen Boassen, is one of the very few Greenlanders who loudly support Trump; he spent much of the past year in self-imposed exile, floating between far-right American and European political gatherings, his

travel and living expenses covered by American benefactors whom he refuses to identify. And then there is Trump himself, whose stated reasons for coveting Greenland do not stand up to scrutiny—except that he considers it “psychologically important,” as he recently put it to the *New York Times*, to own the territory rather than merely have military access to it, as the U.S. has had continuously, under a treaty with Denmark, since 1951.

European officials have been perplexed and outraged in recent months, unsure when or whether Trump will order the U.S. military to annex Greenland. But the reality is that the United States is now a country in which matters of war and peace are decided not among diplomatic or military experts, in the interests of the state, but through informal channels, by people whose personal proximity to the President—through family, business, donations, or flattery—is their principal qualification.

In January, the *Times* asked Trump if there were any limits to his global powers. “Yeah, there is one thing,” he replied. “My own morality. My own mind. It’s the only thing that can stop me.”

The first time Trump is known to have expressed an interest in Greenland was in late 2018, when he was seventy-two years old. He summoned his national-security adviser, John Bolton, to the Oval Office, and confided that his longtime friend Ronald Lauder had suggested that he buy the island. “He asked, What did I think of it?” Bolton recalled. “I said, ‘Well, we do have some security issues in the Arctic.’ And then I went through them and said, ‘There are probably a lot of ways to handle it. Let me do some research, and I’ll come back to you.’ ”

What followed “was all done in a slightly clandestine, cloak-and-dagger way,” Fiona Hill, who was serving as the senior director for Europe and Russia on the National Security Council, told me. Bolton summoned her to his office, but he wouldn’t say why. When she arrived, she found him ashen-faced, sitting next to a Coast Guard admiral who was serving as the White House’s homeland-security adviser. “Bolton said to us, ‘Look, Ron Lauder has told Trump he needs to buy Greenland, and we’ve got to head this off before he announces he’s buying Greenland to everybody,’ ” Hill said. “He didn’t want us to let anybody else know, not even within our directorates.”

Bolton asked her to discreetly prepare a memo that presented more reasonable alternatives.

As Bolton saw it, the United States and its allies had been neglecting security in the Arctic region since the end of the Cold War. Although the U.S. had constructed seventeen military bases in Greenland during the Second World War, it started decommissioning them in the early fifties. Now the polar ice cap was melting, opening up potential Arctic sea lanes. Vladimir Putin had revived the Russian Navy, and had access to a large fleet of icebreakers. China was beginning to carry out state-funded scientific missions in the region, which could be useful for its commercial and military ambitions. The government in Beijing was also beginning to refer to China as a “near-Arctic state,” a designation that it invented and partly attributed to the fact that it *borders* an Arctic state. (The northernmost part of China is more than nine hundred miles south of the Arctic Circle.) One Chinese state-run entity even offered financing for three new runways and airports in Greenland.

The financing had come at Greenland’s request; after failing to persuade the Danish government to pay for the new airports, Greenland’s premier travelled to Beijing in 2017 and solicited more than half a billion dollars in funds. When U.S. Defense Secretary James Mattis heard about the arrangement, he warned the Danish defense minister that China must not be allowed to gain a foothold on the North American side of the Arctic—especially with infrastructure projects that could be of use to the Chinese military. Denmark stepped in to block the Chinese loans, and pulled together the funds to finance the airports directly. Still, the incident rattled analysts in the White House and the Pentagon. Greenland had achieved self-rule in 2009, and appeared to be on a path toward independence. What would happen when Denmark—which maintained authority over Greenlandic security—could no longer intervene?

But Hill’s research proved reassuring to Bolton. She and an Arctic specialist at the State Department named Markus Thomi found that the United States, under the 1951 treaty with Denmark, already had de-facto military control of Greenland. The U.S. had taken over the defense of Greenland during the Second World War, and had preserved its military access through negotiations that allowed Denmark to become a founding member of *NATO*.

Although the U.S. now maintained only a single base, in the far north, called Pituffik Space Base, for detecting and tracking incoming ballistic missiles from Russia, it could expand its presence in Greenland whenever—and pretty much however—it wanted to. All it had to do was ask.

Hill and Thomi put together a memo, laying out various options that were already available under the treaty. The idea, Hill said, was “to try to throw Trump off the scent and focus on putting together a broader U.S. Arctic approach.” Bolton told me much the same. “I read the treaty, and it seemed to me that it solved the problem, at least on the military side,” he said. “In terms of buying it, one thing that became apparent was that, you know, this is not the nineteenth century anymore. There are fifty-seven thousand people in Greenland. They have this feeling that they ought to have a say in their future.”

But, as more people in the Administration got wind of Trump’s ambitions, “it took off in a direction that Bolton feared it would,” Hill recalled. “It was like vultures circling a corpse—people going, ‘Oh, look at this! Maybe there’s a scrap here that I can do something with, for my own interest.’ ” Hill, who had previously worked as the U.S. intelligence community’s lead analyst on Russia and Eurasia, was struck by a horrifying sense of déjà vu. “I was taken aback—although perhaps I shouldn’t have been—by how much this paralleled things I saw in Russia over and over again: people hitching their wagon to a money-making or prestige opportunity, getting some swanky title, to pursue things that were obviously not to anybody’s benefit. I’d seen that in Chechnya, across the Caucasus, and in Donbas and Crimea,” she said. “I kept thinking, We’re even more like the Kremlin than I could have imagined, in terms of hangers-on, because there’s no discipline. It’s top-down, and nobody has power unless it’s derived from Trump.”

After completing the Greenland memo, Hill and Thomi met with the Danish Ambassador and several other Danish officials. As the conversation shifted to the North Atlantic, she recalled “trying to give them a heads-up by making strange eye movements, body-language signals that something was going to happen.” But the Danes didn’t pick up on it.

In mid-July, 2019, Hill ended her tenure. She felt that there was no way to continue serving in the Administration without becoming part of the

problem. “It is what it looks like—Trump is a king, and he’s thinking about his empire,” she told me. “It’s all about acquiring things—staking your claim, and then covering it in bling.”

Around the time that Hill left the White House, a phone rang at the Danish foreign ministry, in Copenhagen. It was the middle of a summer holiday, in 2019, and the sun was streaming into mostly empty offices. The caller was from the American Embassy, relaying a request from Washington: the President and the First Lady of the United States would like to visit Denmark in a little more than a month, and would appreciate a formal invitation from the Queen. (According to Bolton, White House staffers had heard that Melania wanted to see Copenhagen and thought it might be a nice stop for her and Trump on the way home from a state visit to Poland.)

“Danish diplomats, politicians, and defense officials cut short their summer vacations and threw themselves into the preparations,” the Danish journalist Martin Breum reported. “There was no room for negotiation on the dates.” On July 31st, the Danish royal family announced that Donald and Melania Trump would pay a state visit “at the invitation of Her Majesty the Queen.” Although Trump was reviled in Copenhagen, Mette Frederiksen, the Prime Minister, made clear the urgency of a warm reception. “The USA is Denmark’s most important and strongest ally in NATO,” her office wrote. “Our soldiers stand shoulder to shoulder in the world’s hotspots and in the defense of Europe’s security.”

Two weeks later, the *Wall Street Journal* broke the news that Trump had, “with varying degrees of seriousness, repeatedly expressed interest” in purchasing Greenland. The story came as a shock to the Danes—and to Bolton, who had spent the preceding weeks trying to figure out how to quietly warn the Danes himself. “I couldn’t imagine it leaked from the National Security Council, because we were holding it very close,” he told me. “I found out subsequently that, at various occasions down at Mar-a-Lago, Trump would be sitting around his dinner table, saying to the guests, ‘What would you think if we bought Greenland?’ And the guests would say, ‘Oh, well, that’s a good idea.’ ”

Trump later clarified to reporters that he saw the potential purchase as a real-estate deal for an island with a strategic location and rare-earth minerals.

“Why don’t we have that?” he asked. “I love maps. And I always said, ‘Look at the size of this. It’s massive. That should be part of the United States.’ ” (Because Greenland is so far north, it appears more than ten times larger on a Mercator projection than it does on a globe.)



The news of Trump’s territorial ambitions did not land well in Copenhagen or in Nuuk. “Are parts of the US for sale? Alaska?” Rasmus Jarlov, who has served as the chair of the Danish parliament’s defense committee, wrote on Twitter. Frederiksen took a more diplomatic line. “Thankfully, the time where you buy and sell other countries and populations is over,” she said. “Greenland belongs to Greenland. I strongly hope that this is not meant seriously.” The prospect of a sale, Frederiksen said, was “absurd.”

Trump fixated on Frederiksen’s comment. “I thought that the Prime Minister’s statement that it was absurd—that it was an absurd idea—was nasty,” he said. “You don’t talk to the United States that way.” Later that day, while he was in a private meeting with Bolton, Melania called. Trump answered the phone on speaker, and Bolton overheard the exchange. “I don’t know why people keep saying I want to go to Denmark,” Melania said. “If *you* want to go, I’ll go with you.”

Trump hung up the phone, then took to Twitter to cancel the trip, blaming it on Frederiksen.

Bolton says that he resigned three weeks later. Trump announced the departure on Twitter, by claiming to have fired him.

In the following months, Trump was impeached by the House for withholding military aid from Ukraine while pressuring its President to open an investigation into the Biden family. During that period, the “Greenland question,” as a senior State Department official referred to it during the impeachment inquiry, appeared dormant. In fact, the discussion had simply moved to secure rooms in the Eisenhower Executive Office Building, where, according to the official, it “took up a lot of energy” among Trump’s national-security staff. “Not only did he want to purchase Greenland, he actually said he wanted to see if we could sell Puerto Rico,” Miles Taylor, a former chief of staff at the Department of Homeland Security, later said. “Could we swap Puerto Rico for Greenland? Because, in his words, Puerto Rico was dirty and the people were poor.”

The Senate acquitted Trump in February, 2020, and his acolytes set about purging the White House and the civil service of career officials and replacing them with loyalists. Among the leaders of this effort was a lawyer named Paul Dans. Around that time, Dans’s twin brother, Tom, the former venture capitalist, who was now running a pecan farm in South Texas, got a call, asking if he’d like to be the Treasury Department’s Deputy Assistant Secretary for Europe and Eurasia.

Tom Dans had first come into contact with Trump in the early nineties; as a junior investment banker, Dans was part of a small team that was brokering the sale of Madison Square Garden, a deal that included not only the arena and various New York sports teams but also the Miss Universe pageant. As Dans remembers it, Trump and his representatives would call his office once a week and ask if he could purchase Miss Universe separately from the rest of the deal. “We were, like, ‘No, you gotta buy the whole enchilada,’ ” Dans told me. Trump would “hang up, wait a week, and try again.”

In Washington, Dans learned that there was a task force being run out of the National Security Council in which staffers representing each of the relevant

U.S. government agencies were deliberating options for the future of Greenland. “Let me get involved, because I’ve got a family connection,” Dans recalled telling his boss. Although Dans had never been to Greenland, his grandfather had served there as a merchant mariner during the Second World War, and had later helped construct Pituffik Space Base. Dans was appointed to the Greenland Policy Coordination Committee.

Much of the work of the Greenland P.C.C. was retroactively classified, but it centered on what the group’s members and their superiors regarded as both the threat and the opportunity of Greenlandic independence. “I want to say it’s an opportunity as long as we are willing and able to position ourselves to have a robust security and economic relationship with an independent Greenland,” Alexander Gray, who was serving as the chief of staff of the National Security Council at the time, told me. But Gray worried that Greenlandic independence would throw into question the security arrangements that were already in place: “Why would a Greenlandic independent government honor a treaty that their colonial masters signed with the United States decades ago?”

Gray had spent the preceding years observing and seeking ways to counter Chinese influence operations in sparsely populated island nations. “I had the portfolio dealing with the Pacific islands in the N.S.C., and we were dealing with this every day,” he told me. State-owned Chinese entities offered loans to such nations for infrastructure projects; if the nations defaulted, the Chinese could take control. A security agreement between China and the Solomon Islands enabled the deployment of Chinese paramilitary forces. “Watching that in real time prompted a lot of people to really have concerns about where an independent Greenland would ultimately end up,” Gray said.

To temper the perceived risks posed by Greenlandic independence, the Trump Administration set about trying to accelerate it in ways that would bring about a greater reliance on the U.S. “There’s nothing secret about the contours of the thing—if you study Greenland at all, you quickly arrive at the point that, you know, they’re asset rich and cash poor,” Dans told me. A major obstacle to Greenlandic independence is the absence of a self-sufficient economy; each year, Denmark doles out a block grant of around six hundred million dollars. “So, like, this is not a toughie, if you come from an investment-banking or dealmaking background, to solve,” Dans

continued. “I hate to sound glib about it, but, when we’re shovelling trillions of dollars out of the Treasury for *COVID* relief—boom, boom, boom—and you’re looking at a number which is a couple hundred million, it’s, like, ‘Guys, let’s get serious here. What’s going on? This is not a difficult thing.’”

The U.S. set out on a “charm offensive,” as Greenland’s only private national newspaper, *Sermitsiaq*, put it at the time. Trump’s Ambassador to Denmark made numerous trips to Greenland, and courted Greenlandic politicians with promises of American business investment, educational opportunities, and development aid. The U.S. reopened its consulate in Nuuk, which had been shuttered since 1953. During the fall of 2019, a delegation of American diplomats and national-security officials arrived in Nuuk to discuss Greenland’s mineral resources, with a particular focus on mining strategic rare-earth minerals. Left undisclosed was the fact that among them were members of the National Security Council who were working to subvert the Kingdom of Denmark; they belonged to the Greenland P.C.C.

According to Drew Horn, the senior Administration official who was co-leading the Greenland P.C.C., the group routinely discussed the potential for friction with Denmark, and took “deliberate efforts meant to appease Danish concerns.” The intention, Horn said, “was never to vilify Denmark. It was always to do this as a win for everybody.” (Denmark’s win, as he saw it, was that it could cut loose a financial burden, even as it lost ninety-eight per cent of its territory and its relevance to Arctic geopolitics.) But the Danes were neither informed about the existence of the Greenland P.C.C. nor aware of its plans.

For the final two years of Trump’s first term, the work of the U.S. government in Greenland amounted to overt diplomacy and outreach paired with covert, winking assurances to Greenlandic officials that the U.S. would financially support their pursuit of independence in exchange for total military sovereignty over the island. The concept was hardly different from what Gray had cast as the Chinese approach—only the U.S. was now doing it first.

Still, military annexation was not on the table. The United States military continued to regard its allies and the “rules-based order” as the cornerstone

of its Arctic strategy. On the sidelines of the *NATO* Leaders' Meeting that winter, Bolton's replacement, Robert O'Brien, urged his Danish counterparts to make a show of their commitment to Greenland's security. O'Brien advised them to build a large, permanent air-force base, and to keep frigates on rotation in the Nuuk harbor, as a deterrent to the Russian and Chinese navies. The Danes "wanted to talk about plans and white papers, and that sort of thing," he told me. "Whereas I'm the kind of guy who—well, I'd just take over a hotel in Nuuk and send a hundred Danish special operators there."

To the Danes, it was as if the Americans had lost track of their own fantasy. The American argument, O'Brien said, was that "guys with dogsleds aren't going to stop a naval infantry regiment of the Chinese or the Russians coming on board from an icebreaker." But neither country had ever threatened Greenland, and the prospect of an imminent invasion made no strategic or tactical sense. After Denmark stepped in to finance the three Greenlandic airports, Chinese investment ground to a halt. Besides, Greenland was *NATO* territory; any attack would, at least in principle, invoke the possibility of nuclear Armageddon.

"I think the Danes had gotten used to business as usual," O'Brien told me. "They liked it much better when the U.S. provided all their security, and it didn't cost them anything, and they could spend their money on social programs and worker programs." He continued, "In other words, we were supposed to defend it but not have any say in the governance of Greenland, and potentially even have *how* we defended it questioned by the Danes."

I asked whether he felt that the Danes had grasped the depth of Trump's desire to take over the island.

"No, I don't think they took it seriously," O'Brien said. "They did when he came back."

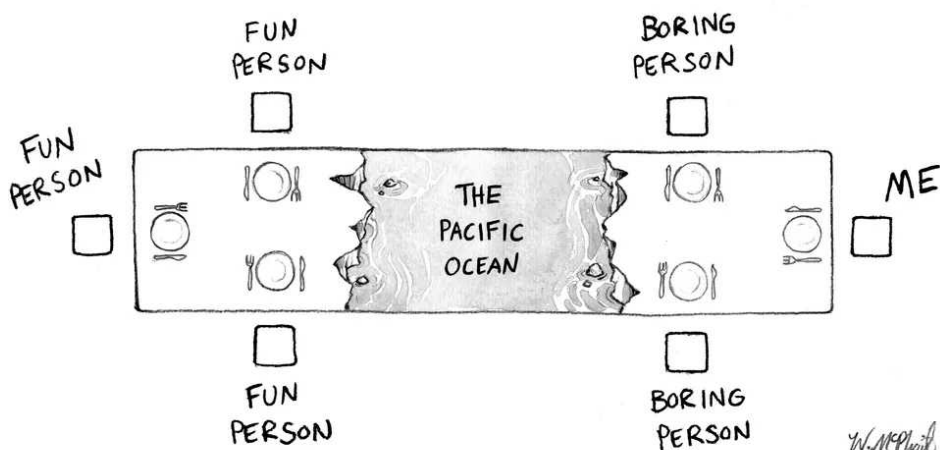
After Trump lost the 2020 election, Tom Dans went back to pecan farming. "We did have a period of exile," he told me, of the aftermath of the Capitol insurrection. (He was unaware of the attack in real time; he'd spent much of the day inside a secure facility, working with members of the Greenland P.C.C.) But, in the lead-up to Trump's third run for office, Dans visited

Washington as a non-resident fellow at the Heritage Foundation, where his brother, Paul, was leading the effort to draft a blitz of executive actions and policies that became known as Project 2025. As the election approached, Dans spoke with the Greenlandic diplomatic representative in Washington, who mentioned that he knew of a Greenlander who supported Trump: a bricklayer named Jørgen Boassen.

Boassen had been a Trump fan since 2016. “I was so tired of the élites, and of politically correct politicians,” he told me. By reading the news on social media, he had come to believe that Europe was sleepwalking into civil war, owing to the influx of Muslim migrants from Africa and the Middle East. “Denmark cannot even protect Denmark,” he said. “How can they protect us?”

In the fall of 2024, Dans wrote to Boassen on Facebook, and invited him to the U.S. They spent a week campaigning for Trump door to door in Pittsburgh, then travelled to West Palm Beach for Election Night, where Boassen shook hands with senators, billionaires, and several *MAGA* luminaries. “I also met Don, Jr., there, and I told him, ‘If you want to come to Greenland, just contact me,’ ” he recalled.

EVERY SEATING PLAN



After the election, Boassen returned to Nuuk; Dans spent the following weeks pushing his Greenland agenda, in conversations with people he knew on Trump's transition team, until it became one of Trump's central fixations. "You have to get meetings with people, you have to coach an idea, and you have to work it and sell it and help people understand why it makes sense," Dans told me. "Ultimately, it has to become their idea, not yours. There's no end to what you can accomplish in D.C. if you are willing to give other people the credit."

In early January, 2025, the right-wing activist Charlie Kirk texted Boassen and asked for help arranging a visit to Nuuk, for himself and Don, Jr. A few days later, the Trump family's Boeing 757 landed on Nuuk's new runway. Boassen was there to receive them. "That's the great irony here," Dans said, laughing. "The Chinese were the ones who, ten years ago, came and said, 'Let us build your airports and walk into your mineral deposits.' And then they got read the riot act by the U.S. side, and the Danes stepped up and found the money and built the airport—and that allowed the 757 to land and get the visuals."

An advance team came to Nuuk with a stack of *MAGA* hats. Boassen assembled a small group of people to cheer Don, Jr.'s arrival, and to join him for lunch at Nuuk's most expensive hotel. It was only after the plane left, that evening, that local journalists discovered the supporters included homeless people who had been recruited with the promise of a free meal.

"They told us that they would welcome us as part of the United States," a high-school student named Malik Dollerup-Scheibel, who ran into Don, Jr., and Kirk at a pool bar called Daddy's, told me. "And we were just, like, 'Yeah, well, it would be really strange to say that we're not welcome, since you just came *here*.' " He was handed a *MAGA* hat and photographed with Kirk and Don, Jr. "But what we didn't know was that, at the same time as we were being photographed, Donald Trump, Sr., was saying that he would take Greenland by force," Dollerup-Scheibel said. "So we were kind of manipulated. When they posted the pictures, it looked like there were so many people who liked him. But we were just friendly, and people got free beer."

Back in the U.S., Kirk went to his broadcast studio and gave an account of his few hours in Greenland. “There’s polar bears that walk around Nuuk,” he said. (There are no polar bears walking around Nuuk.) He recounted a tale of a young boy coming to him and telling him about rubies the size of baseballs. “And he says, ‘The Danes don’t let us mine our rubies, our gold, our lithium, or our gas,’ ” Kirk claimed. (Greenland has total autonomy and ownership over its natural resources.) “He said, ‘It’s time for a rebellion against the Danes.’ The younger people of Nuuk, the younger people of Greenland—they want to be rich, and, oh, my goodness, do they have wealth in Greenland. Incomprehensible amounts of wealth. We are talking that Greenland could be the new Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Russia, Permian Basin, Marcellus Shale, and the Balkan, all mixed into one. America should want those resources for our country, and Greenland should want them for their country. We’d be far more willing and able to develop them than Denmark and the socialist Greta Thunberg environmentalists from Copenhagen.”

Kirk framed the question of annexation as a matter of dignity. “They want to be part of a country that respects them, that gives them human rights,” he said. “It is the return of Manifest Destiny. Gulf of America. We’re taking back the Panama Canal, and we’re gonna do whatever it takes to have Greenland be part of the United States of America.”

In the next week or so, several Trump-friendly influencers began arriving in Nuuk. Nick Shirley asked Greenlanders what they thought about annexation on camera; the Nelk Boys handed out hundred-dollar bills to children, prompting locals to call the police. When Chris Cox showed up, Boassen served as his fixer.

Most of the propaganda wasn’t aimed at persuading Greenlanders to call for closer ties with the United States—it was focussed on convincing conservative Americans that the Greenlanders would welcome U.S. forces as liberators. An organization called Patriot Polling reported that fifty-seven per cent of Greenlanders supported joining the United States; Kirk shared the poll on X. But a Danish-Greenlandic poll found that the figure was around six per cent.

“Charlie Kirk said that there were a hundred people waiting for him at the airport with *MAGA* hats on,” Dollerup-Scheibel recalled. “I have seen

pictures from the airport. There were three.”

Trump’s territorial ambitions emboldened those of America’s adversaries. Days after Don, Jr., returned from Greenland, a Russian lawmaker and former senior military officer argued on state television that, for defensive reasons, Russia should now annex Norway’s Svalbard archipelago, where it has maintained two coal-mining settlements for almost a century. “A war has begun in the Arctic,” he said. “Trump is declaring his claims to Greenland. Why shouldn’t we look at Greenland? We need Greenland! This is not a joke. We absolutely need it!” But it was impossible to tell whether he was serious, trolling, or just revelling in the end of the rules-based international order. There was no point in dealing with the Greenlandic or Danish authorities, he said; the best way forward was to “reach an agreement with Trump, and divide Greenland into a couple of parts.”

Some Greenlandic politicians also saw the *MAGA* incursion as an opportunity for leverage. “People are beginning to understand that independence is not a question of the block grant,” Pele Broberg, the chairman of the hard-line-nationalist Naleraq Party, said. “It is only a question of whether we *want* independence.” He brushed off Trump’s annexation rhetoric as a negotiating tactic. “They are showing good will by saying, ‘Forget the economic side. We will figure that out,’ ” he said.

A young Greenlandic parliamentarian named Kuno Fencker announced his openness to entering into a defense pact with the United States, cutting Denmark out of the picture. He had read about the concept in an essay published shortly before the 2024 U.S. election, unaware that two of its authors—Tom Dans and Alexander Gray—had previously worked on covert plans for Greenland at the National Security Council. Dans seized upon Fencker’s interest, and invited him to Trump’s Inauguration. Kirk arranged tickets for Fencker and Boassen to attend the Turning Point USA Inauguration ball.

“We met many people there—Kid Rock, Ben Shapiro, Jordan Peterson, Trump’s lawyer,” Boassen recalled. By then, Boassen had started introducing himself as “Trump’s Greenlandic son.” Fencker met with White House lawyers and other Administration officials, and candidly discussed his grievances with Denmark and possible paths forward for Greenland and

the United States. Although he was travelling as a private citizen, he was apparently received and treated as a representative of the Greenlandic legislature. “It’s easy to meet people in the government or State Department or whatever,” he told me. “I met with almost three hundred people.”

In the days before the Inauguration, a group of Republican lawmakers had introduced a bill to authorize the acquisition of Greenland. “We are, quite frankly, the dominant predator,” its lead author, Representative Andy Ogles, of Tennessee, said on Fox News. Dans arranged for Fencker and Boassen to join Ogles for an interview on his social-media channels. The two Greenlanders sat in silence on either side of Ogles as he rejoiced in the prospect of more deportations and fewer rights for transgender people. “The liberal crazies are crying, and the righteous Republicans are rejoicing,” Ogles said. Then he turned to the Greenlanders and cited the dubious poll that said a majority of their compatriots supported their country being acquired by the United States.

“Our philosophy here is very American. We want to be independent,” Fencker said. But Ogles framed the affiliation with the U.S. as a foregone conclusion, and his guests did not disagree. Once Greenland joined the U.S., Ogles said, they could expect “a new tourism industry from Americans who suddenly see this as part of their homeland, as part of our territory.” Fencker shifted uncomfortably. When I met him in his office, in Nuuk, last fall, he defended his appearance as an act of unofficial diplomacy. “If you listen closely to what I say and try to have a legal hat on, you will realize that I am saying that Greenland wants to be a sovereign country,” he told me. “But we are on a diplomatic mission. How do you think that attacking the greatest power on earth, military-wise, and having a bad relationship with them—how would that go down?”

Before leaving Washington, Fencker posed for photographs with Dans and Boassen on the White House grounds. I asked him whether he was using Trump’s desire for Greenland as a cudgel against Denmark, to extract more concessions. “Of course,” he said. He added that he doesn’t necessarily want Greenland to fully break from the Kingdom of Denmark—only to be an equal partner in shaping all aspects of its future. “My visit to the White House was just a stunt. It was just to make Denmark afraid,” he said. “I was just there as a visitor, sitting in the West Wing to get a picture.”

Shortly after Fencker and Boassen left, a congressman from Georgia introduced a bill to change Greenland's name on all federal documents and maps to "Red, White, and Blueland." Alexander Gray, meanwhile, made it clear in a congressional hearing titled "Nuuk and Cranny" that he had no interest in Greenlandic self-determination on its own terms. "The security stakes are simply too high to allow Greenland to obtain independence without a plan in place for the U.S. to insure our core strategic interests are assured," he said.

Drew Horn—the former Special Forces commander who had co-led the Greenland P.C.C.—set out to become a conduit between American financing and struggling Greenlandic businesses. He had left the public sector in early 2021, after Trump failed to overturn the election, and had formed a strategic-minerals advisory firm with the intermittent backing and guidance of former senior defense and intelligence officials, as well as from Trump's former head of security and one of Trump's lawyers. Horn announced that he would travel to Greenland on behalf of his investors, and that he planned to "support the country's pursuit of independence." "If Greenland wants independence and inclusion in North America, the private funding exists to make it a reality," he wrote on LinkedIn.

In Nuuk, Horn dined multiple times with Pele Broberg, the head of the Naleraq Party. Horn—whose résumé notes his training and expertise in "Unconventional Warfare"—insisted that he was just acting as a businessman. But his background aroused suspicion in Nuuk, though Danish and Greenlandic officials were still unaware of the Greenland P.C.C.'s existence, and of his role as its leader. "We call him Rambo," a senior Greenlandic official told me. In 2024, a documentary about a botched mercenary coup in Venezuela revealed that, while serving in Trump's first Administration, Horn had dined with the leader of the operation—a fellow former U.S. Special Forces soldier—and remained abreast of its progress. In messages with the lead mercenary, Horn repeatedly claimed to be engaging U.S. government departments on the man's behalf. The coup ended with the slaughter or imprisonment of most of its participants. (Horn declined to comment about this.)

In Nuuk, Horn appeared to be positioning himself to profit in the event of an American annexation. "He is trying to make himself the center of whatever

happens,” the senior Greenlandic official told me. “Everybody is trying to find out what he is doing, what he is saying. And then he just changes the subject.”



In March, 2025, as Greenlanders prepared to vote in their parliamentary elections, Horn’s firm put out a press release for “stakeholders” that laid out a path to Greenlandic independence. “The majority of the Greenlandic Parliament today is controlled by pro-independence parties,” the press release noted. Horn anticipated a landslide for those parties, followed by a rapid break from Denmark, with an initial referendum triggered within a month. Trump assured Greenlanders that, if they became independent, his government stood “ready to INVEST BILLIONS OF DOLLARS to create new jobs and MAKE YOU RICH.”

Horn’s assessment wasn’t unreasonable; it was based on recent statements by Greenlandic politicians. But he had misjudged the effects of Trump’s rhetoric, and perhaps of his own. When Greenlanders went to the polls, a plurality of the votes went to a center-right party that had never previously won a Greenlandic election and, in light of ongoing threats, favored the status quo. In the following weeks, it formed a coalition government whose organizing principle was its opposition to American aggression. Only Naleraq, whose leadership wanted to initiate the independence process

immediately, was excluded from the coalition. “We shall choose our partners ourselves,” the coalition agreement read. “It is we who dictate the pace.”

In *MAGA* circles, the elections were falsely framed as a victory for Trump. “The pro-Denmark party got first, but the pro-United States party got its best-ever result,” Charlie Kirk said on his broadcast, the following day. “This election shows that the pro-American forces are ascendant in Greenland, and it should be partnered with America, not the Old World,” Kirk added. “This would be nothing but upside for the great people of Greenland.” Like Trump, he focussed on money: “You will be wealthier. You will be richer. You will have the U.S. dollar. You will have more purchasing power.”

Each spring, Greenland’s dogsledding association hosts a national race. “This is somewhere between Nascar’s Daytona 500 and Super Bowl Sunday,” Tom Dans told me. “It’s a massive logistical undertaking. You’ve got three hundred-plus dogs, you’ve got mushers, and you’ve got their support people coming in from nineteen remote locations in northern Greenland, all in the dead of winter. So we thought, Why don’t we make a little Arctic exercise out of this, and get some Chinooks, and help them bring the dogs in?”

Dans pitched his idea to the White House and the Pentagon: part influence operation, part military exercise. “Nobody was saying no,” he told me. The plan was to deploy Chinook helicopters from the Army’s 160th Special Operations Aviation Regiment, the top airborne unit for high-risk Special Operations Forces raids. The use of the Night Stalkers, as the unit is known, to shuttle dogsleds around Greenland would demonstrate, as Dans put it, “the capability that the U.S. had to really help this, in a kind of exciting, peacetime format.” Dans suggested that the dogsledding association invite the U.S. Secretary of Defense, Pete Hegseth, to the race. But to Mikkel Jeremiassen, the head of the association, the invitation seemed like a condition that would “grant us access,” as he later put it, to helicopter support from the Night Stalkers. Jeremiassen drafted a letter to Hegseth, and sought assistance from the Greenlandic ministry of culture in getting it to Hegseth through official channels. But the ministry declined the request on technical grounds, since the island’s political parties had not yet formed their coalition.

Instead, the White House announced that Usha Vance, Vice-President J. D. Vance's wife, would attend the dogsled race with one of her sons, and visit Nuuk as a tourist. "She's a very nice woman, and she loves the concept of Greenland, so she is going there," Trump said. Two U.S. military-transport planes delivered an advance security team, which drove around Nuuk in armored black S.U.V.s, and Denmark deployed around seventy police officers to maintain public order. But the Second Lady's visit was abruptly cancelled. "American representatives have been walking around, practically knocking on one door after another in the past few days, to ask if people might be interested in a visit from the Vice-President's wife," a Danish TV correspondent in Nuuk reported. "Everywhere, the answer was the same: 'No, thanks.'"

The Administration framed it differently. "There was so much excitement around Usha's visit to Greenland this Friday that I decided that I didn't want her to have all that fun by herself," J. D. Vance said, in a video announcing the change of plans. He added that he and Usha would visit Pituffik Space Base, alongside Trump's national-security adviser and the U.S. Energy Secretary. (Usha's touristic visits were cancelled.) "A lot of other countries have threatened Greenland, have threatened to use its territories and its waterways to threaten the United States, to threaten Canada, and, of course, to threaten the people of Greenland, so we're going to check out how things are going there," Vance said.

By then, European leaders were losing faith in the transatlantic alliance. No other countries were threatening to take over Greenland—only the United States. Jarlov, who was serving as the head of the Danish parliament's defense committee, raised concerns about Europe's reliance on U.S.-manufactured weapons systems and fighter jets. "I don't know if there is a kill switch in the F35's or not," he wrote on X, in response to the Pentagon's claim that there was no such thing. "We obviously can not take your word for it. As one of the decision makers behind Denmark's purchase of F35's, I regret it." He added, "I can easily imagine a situation where the USA will demand Greenland from Denmark and will threaten to deactivate our weapons and let Russia attack us when we refuse."

On March 28, 2025, Vance landed at Pituffik Space Base, where he repeated the fantasy that Russia and China were attempting "a lot of very aggressive

incursions” in Greenland. He also berated Denmark. “The President said we have to have Greenland,” he said. “We can’t just *ignore* the President’s desires!”

Spring turned to summer. The White House appeared to focus on other matters, and the ice began to melt. But, for a former senior Danish defense-intelligence officer named Jacob Kaarsbo, the good weather carried with it a deeper concern: the easiest time to annex Greenland would be in the summer.

In May, 2025, I met Kaarsbo for a walk along a pier near Copenhagen. A few days earlier, the *Wall Street Journal* had reported that Trump’s director of National Intelligence, Tulsi Gabbard, had tasked America’s spy agencies—including the Central Intelligence Agency, the National Security Agency, and the Defense Intelligence Agency—with identifying people in Greenland and Denmark who supported Trump’s aims. The staff of *Sermitsiaq* had taken to leaving their phones outside editorial meetings, for fear of eavesdropping by the United States. A recent survey by the Center for Public Health in Greenland noted a more than fourfold increase, in the past year, in the percentage of Greenlanders who show symptoms of psychological distress. Eighty-two per cent of respondents reported that Trump’s annexation rhetoric negatively affects their everyday lives. One in four said that they have difficulty sleeping.

Most Danish and Greenlandic contacts I met with were reluctant to speak publicly. Some asked me to leave my phone at my hotel. A prominent Danish historian told me his thoughts, then asked me to not report them, lest he be perceived as speaking for Greenlanders. One of his Greenlandic colleagues offered his own thoughts, then similarly retracted, lest his assertions affect Greenland’s new position of leverage.

Kaarsbo—who had spent fifteen years working alongside Americans in Iraq and Afghanistan—was not too concerned about professional spies. Most Greenlandic political discourse takes place on Facebook, among small groups of people who write in Greenlandic and know one another by family and name; when, in the spring of 2025, a new Facebook account appeared and started polling Greenlanders on their opinions about the United States, it was instantly identified by locals as a likely influence operation. “The

Administration may put pressure on the rank and file, but I would assume that a lot of them will try to do their job to a bare minimum,” Kaarsbo told me. “And some of them will just quit. The problem is that they will be able to find some idiots who will do anything to get ahead.” Although the U.S. diplomatic mission in Nuuk operated out of the small red cabin that served as the consulate, the American government was preparing to move it to a thirty-thousand-square-foot office space in one of Nuuk’s largest buildings, right in the center of town. “The new consulate could hold three hundred” staffers, Kaarsbo said. “What the fuck is that all about? In a community of fifty-seven thousand people, there should be a maximum of ten.”

Last spring, Hegseth was asked in a congressional hearing whether the Department of Defense had a plan “to take Greenland and Panama by force, if necessary.”

“Our job at the Defense Department is to have plans for any particular contingency,” Hegseth replied.

“Including the contingency of basically invading Denmark?”

“Any contingency you need, we’ve got it.”

To Kaarsbo, the absurdity was partly reassuring. “People just think, Oh, they’ll take it over, there’s nothing we can do,” he said. “But I think it’s unlikely that the Trump Administration could carry out a large plan for an amphibious assault without it getting leaked,” and thus becoming a catastrophic political scandal in the United States before the first ships reached Nuuk. Instead, Kaarsbo worried about a “quick-and-dirty takeover,” as he put it—“the 2 *A.M.* version, where a couple of planes with a flight plan that says ‘Pituffik’ suddenly veer toward Nuuk. A couple of hundred Special Forces take over the capital, take over the airport, take over parliament, and so on.” But such a scenario is not impossible to deter. “If we get a small European force up there under the pretext of military exercises—and say to Trump, ‘You’re right, we should take Arctic security very seriously, and so we’ve decided to start these exercises to deter China and Russia’—then, suddenly, the quick-and-dirty annexation is not so easy.”

It was against this backdrop that Drew Horn returned to Nuuk to visit a mining prospect in southern Greenland called Tanbreez. “As the only shovel ready rare earth project in Greenland, Tanbreez represents a game-changing opportunity for both the Greenlandic economy and the critical minerals supply chain in North America and Europe,” he said, in a press release. But the story didn’t quite add up. Horn named Naaja Nathanielsen, then Greenland’s mining minister, as one of his recent points of contact—but she insists that they have never spoken.

“Drew Horn came into our office and said that he was representing the Tanbreez mine,” the senior Greenlandic official told me. But, since Horn’s name wasn’t on the license, the official called the mine’s owner at the time, an Australian named Greg Barnes. “And Greg Barnes said, ‘No, he’s got nothing to do with us,’ ” the official recalled.

Horn has visited Greenland four times since Trump’s second Inauguration. In some ways, he appears highly connected; his former business partner and chief geologist is now the director of the U.S. Geological Survey. But in Nuuk his self-presentation frequently collided with reality. “He said that he was representing all kinds of people and organizations,” the senior Greenlandic official told me. “We called the U.S. State Department and said, ‘We’ve had this guy fooling around here in Greenland, saying this and that,’ and they said that they had nothing to do with him.”

Marbles



Horn told Markus Valentin, a Danish reporter at the Greenlandic public broadcaster, that he and his colleagues in the private sector wanted to invest ten billion dollars in Greenlandic businesses “as soon as possible.” Reuters recently reported that, while pitching a prominent Greenlandic businessman on investment, Horn repeatedly paused “to respond to e-mails he said were from Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Commerce Secretary Lutnick.” Horn denies this, though it’s unclear whether he was inflating his connections to impress the Greenlandic businessman or is now downplaying them to protect senior White House officials. He told me and other journalists that, after each trip, he briefed members of the Administration on what he’d found.

Greenlandic mining concessions are open to international investment; there is no need to annex the island to pursue its natural resources. The problem is that the costs of logistics, infrastructure, poor weather, and bureaucracy, in this remote Arctic environment, exceed the value of whatever can be pulled from the ground. “We have looked at Greenland—we have been exploring it for fifteen years,” a mining executive told CNBC last year. “We have never been able to come up with a profitable project.”

I asked Horn whether the Trump Administration sees Greenland’s rare-earth sites like the Russians see their two coal-mining towns in Svalbard:

something to maintain at a perpetual loss—the cost of strategic presence. Each unprofitable Greenlandic mining concession that is bought up by an American entity is one that is no longer susceptible to such an investment by the Chinese. “No, they’re looking to turn a profit,” Horn said. But, in a recent podcast interview, he acknowledged that the United States has more rare-earth minerals than it could ever need. “We’ve just tied our hands to permitting,” he said. If the United States simply extracted and processed the contents of its own deposits, he added, “we could be, like, a net exporter for forever.”

At around 1 *A.M.* on January 3, 2026, Chinook helicopters and pilots from the Special Operations aviation regiment that Tom Dans had tried to deploy to Greenland flew Delta Force soldiers into Caracas and kidnapped the Venezuelan President. “He got bum-rushed so fast,” Trump, who’d watched the raid from Mar-a-Lago, said. He added that the U.S. would now “run the country” and take its oil. “We’re going to be taking out a tremendous amount of wealth out of the ground,” he said. “American dominance in the Western Hemisphere will never be questioned again.” Hours after the strike, Katie Miller—a former White House official who is married to Stephen Miller, Trump’s homeland-security adviser—posted to X a map of Greenland overlaid with the American flag, with a one-word caption: “SOON.”

“We do need Greenland, absolutely,” Trump said the next day. He and his acolytes were practically giddy from the success of the Caracas raid, and started listing other places they’d like to invade: Cuba, Colombia, Iran. “By what right does Denmark assert control over Greenland?” Stephen Miller asked on CNN. “Nobody’s going to fight the United States militarily over the future of Greenland.”

In the following days, Denmark and seven other European nations deployed troops to Greenland. The Danes carried live ammunition and explosives, and prepared to blow up Greenland’s runways to slow any possible invasion. They also carried fresh blood packs, in case of casualties, and were operating under standing orders to shoot at any invading forces. There was no concrete evidence of a planned U.S. attack, or any expectation that Denmark and its allies could fend one off for very long. The idea, as one

European source involved with the planning told me, was merely “to raise the cost.”

Greenlanders were terrified; some have since moved to Denmark. The Greenlandic government scrambled to reassure locals, informing them that Danish and other European troops would now be a permanent fixture on the island. “If we have to choose between the United States and Denmark, here and now, we choose Denmark,” the Greenlandic Prime Minister, Jens-Frederik Nielsen, said. “We choose *NATO*. We choose the Kingdom of Denmark. We choose the E.U.”

Later that day, Trump was asked about Nielsen’s remarks. “I don’t know who he is,” Trump said. “Don’t know anything about him. But that’s going to be a big problem for him.”

Trump understood the message of force, however. He announced that every European nation that had deployed troops to Greenland would face new ten-per-cent tariffs—and that the tariffs would rise to twenty-five per cent on June 1st if the United States had not reached a deal “for the Complete and Total purchase of Greenland” by that date. “It is time for Denmark to give back,” he posted on Truth Social. “World Peace is at stake!”

Four days later, at the World Economic Forum, in Davos, Switzerland, Mark Rutte, a Dutch politician who serves as the secretary-general of *NATO*, spoke to Trump and defused the situation. Trump claimed that they had reached a “framework of a future deal.” Greenlandic and Danish politicians noted that Rutte has no authority to negotiate on their behalf. But, whatever Rutte said to Trump, the President dropped the tariffs and the threatening rhetoric, for the time being, and then tied up the U.S. military by going to war with Iran.

“Greenland is behind us,” Senator Lindsey Graham said, at the Munich Security Conference, in mid-February. “Who gives a shit who owns Greenland? I don’t. So, the point is, Greenland is going to be more fortified, because Donald Trump—once he feels like it’s his brand, or he has some buy-in—is going to go big.” The next day, in a bizarre closed-door meeting with the Danish and Greenlandic premiers, Graham addressed Mette

Frederiksen, Denmark's Prime Minister, as "little lady," and loudly yawned in Nielsen's face.

Chris Cox, the founder of Bikers for Trump, has not returned to Greenland since his visit last March. But he has made a couple of appearances as a Greenland expert on One America News Network, where he spews inaccurate anti-Danish propaganda and has been falsely presented to viewers as having lived in Nuuk for most of last year.

Drew Horn returned to Greenland in February—just after the talk of invasion died down. He appears to have shelved his interest in mining there, and is now hoping to build a large data center in the sparsely populated settlement of Kangerlussuaq, where there is a Danish military station and the longest commercial runway in Greenland.

Tom Dans was appointed by Trump as the chair of the United States Arctic Research Commission in December. When I met him for lunch in Washington, earlier this year, he declined to speak further on the record, except to articulate a narrow, symbiotic vision for the future: "My view is that the United States could take all the seafood Greenland could produce, and cut out the middleman, and keep it from China—and you could bring back all-you-can-eat shrimp at Red Lobster."

Jørgen Boassen joined us a few minutes later. He had left Greenland for the U.S. last fall, his life style funded by anonymous American benefactors. When I was in Nuuk, I was told by several people that Boassen was known for groping women and getting into drunken fights. (Boassen denies any such acts.) He has been banned from several venues, including a swimming pool, a martial-arts club, and the hotel where he'd brought Don, Jr. "I am the last revolutionary fighter," Boassen told me. While Danish troops were preparing to defend Greenland, he attended a gathering at the Kennedy Center, at which Andy Ogles and other Republican lawmakers sliced into a Greenland-shaped cake.

In Washington, the Danish and Greenlandic governments are quietly engaged in a process of negotiation with the White House. The U.S. plans to reopen some of its long-abandoned bases in Greenland—an outcome that would have been welcomed by both Greenland and Denmark until recently,

and that could have been achieved under the existing 1951 treaty. But there are new points of contention. According to the *Times*, the Americans want veto power over foreign investment interest in Greenland. Another disagreement appears to be over the matter of territorial sovereignty. “We can’t be constrained by notions of leasing bases and that sort of thing,” Robert O’Brien, the former national-security adviser, told me. “We can’t have a situation like we’ve seen during this Iran operation, where certain governments aren’t giving permission to use bases. We can’t have that in Greenland. It’s just too essential to the defense of the homeland.”

I pointed out that no one in Greenland owns land: individuals merely apply for permission to build homes and businesses. If the United States took sovereignty over its bases, its military would be the only entity that owns land in the country, a matter that Jens-Frederik Nielsen has called a red line. “To give up territory, to give up self-determination, to give up the right to one’s own land—whether it is only the size of a postage stamp or more—we cannot do that,” Nielsen said. “We will not do that.”

But O’Brien, like his former boss, was unconcerned by the opinions of the people who live in Greenland. “They may understand the cycle of life better,” he told me. “But the lawyers will work out how the territory gets titled.”

In February, Boassen travelled to Louisiana, where he was hosted by the governor, Jeff Landry, whom Trump had recently named on Truth Social as his special envoy to Greenland. (Landry’s appointment came as a surprise to Denmark, Greenland, and the State Department, and circumvented congressional confirmation requirements.) At dinner, Boassen complained to Landry about the state of the Greenlandic health-care system. “It is a death sentence to get sick in Greenland,” he said.

In the following days, Landry dined with Trump, who took to Truth Social to announce that he was sending “a great hospital boat to Greenland to take care of the many people who are sick, and not being taken care of there.” The post was accompanied by an illustration of a U.S. Navy hospital ship, the *Mercy*. “It’s on the way!!!”

Danish and Greenlandic officials quickly rejected the offer. “We have a public health-care system where treatment is free for citizens,” Nielsen said. “Please talk to us instead of just making more or less random statements on social media.”

Landry was incensed. “Shame on Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen!” he wrote on X. “President @realDonaldTrump and America care.” But the Navy didn’t deploy the *Mercy*; the ship was undergoing scheduled maintenance, alongside the Navy’s only other hospital ship, at an Alabama shipyard.

Last month, Landry showed up at a business conference in Nuuk. Upon his arrival, he shared with reporters his instructions from the President: “He said, ‘Go over there and make a bunch of friends—as many friends as we can.’ ” He also brought along a doctor who claimed to have come to “assess the medical needs” in Greenland—though this doctor had not reached out to the health ministry.

For the next three days, Landry wandered around Nuuk, with Boassen as his fixer, and tried to hand out *MAGA* hats. “If you come to Louisiana and you come to the governor’s mansion? All the chocolate-chip cookies you could eat,” he told a group of boys. Another boy apparently asked if Landry was famous.

“I don’t know if he’s famous, but he’s the governor of Louisiana,” Landry’s wife, Sharon, said.

“Do you want to take a picture?” Landry asked.

“No,” the boy replied.

Landry abandoned the business conference within half an hour of its start. “We have our red lines,” Nielsen, who looked exhausted, told the Danish national broadcaster. “No matter how many chocolate cookies we get, we are not going to change them.”

The day after Landry left Greenland, the new U.S. consulate opened in the center of Nuuk. American officials and businessmen ate musk-ox hot dogs

and discussed their ambitions for Greenland's future. Hundreds of Greenlanders protested outside.

Rasmus Jarlov, whose term in parliament had just ended, called for the consulate to be shut down immediately. "It is utterly insane that we allow their presence," he wrote on X. "The new, very large American consulate in Nuuk has one clear mission and task, and that is to pave the way for an American takeover." The policy of treating the United States as the ally it once was has merely paved the way for more subversion. "The only thing that has worked," Jarlov emphasized, "was when we, along with our allies, made it clear that we would rather go to war with the United States than let them have Greenland." ♦

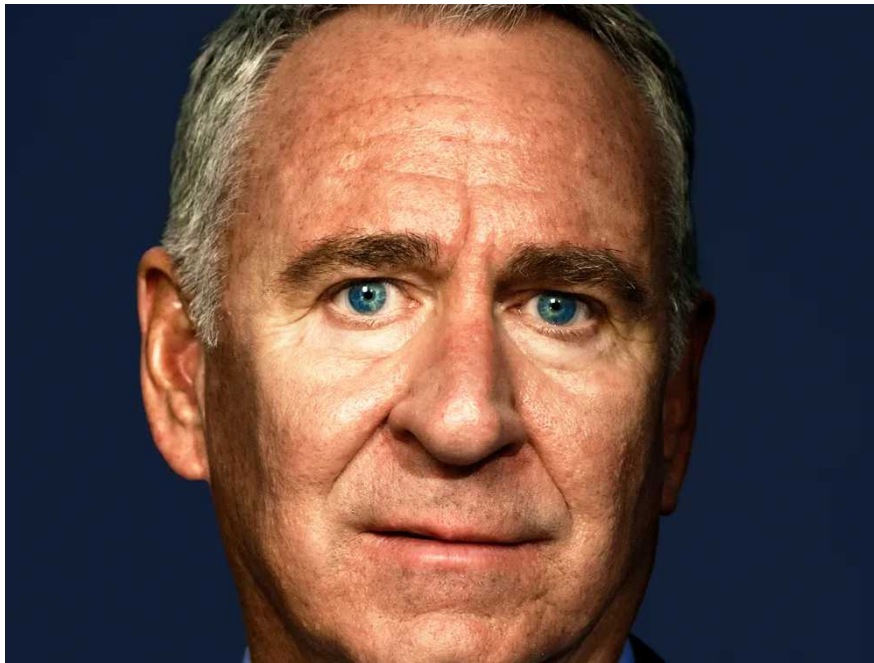
Profiles

Ken Griffin's Billions and Billions

The hedge-fund titan is an unabashed big spender, from pièds-a-terre to politics.

By Gary Sernovitz

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When Zohran Mamdani, the mayor of New York City, recently filmed a one-minute video to announce a tax on pièds-à-terre, his appetite for class warfare was on full display. Background music evoked the “Succession” theme, underlining that he was taking on wily tycoons. He stood across the street from the building that housed the most expensive home ever sold in the United States—a four-floor penthouse on Central Park South, which was purchased in 2019 for two hundred and thirty-eight million dollars. Its owner, Mamdani noted, was the “hedge-fund C.E.O. Ken Griffin”—one of the “richest of the rich, those who store their wealth in New York City real estate but who don’t actually *live* here.”

Griffin, who lives in Miami, was an obvious target. He is, by far, the most successful Wall Street entrepreneur of his generation. Worth about fifty

billion dollars, he founded Citadel, one of the biggest hedge funds in the world, and Citadel Securities, a hugely profitable “market maker”—a company that generates billions of dollars each year by handling countless orders to buy and sell stocks, options, and bonds. In the past decade, Griffin, who is fifty-seven, has also become a public figure, known throughout Wall Street as just “Ken.” He regularly speaks at elite conferences and at business schools, on topics as varied as trading, the economy, patriotism, charter schools, and the Iran war. A Reaganite Republican, he has praised President Donald Trump for his policies on border security, deregulation, and taxes while also calling Trump’s tariffs “anti-growth” and expressing concern about “decisions or courses that have been very, very enriching to the families of those in the Administration.” Griffin’s self-positioning as a conservative businessman who’s more rational and ethical than the President has fuelled speculation about his own political ambitions.

His response to Mamdani’s provocation showed him to be in equal command of the American outrage machine. The press obtained an internal e-mail written by Citadel’s C.O.O., Gerald Beeson, who implied that the two Citadel businesses might cancel plans to build a new skyscraper in New York, where they have nearly twenty-five hundred employees. (The New York *Post* ran a flurry of alarmist headlines, even though Beeson was surely bluffing: Citadel consumes new traders as voraciously as Starbucks consumes beans, and has long had its largest employee presence in Manhattan.) Then the plutocrats circled their yachts. The Washington *Post* opinion page, operating under the new editorial direction laid out by Griffin’s friend Jeff Bezos, called Mamdani’s video “unethical.” Steven Roth, a co-developer of the proposed Citadel tower, on Park Avenue, argued that Mamdani’s video had singled Griffin “out for ridicule”—and condemned the Mayor for using the slogan “Tax the rich,” which he said was just as “hateful as some disgusting racial slurs.” (Griffin clearly appreciated the backup. Last week, he told me, “It has been good to see the business community in New York find its voice.”)

Mamdani retreated, a little bit. He praised Griffin for a donation to a 9/11 memorial for New York City police officers, and his press secretary declared that the Mayor wants all New Yorkers to succeed—including Griffin, “who is a major employer in our city.” But Griffin wasn’t finished exploiting the controversy. At a conference in Beverly Hills organized by his friend

Michael Milken, the former junk-bond king, Griffin said that the *pieds-à-terre* video had put him “in harm’s way,” and noted that “the C.E.O. of UnitedHealthcare was killed just a few blocks from my house.” Griffin didn’t mention that his purchase of the Central Park South apartment was famous long before Mamdani’s video, or that he owns at least eleven residences worldwide—including adjoining co-ops on Park Avenue and four spreads in Florida. At the conference, Griffin said that Mamdani’s video was “triggering of the trauma I went through in Chicago,” where Citadel was originally headquartered. He’d had a noisy feud with liberal politicians in Illinois, increasingly over crime in Chicago, and this led him to move the headquarters of Citadel and Citadel Securities to Miami in 2022.

Several months before the Mamdani drama, I travelled to Miami and met with Griffin at a temporary office a few blocks from where he plans to build Citadel’s new headquarters, designed by the firm of the celebrity architect Lord Norman Foster. We sat down in the kind of white, sunlit, blandly expensive space where an aspiring trader might interview for a job. Griffin is very comfortable in such rooms—he estimates that he’s interviewed ten thousand people. Part of what makes Griffin different, however, is that he’s barely ever had to interview for a job himself. Lloyd Blankfein, the former C.E.O. of Goldman Sachs, who is a friend of Griffin’s, told me that he still can’t figure out “who mentored him—to whom he has a debt.” It’s a rare quality on Wall Street, which traces its heroes by the lineage of their strategies. Griffin started trading convertible bonds in his dorm room while studying at Harvard in the late eighties, then launched Citadel in Chicago in 1990, a year after graduating.

I asked Griffin to name which hedge-fund “ancestors” he’d modelled himself on. For seven seconds, he regarded me in silence. New Citadel employees learn not to fill in those pauses. Griffin’s blue eyes are unsettlingly bright. Colleagues debate, half in jest, about whether he lacks the normal need to blink.

Finally, he responded. “When I was in college, I wanted to be in private equity,” he said. He named one of the titans of that field: “Henry Kravis—that was the mission.” I pressed him to cite someone who had influenced him in the world of hedge funds—the investment firms that emerged in the nineteen-fifties with trading strategies designed to offer wealthy clients

exclusivity, higher returns, and lower risks. Griffin dodged the question with a feeble joke. Early in his career, he said, whenever he told someone that he worked at a hedge fund, the response “was, literally, ‘Do you use shrubs or bushes?’ ”

There are many precursors Griffin could have cited. In the nineties, George Soros became famous for shorting the British pound. At the time, Soros, along with the financiers Julian Robertson and Michael Steinhardt, defined the public image of hedge-fund managers as investment wizards who made fortunes through huge bets, contrarian calls, iron stomachs, and a willingness to operate close to—or over—the regulatory line. Griffin became a leader of the next generation in part by aggressively automating college-level math to analyze trades. But he knows that he’s not a mathematical genius on the order of Jim Simons or David Shaw—pioneering “quants” who harnessed computing power to extract money from the markets. Nor did Griffin mention the other phylum of modern Wall Street, the descendants of Warren Buffett and Charlie Munger: the virtuosos of the long-term pick who identify stocks trading at sensible prices and let them compound for years.

Griffin has never pretended to be a radical innovator or a savant. His mission has always been different: to build finance businesses that update their strategies and infrastructure so relentlessly that they beat rivals not just today but over decades. Paradoxically, maintaining a consistent edge requires constant, unsentimental internal change—of processes, technology, and people. Citadel takes ideas that are just beginning to circulate and improves them, with math or technology or data that others haven’t thought to use. As Griffin once acknowledged, “If there are a thousand things that make Citadel special, there will be very few that are actually truly unique and bespoke to Citadel.” Before the millennium, for example, Citadel embraced the emerging technique of “event-driven” trading—strategies crafted to take advantage of major corporate news such as merger deals, bankruptcies, or regulations. In 2014, after many other traders had adopted event-driven trading, Citadel paused the practice.



All this churn has been guided by Griffin's fear that everything he's built is fragile—the most impressive sandcastle on the beach. His longtime deputy, James Yeh, who is now retired, told me, “If you talk to a hundred executives, ninety per cent of them will tell you, ‘We’re never satisfied with what we’ve done before, we always want to do better, you can’t rest on your laurels, and you’d better constantly try to improve.’ But ninety-nine per cent of them don’t actually *mean* it. Ken actually means it.”

Given that Griffin lacks a signature trading or investing style, his achievements can feel both confounding and imitable. But nobody has duplicated his monetary success—or built two separate businesses that are so wildly profitable. Citadel's fund now manages sixty-eight billion dollars, more than nineteen billion of which is Griffin's and his colleagues' own money. Although Griffin doesn't directly run Citadel Securities, he is its non-executive chairman and owns at least seventy-five per cent of it. That business trades more than a hundred and seventy trillion dollars a year for institutional clients and retail investors. In 2025, it generated \$12.2 billion in revenue on those trades and \$5.4 billion in net income. *Bloomberg* estimates that Citadel Securities accounts for nearly half of Griffin's net worth, which has tripled in the past six years. (Being the top man on Wall Street makes him only the world's thirty-seventh-richest person, according to *Forbes*—well behind the six tech giants who top the chart.)

In an era in which income inequality is a source of increasing political and social concern, Griffin is an unabashed big spender. For him, half a billion dollars is a basic unit of currency. He spent that much for twenty-seven acres in Palm Beach; for the joint purchase of a Jackson Pollock and a Willem de Kooning; in gifts to Harvard; and in political contributions, mostly to conservative candidates. He dropped a mere forty-five million on a stegosaurus skeleton, called Apex, which is now on loan to the American Museum of Natural History (though “the dream,” Griffin told me, “is one day she’ll be in Miami”).

Griffin may decide that running for political office is a bet he’s not willing to make: a Harvard man with a hedge fund and a house on the French Riviera might unite people across parties in distaste. Then again, he has the cunning and the means to update his image, and he remains ambitious. He told me, “I take great joy in problem-solving. If there was a moment that came to pass where those skills would be of crucial importance for our country, of course I would look to be involved.”

Kenneth Griffin was born in Daytona Beach, Florida, in 1968. His mother, Cathy, was just two years out of high school in Libertyville, Illinois, where she had been the student-council president. Ken was the first of three children. Cathy, a housewife, had contemplated becoming a teacher, Griffin told me. “She changed the mobile over my crib every week when I was a baby,” he said. “She read somewhere you’d be more curious.” (Griffin suggested to me that he’d never lost his curiosity. He also added this flourish: “Maybe I never grew up.”)

Griffin’s father, Don, worked in the space program at General Electric. Job offers led him and the family to suburban Milwaukee and Midland, Texas; finally, they relocated to Boca Raton, Florida, where he became the C.F.O. of a roof-tile manufacturer. Griffin recently addressed students at Boca Raton Community High School, his alma mater, and recounted that he’d learned to code after negotiating with his parents for an I.B.M. personal computer. In high school, he took part in high-achiever activities—math team, a community-service group—but he was also an entrepreneur, selling software from various vendors to students and teachers.

At college, Griffin could code as well as many computer-science majors, but he studied economics and government, writing a thesis on shareholder returns in corporate takeovers. He graduated in three years, using A.P. credits from high school—an unusual move at Harvard, though most students there could have done the same. He was dating a young woman from Boca, Katherine Weingart; they married when he was twenty-two and divorced four years later. (Griffin is now twice divorced and unmarried. He has three children.)

Around the time Griffin was in college, three books were published which became the modern Wall Street canon—“Liar’s Poker,” by Michael Lewis; “Barbarians at the Gate,” by Bryan Burrough and John Helyar; and “The Bonfire of the Vanities,” by Tom Wolfe. These books could be gimlet-eyed about the follies of finance, but they also glamorized new paths to riches, from leveraged buyouts to bond securitization. According to Alex Slusky, a college friend of Griffin’s and later a private-equity investor, most aspiring financiers at Harvard “just wanted a job.” Griffin had a different plan: “To build something of significance in finance using technology.”

He started trading in 1986, and, he told me, made five thousand dollars on one transaction involving Home Shopping Network options. But he said it bothered him that the market maker who bought the options, though his profits were relatively small, had a much higher “quality of earnings”: whereas Griffin was taking risky bets, the market maker was generating a reliable cash flow. Griffin’s frustration led him to try to find a way to achieve higher-quality earnings himself. At the Harvard Business School library, he taught himself derivatives pricing and trading theory, and by 1989 he’d settled on convertible arbitrage as his method of choice—buying a company bond that could be converted to stock while simultaneously shorting the company’s stock. At the time, this strategy was being pursued by only a few banks and about a dozen hedge funds, even though you could do the math with pen and paper.

Griffin called up First Boston, an investment bank, and asked a salesperson how it handled convertible arbitrage. The salesperson, Griffin remembers, said, “We don’t do this with any *customers*. We do this with the firm’s money.” To Griffin, “that was a light-switch-on moment.” He got Harvard’s permission to install a satellite dish atop his dormitory, Cabot House, so that

his I.B.M. could get real-time trading data. Touting himself as part of a new money-management firm, he raised more than a million dollars, from a Palm Beach retiree, his grandmother, and others. He programmed his computer to price equity-linked securities, allowing him to assess value better than many professionals. And yet, the origin of Griffin's empire was neither the satellite dish nor the coding but, rather, the idea of seeking out higher-quality earnings not yet being widely pursued.

Griffin founded Citadel in Chicago because he'd received an investment from Glenwood, a firm that staked small hedge funds, and he liked Glenwood's gruff Chicago-based partner, Frank Meyer. Hedge funds were then in their second of three Cambrian explosions; according to one estimate, a thousand new funds formed following the 1987 stock-market crash. Hedge funds are most attractive to investors when the over-all market performs poorly, as bruised investors seek ways to protect themselves against another crash by putting their money in the hands of people supposedly expert at managing risk.

Meyer advised Griffin to make two moves that were cheeky for a new fund managing only four and a half million dollars: first, adopt multiple investment strategies; second, charge "pass-through" fees to investors, requiring them to cover Citadel's expenses as incurred, rather than having them pay the traditional fixed management fee of two per cent. This allowed Citadel to spend more aggressively on people and technology in pursuit of higher returns. Griffin's carried-interest take of the fund's annual gains remained more than twenty per cent.

The early Citadel had an improvised feel. With little money or reputation, Griffin often hired inexperienced people who had impressed him in interviews, including Yeh, a graduate student in theoretical physics, and Beeson, a cop's son who had studied accounting on a scholarship at DePaul. (Beeson became Citadel's C.O.O. in 2008.) The firm was a nerdy, all-hours place. Griffin himself had coded a trading model for employees to use on Sun workstations. By Yeh's estimate, the math used in the model was five years ahead of the market. The I.T. staff made up more than a quarter of the head count. Julio DePietro, an early hire who later became a partner, and who helped come up with the name Citadel, told me that traders sometimes

rewarded themselves at the end of the day with “teeny Pounders,” a McDonald’s Quarter Pounder cut into fourths.



Griffin obsessively monitored his competitors’ moves. Yeh recalled to me that, at one point, Griffin theatrically presented him with a piece of paper bearing a number: the profit David Shaw’s firm had made through a new technique called statistical arbitrage, or stat arb. It was a bonanza.

“What the hell is stat arb?” Yeh asked.

“I’m not really sure,” Griffin admitted. But, he continued, it involved “numbers and formulas and computers,” all of which were part of Yeh’s physics background. Griffin told Yeh to choose one other colleague for a new team that would learn by doing. Citadel started trading stat arb about six months later.

“I do enjoy understanding what systems we need to build,” Griffin told me. “I am willing to get my hands dirty with all kinds of details that in some sense would often be viewed as not belonging on the radar of a C.E.O.” At one point, Griffin moved his office away from the trading desk, but he kept going back over to look at traders’ screens. An early employee told me, “We used to joke—is the dragon in the cave, or is he out?”

Citadel has never publicly codified how it achieves “alpha”—outperforming the market. But my conversations with Griffin and twenty-eight of his current and former employees revealed that they had consistent tenets. The output of Citadel’s factory is alpha. Every aspect of the factory must be constantly improved, and to accomplish this everyone must forage for information. The purpose of every improvement is to minimize unknown risk so that Citadel can maximize intentional risk. The biggest risk of all is complacency. The objective is not just profit but victory over rivals.

An ongoing challenge is that every idea that beats an efficient market eventually becomes stale. You can scour the world for better weather forecasts to make bets on the cold snaps that affect natural-gas prices, but if you are successful other funds will start doing the same. Griffin sponges up intel wherever he can find it. A former underling told me that Griffin, after reading a *PCMag* article about the differences between Advanced Micro Devices and Intel chips, asked why the underling wasn’t recommending A.M.D. chips for the company’s servers. Griffin is still so up to date on technological wonkery that he is Citadel’s de-facto chief technology officer.

The goal at Citadel is not to be right all the time; it is to be consistently right *most* of the time. (The fund’s best portfolio managers beat the market on only about fifty-four per cent of their trades.) As Alec Litowitz, an early Citadel partner, told me, “It’s not about a portfolio, it’s about a business that can re-create great portfolios again and again.”

Citadel, built on an economic law of diversification to reduce over-all risk, takes as many uncorrelated risks as it can. That way, no one event can capsize the fund. Portfolio managers and analysts are asked to manage more money than at many rivals, and cannot stop aggressively trading. (Elsewhere, a trader who has achieved strong returns by Thanksgiving may try to quietly lock in a year-end bonus by taking on little new risk in the remaining weeks.) Unlike at some other funds, Citadel traders are required to maximize their “idio”—the idiosyncratic element of every trade. An average Citadel equity-portfolio manager turns over his portfolio ten times per year.

Griffin pushes Citadel to interrogate its methods and break industry precedent. Traditionally, for example, a fund relies on prime brokers at an

investment bank to settle the exchange of securities for cash. Early in Citadel's history, it cut out these middlemen; the speed that resulted from "self-clearing" its trades gave it a pivotal advantage in the digital era.

Citadel's high pass-through fees, which have sometimes reached twelve per cent, help pay for top traders and technology, but they also represent a risk themselves—such spending can destroy a hedge fund if net returns are too low. (A large rival, Jain Global, recently foundered, partly for this reason: last year, it generated gross returns in the mid-teens but net returns of less than four per cent, disappointing investors.) Citadel borrows a ton of money—currently, it is financing investment assets of more than three hundred billion dollars—and that helps offset this risk. If a hedge fund can generate five-per-cent returns on a seven-dollar trade, and six of those dollars were borrowed, then the return on the one "equity" dollar it invested will be thirty-five per cent, before the fund covers the interest on its debt and pays other expenses. However, this level of leverage has risks, too: with a modest six-per-cent loss you may suddenly need cash to satisfy your lenders. Such pinches have been toppling financial firms for decades.

Griffin doesn't worry much about Citadel's leverage—he feels the company knows how to manage it. But what he hates is "when we make careless mistakes" because employees become too cocky about the firm's size and success. A former executive said that "Ken's way" of combatting suboptimal performance was "some amount of turnover," adding, "There needed to be some fear in the organization."

In 1994, the bond market crashed, and Citadel had its first down year, losing 4.3 per cent. One employee at the time recalled that the fund dismissed seven of its recently hired traders. A few years later, in a precocious move—he was not yet thirty—Griffin locked up the fund's capital so that investors couldn't ask for it back immediately during periods of market turmoil. In 1998, Citadel took advantage of one such period by buying when other firms' capital was less secure. That year, it reached a billion dollars in assets under management. By 2004, it had ten billion. Convert arb, Griffin's dorm-room strategy, remained Citadel's profit center for most of its first decade. Yet the fund regularly booted out traders and set up new teams to pursue fresh trading ideas, eventually focussing on five areas: commodities, equities, quant, fixed income and macro, and credit and converts. Most

famously, Citadel spearheaded an approach to equity investing that Wall Street calls “pod shops.” In each largely independent “pod,” a portfolio manager may lead three to nine analysts and associates, with each analyst responsible for about fifty stocks in a specific industry. Citadel expects the traders to be the biggest experts on Wall Street on those stocks, and to know how rivals are positioned. Pods that flourish are given more money to invest, allowing Citadel to take on more risk. Pods that flounder are eventually shuttered.

Citadel also became a “grave dancer”—taking over the assets of failing hedge funds or other businesses. Griffin flew sixteen people to Houston on a chartered jet to interview hundreds of Enron’s employees during that company’s demise. Citadel also added new businesses not conventionally part of a hedge fund, including a technology platform and a derivatives market maker that was the precursor of Citadel Securities. Griffin saw that the digital-trading era had opened up an opportunity for a firm like Citadel, which had ample money to invest in hardware and had spent years improving algorithms to minimize risk and accelerate trades.

Citadel was successful but borderline obnoxious. The firm, even more than its peers, cultivated a culture so secretive that employees were not allowed to let any outsider know what they did at work. If Griffin suspected that an employee was sharing proprietary information, he might ask a Citadel lawyer to conduct an investigation, which could include reviewing employees’ e-mails. He retained an odd intensity. A former employee said, “When Ken didn’t want to make a decision, he’d stare into space for an extended period of time while he was processing.” In 2005, the *Times* printed a leaked e-mail to Griffin from Dan Loeb, the manager of a different hedge fund, that snarled at the “gulag” Griffin had created: “You are surrounded by sycophants but even you must know that the people who work for you despise and resent you.”

Many competitors on Wall Street were thus gleeful when Citadel’s main fund fell by fifty-five per cent during the 2008 global financial crisis. CNBC parked a truck outside the firm’s headquarters in order to film its death. Griffin told me that Citadel *would* have collapsed had Morgan Stanley failed, as that would have ignited more panicked selling. Citadel’s assets plummeted in value not because it had excessive exposure to the dubious

mortgage-backed securities at the root of the financial crisis but because it had underestimated how its own “safer” and purposely uncorrelated bets would fare in a crisis when strange things happened and nearly everything became correlated. The Securities and Exchange Commission, for instance, banned short selling on certain financial stocks, a move that upset Citadel’s efforts to hedge some securities. Many unshorable companies stopped paying dividends, and Citadel trades that had involved paying for those dividends up front piled up losses.



But Citadel survived the crash, in part because of the unusual trading and capital systems Griffin had built. During the crisis, for instance, Citadel’s self-clearing of trades allowed it to know exactly where it stood financially every minute. Still, Griffin found the moment humbling. He and several partners had to put half a billion dollars into the fund, in part to retain employees who *hadn’t* lost money. He apologized to investors for suspending their ability to take money out of the fund. Citadel would not be able to receive a fifth of future profits again until the fund hit the “high-water mark” that it had achieved before the crash. But Griffin didn’t shut down the fund and start over. As Warren Buffett once complained, other hedge-fund partners were notorious for making this move, “so that they could immediately participate in future profits without having to overcome their past losses.”

During Citadel's reboot, investors started asking pointed questions about the fund's side businesses, especially Citadel Securities, which officially became a separate entity in 2012. The extent of that separation is still the source of considerable speculation on Wall Street. Even sophisticated players told me that Griffin's hedge fund *must* benefit from Citadel Securities' trading data, and that Citadel Securities must profit from the hedge fund's trading volumes. Citadel executives brusquely dismiss the idea that anything shady is going on. Jim Esposito, Citadel Securities' president, told me that the market maker does not have Citadel as a client. And, because Griffin remains the C.E.O. of the hedge fund, there are limits to what he can know about Citadel Securities' business—even though he's on the board and owns most of it.

Yet suspicion endures, in part because Citadel Securities isn't just a passive taker of orders to buy and sell. A decade ago, it jumped ahead of the competition in "high-frequency trading"—a term it coined—by spending vast sums to use fibre-optic cables laid between Chicago and New Jersey, allowing for faster communication between stock and option exchanges in those locations. The company used this speed advantage (and, later, similar ones) to profit from infinitesimally brief pricing differences between exchanges, all while fulfilling clients' orders to buy and sell on those exchanges. Citadel Securities told certain clients that it was getting them the best price when executing those trades; from 2007 to 2010, the firm didn't actually do so about three per cent of the time, and it ended up having to pay the S.E.C. a \$22.6-million fine. By 2014, high-frequency trading in general had become controversial. Senator Elizabeth Warren called it market manipulation. Michael Lewis, in his book "Flash Boys," caustically observed, "The U.S. stock market was now a class system, rooted in speed, of haves and have-nots. The haves paid for nanoseconds; the have-nots had no idea that a nanosecond had value." The criticism died down only after shaving off nanoseconds became widespread, making the strategy less profitable.

More recently, Citadel Securities has been attacked by Warren and others for a practice called "payment for order flow." Citadel Securities pays about a billion dollars a year to retail brokers such as Robinhood for the privilege of fulfilling amateur investors' orders—to buy everything from common shares of Nvidia to stock options. Matching a buyer to the seller of those securities

generates tiny margins but is immensely profitable in the aggregate. Robinhood uses P.F.O.F. “rebates” to provide its customers with commission-free trading at spreads—the gap between what the buyer will pay and what the seller will accept—that are microscopic by historical standards. Yet the Wall Street watchdog Better Markets calls P.F.O.F. a “kickback,” and argues that companies like Citadel Securities, by subsidizing commission-free trading, encourages inexperienced people to trade with “excessive frequency and in excessively risky products.”

Griffin is unswayed by such arguments. He told me that the “explosion in trading volumes” was a good thing, because people were less prone to stick to bad bets. “When the cost to change your mind goes down profoundly, you’re more willing to change your mind,” he said. But forty per cent of the options trading for retail clients by Citadel Securities is for “zero-day contracts”—almost comically risky trades that are all or nothing at the end of each day. Europe plans to ban P.F.O.F. at the end of this month.

Impulsive trading, of course, led to the 2021 GameStop “meme stock” bubble, when the company’s stock soared largely because of retail trading on Robinhood. Citadel ended up making a grave-dancer investment in Melvin Capital, a hedge fund that had shorted GameStop, to capitalize on Melvin’s distress. In “Dumb Money,” a film about meme stocks, Nick Offerman plays Griffin as a smug cyborg whose tennis games keep getting rudely interrupted by the crisis. Griffin’s lawyer reportedly sent threatening letters to the filmmakers.

By the start of 2012, Citadel had passed its pre-crash high-water mark, and by 2015 it had twenty-five billion dollars under management. But the next three years reeked of alpha decay—the firm’s average yearly gain slumped from eighteen per cent to nine. Such decline is almost an expected outcome for a firm of Citadel’s size and age, but Griffin was intent on defying the trend. He started directly running the commodities-trading division, which had a setback in 2014, when the polar vortex walloped a large natural-gas trade that Citadel had made. Griffin sat alongside mid-level employees, crunching numbers. (That was “a *lot* of Ken,” one employee later joked.) In 2017, Griffin hired an Australian named Sebastian Barrack to ramp up the commodities business. The firm hired hundreds of people, including hydrologists and other experts in very specific parts of the weather. And it

invested heavily in technology to, for example, better shape sensor and satellite readings of the physical world into forecastable form. To critics of Wall Street, it might seem obscene that leading weather experts, presumably trained to help mitigate the destruction from, say, a hurricane, were lured away to help Citadel profit off one. But Citadel's commodities division became enormously successful. It made more than ten billion dollars in 2022 and 2023 alone, in large part from trading European natural gas, exploiting a huge price spike that occurred after Russia invaded Ukraine.

A former Citadel portfolio manager said of such overhauls, "The next incarnation of what gets built is better than what was there before, and that's always the case." The downside: "a highway wreck of human bodies." Almost every former employee I spoke to had stories about turnover. One had five bosses in five years; another kept a "Book of Souls" listing the fifty colleagues who had left his small trading unit in six years. Yet another moved to Chicago only to see his boss's boss be immediately fired, and then his boss fired. Amid the bloodshed, a source told me, the reading of internal e-mails continued, if Griffin thought someone had lied to him or stolen information. (A Citadel spokesperson said of its firings, "We have deliberately built a high-performance culture.")

It may comfort outsiders to know that at least *some* pain comes with hedge-fund jobs that pay millions of dollars to people who push buttons to buy and sell. Citadel is proud not to have a touchy-feely atmosphere. Jim Esposito told me that Griffin expects efficient communication, adding, "This is not a place where a long windup is well received." A former business leader recalled that meetings with Griffin "could turn dark very quickly" if someone tried to "gild the lily." Two ex-employees said that their children still remind them of how they were when they worked at Citadel: irritable, exhausted, often absent.

And yet, as unrelenting as Griffin may be when you work for him, employees at least know where he stands. He sometimes yells, but his anger is more cold than hot. At the giant hedge fund Bridgewater, the culture has been performatively sadistic; its former leader, Ray Dalio, reportedly once mandated that employees watch a video of a pregnant manager crying after he'd called her a "dumb shit." I heard only two Citadel stories that bordered on the cruel. Griffin scheduled a regular Friday-afternoon meeting with an

underperforming executive, who never knew if the meeting would last fifteen minutes or four hours; after three months or so of this humiliation, he was canned. And Griffin ordered the head of one desk to fire two of four hires, all recent college graduates—any two—because, a source told me, “That should be the standard.”

Ex-employees tend to have little resentment about their time at Citadel. “It was a gift to be there and a gift to leave,” one told me. New employees are given immediate responsibility, and about half of the portfolio managers have risen from more junior roles. Mid-level workers get to execute major projects, with no expenses spared. One person remembers musing during his first week about buying a fleet of new computer servers, and being told to purchase them right away. Griffin explained why Citadel offered employees such license. New hires, he told me, “may be fantastic salespeople, they may be outstanding investment professionals. But they’re actually not entrepreneurs. And, in building businesses, you learn over time who your entrepreneurs are.” Griffin has even relaxed the office culture a bit. Halloween is now a big day there, and he dresses up: Iron Man, Buzz Lightyear, a velociraptor.



Employees who thrive at Citadel have also shared in the hedge fund’s gains, which have been colossal since 2019. Griffin said of that period, “One of the

key advantages that our team had is that we actually saw the softballs.” (Asked to cite examples, he told me about the “enormous spreads” on Wells Fargo bonds at the height of the pandemic.) “We put those balls out of the park, and we did it day after day after day after day. I mean, just—” He chuckled. “There were days you looked at the profits and losses, and you’re, like, ‘This is not possible.’”

Citadel has delivered a nineteen-per-cent average annual net gain since 1990, with only two years in which it lost money. From 2019 to 2024, that gain averaged twenty-three per cent, with no down years. (The S. & P. 500 rose by an average of nineteen per cent during the same period.) In our meeting, Griffin characterized this as “one of the great runs in the history of finance.” Pasted on Citadel’s elevator doors is a title awarded by L.C.H., a fund that publishes annual rankings of the industry: “The most profitable hedge fund of all time.”

This was also a golden period for Citadel Securities, which in 2022 was valued at twenty-two billion dollars, and is now likely worth much more. The market maker now handles about a quarter of all U.S. equity volumes and some thirty per cent of U.S. equity options. It is also a leading player in floor trading and other services that the big investment banks dismissed as being beneath them. A competitor told me that the banks aren’t sure how they can compete with Citadel Securities’ economies of scale and technology. Griffin, of course, is thrilled that the company, whose C.E.O. is Peng Zhao, is so dominant. “I’m not going to disrupt *that!*” he said.

During a talk with students at Stanford’s business school last April, Griffin said, “I’m so blessed to have been born in this country.” He continued, “I would like to believe that I will—I will have done my fair share to make this the greatest nation in the world.”

Griffin proposed that his legacy was still being built from “other wins, both for Citadel and, more importantly, for America.” He likes to talk about three social benefits of his businesses. The first is the easiest to accept: the extraordinary performance of his hedge fund has enriched his investors, which include five of the eight Ivy League schools. A Citadel allocation is so coveted that the company now chooses whether, and how much, clients can invest—an inversion of the usual dynamic. Moreover, Citadel is an

outlier in an industry that disappoints investors with surprising regularity. Since 2010, according to data from the research firm H.F.R., hedge funds as a whole have delivered a mere 5.6-per-cent annual gain and have lost money on average every four years. (This hasn't stopped generations of hedge-fund managers from getting wealthy off of third-rate performances.)

The other two benefits that Griffin cites are more debatable. At a talk at Goldman Sachs last year, he boasted that Citadel Securities and other market makers have “radically increased the number of families that participate in the equities market.” He added, “We democratized finance.” The owners of sports-betting apps could make a similar claim, though they wouldn't pretend to be so high-minded. Moreover, Griffin's embrace of the Robinhood revolution feels out of synch with skepticism he expressed to me about a current industry push to make it easier for the public to invest in hedge funds and private-equity funds. Retail investors, Griffin said, are “not best equipped to make a thoughtful or reasoned decision” on risk and rewards when it comes to these funds. Such investors, not coincidentally, are also not people whose money Griffin needs.

The third benefit, as Griffin said to a group of Citadel interns last year, is that, “in the history of modern markets, no firm has impacted the markets as much as Citadel Securities has, both in the liquidity of the markets and the cost to trade.” On Wall Street, as for an antiquarian bookseller, intermediaries tend to make the most money when the job is most difficult. In finance, this might mean a trade when buyers or sellers are scarce, or unable to transact at the same time. Citadel Securities, by making millions of trades per day for its own profit-seeking and to fulfill customer orders, has eliminated inefficiencies by always having the liquidity necessary to buy or sell in large volumes.

Yet Griffin's businesses are not doing these things as a public service—that's a side effect. And Citadel isn't an investment firm that provides capital to companies that build steel factories or fast-casual restaurants. Moreover, the liquidity provided by Citadel and Citadel Securities is not an unalloyed good. More than forty years ago, Warren Buffett warned that “hyperactive equity markets subvert rational capital allocation and act as pie shrinkers.” Public companies, he explained, make nearsighted corporate decisions in response to “casino-type markets and hair-trigger investment management.”

Investors, instead of providing capital to companies that want to grow their businesses, pursue high-fee trading strategies—which, Buffett points out, almost never do better than the market. More broadly, the financial rewards of hedge funds lure talented people away from other meaningful endeavors. An uneasy sadness came over me when a Citadel Securities executive told me that the company targets “the best and brightest minds on the planet.” The firm’s publicists proudly asked me if I’d seen a story they’d planted in the press about a coding prodigy, Kairan Quazi, who’d joined the company at the age of sixteen. Quazi told *Business Insider*, “At Citadel Securities, I’ll be able to see measurable impact in days, not months or years like many research environments.” The article, decorously, didn’t mention making money.

In Miami, I asked Griffin if the profitability of the finance industry was justified. “I think it’s, it’s—” he said, falling silent for ten seconds. He then told me about a friend who was trying to make housing more affordable by reducing the cost of title insurance. He detoured into a story about the likelihood of a family in Mississippi losing all its money in a crypto heist—the implication was that stock trading was better than *that*. Finally, he touched on the fortune that Citadel makes through its trading decisions. “The question is, are the fees that people pay to have research done, are they fair?” He paused again, and gave his final answer: “There is a market.”

If you wanted to convince yourself that billionaires shouldn’t exist, you could do worse than fly to Florida, drive across a bridge to Palm Beach Island, take a right at Mar-a-Lago, and drive five hundred yards to a twenty-seven-acre construction project. Starting more than a decade ago, Griffin has spent four hundred and fifty million dollars to buy the land and level a few incumbent mansions, one of which was eighteen thousand square feet. The *New York Post* likes to say that the planned residential compound will be “the most expensive home on earth.”

Griffin’s real-estate portfolio includes properties in Aspen, Hawaii, Montana, Southampton, Saint-Tropez, and London; three in South Florida (Palm Beach, Coconut Grove, and Star Island); and the apartments in New York City. The total cost of these holdings, one and a half billion dollars, doesn’t include construction expenses at the residences, some of which are not yet built, or the private planes and the yacht where Griffin could also rest

his head. The acquisitions keep coming: near his Star Island property, he recently purchased land where he plans to construct berths for six yachts, thirty-seven thousand square feet of buildings, and pickleball and padel courts.

I asked Griffin if the public's fascination with his real-estate holdings irritated him. "It doesn't impact my life," he said. "If we're a nation obsessed with homeownership, it's almost good, right? We still believe in America. We want to buy homes in America. We want to have the American Dream. God bless."

He also told me that, after the 2008 crash, in which he "lost virtually everything in sixteen weeks," he made a decision "that some portion of my net worth would be in non-financial assets." He admitted that the Palm Beach property was "a bit untraditional" as an investment compared with, say, owning an entire condo building. But his family gets to enjoy the place all by themselves.

There will initially be two houses on the Palm Beach lot: a main one (eighteen thousand square feet) and a tidy guest house (seven thousand square feet). The main house, a serene succession of rooms with floor-to-ceiling windows, will resemble a wellness resort. That's for his mother. Griffin plans to erect other buildings on the property for himself. "I love design, I love architecture," he told me. Many of the floors in his mother's house will be laid with "rift-cut" eight-inch-wide white-oak planks, the manufacturing of which was so arcane that it required Amish craftsmen. The cost was extremely high, the visual enhancement extremely subtle. "It's *so* beautiful," Griffin told me, beaming.

Although Griffin has the property portfolio of a Saudi prince, his vibe is more that of a suburban dad. He comes to some meetings in a polo shirt and jeans. He likes Coke at breakfast and Häagen-Dazs with hot fudge. He once said publicly that the "joke is you can tell how stressful it's been by how much my waistline has grown over the last few months." In 2016, a new Citadel employee in Chicago ran into Griffin in an elevator; he was carrying a takeout bag from McDonald's. He loves video games, especially Call of Duty, where winning, he explained to me, "is all about making killstreaks happen." He cycles and skis. He hasn't bought a sports franchise yet, though

in 2022 he and some partners nearly bid for Chelsea Football Club in the U.K., and a year later he thought about attempting to buy a minority stake in the Miami Dolphins.

His three kids, all teen-agers, attend a private school in Miami. Griffin has been unmarried since 2015, when he and Anne Dias, the mother of his children, divorced after eleven years of marriage. Dias reportedly requested a million dollars a month in child support, but she and Griffin settled before the case went to trial, after embarrassing headlines for them both.

Griffin does not discuss his dating life, but he was eager to talk to me about his art collecting. “I’ve always been interested in Jackson Pollock,” he said, then caught himself coming off as a born aesthete. “Actually, that’s not true. Let me be clear—I had no interest or knowledge about art whatsoever until I was almost thirty.” Now, he told me, he sees art as “one of the few ways that we as humanity separate ourselves from being animals.”

Griffin has made multiple art loans to the Norton Museum of Art, in West Palm Beach. One crowded room there has some of his early acquired pieces, including an edition of Degas’s “Little Dancer” sculpture that, he told me, was the “real start” of his interest in art. He first saw it not at a museum but while stopping by Sotheby’s in 1999.

Other parts of the Norton have more mature Griffin acquisitions, including a Rothko, a de Kooning, and a small Pollock. Given the publicly known price of some of Griffin’s acquisitions, which are a fraction of his collection, the total value of his art purchases is almost certainly in excess of two billion dollars. His collecting mirrors other impulses in his life: a yen for the “best”; practical investment logic (Impressionists, he told me, are “all but impossible to collect”); patriotic attachment to America at its most world-conquering. It also signals a desire to be more like an old-school plutocrat than like a tech billionaire who goes to Burning Man. The centerpiece of Griffin’s collection is “Interchange,” a de Kooning painting. It hangs at the Norton, and has never been in Griffin’s possession. He described it to me as “one of the most important paintings of the last hundred years.” He added, “It’d certainly be on a Top Ten list.”

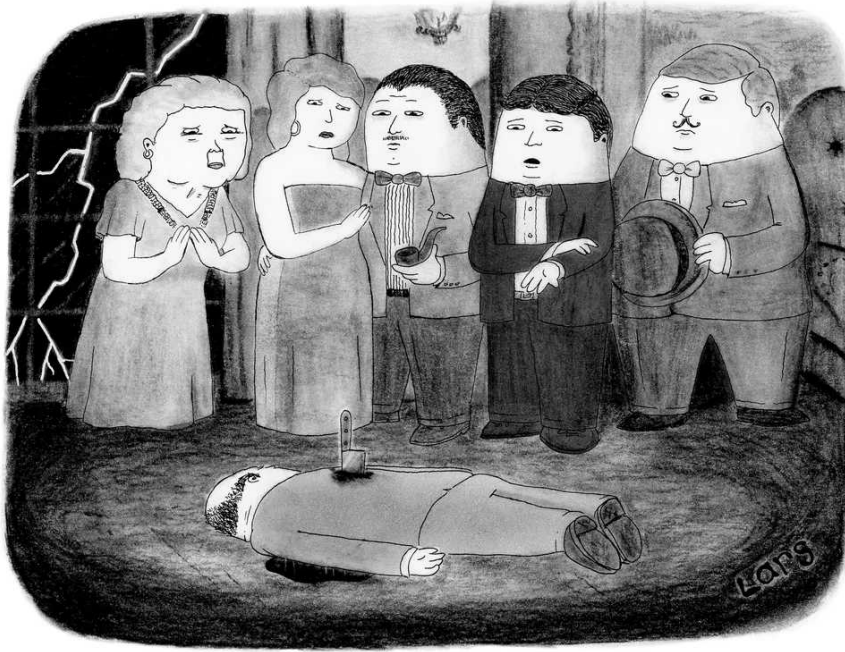
Griffin told me that he's too busy right now to build a museum to house his various collections, but he admitted that the thought has occurred to him. In addition to the art and the stegosaurus, he owns a copy of the Emancipation Proclamation; a draft of the Bill of Rights; a copy of the Thirteenth Amendment; and two of the fourteen surviving original copies of the Constitution. He paid forty-three million dollars for the first copy. He hasn't disclosed the price of the spare.

His own museum may remain notional for now, but Griffin can visit at least thirteen art, science, and history museums and seven hospitals that carry his name on buildings, centers, or wings. After he donated a hundred and twenty-five million dollars to the Museum of Science and Industry in Chicago, in 2024, it became officially known as the Griffin Museum of Science and Industry. He has given away more than two billion dollars in total, almost all of it in the U.S., much of it to established institutions, including the University of Chicago's economics department and Memorial Sloan Kettering, the New York hospital. He also wrote a check to secure a new head coach—an Argentine—for the U.S. men's national soccer team.

Although Griffin has expressed concern that, at elite universities such as Harvard, "whiny snowflakes" have become "caught up in a rhetoric of oppressor and oppressee," he has given generously to his alma mater. He has also made high-profile donations to Success Academy charter schools, criticizing the "human-capital tragedy" of New York City's not allowing the schools to expand, a complaint that echoes ones he made in Chicago. An education focussed on "excellence," he likes to say, is "the on-ramp to the American Dream."

Miami, he believes, is a place where the American Dream still lives. He and his children moved there in 2022. He loves the city's safety and openness to business, but told me that there is work to be done on education, roads, public transportation, and "chronically short" housing. During the pandemic, Miami was hyped first by crypto bros and then by New York financiers who envisaged creating a "Wall Street South." They were drawn in part by the absence of state and local income taxes. (Griffin has recently been joined there by Jeff Bezos and by Sergey Brin, a founder of Google.) The two Citadel businesses now have about five hundred employees in Miami, most of whom moved with Griffin from Chicago.

Griffin was a champion of Chicago for most of his thirty-two years there. He was a friend of the former Democratic mayor Rahm Emanuel and was proud of what he saw as the city's culture of coöperation between business and politics. But he had concerns about corruption, crime, underfunded pensions, and education, as was caustically evident in a speech that he gave to the Economic Club of Chicago in 2013. Decrying the city's public schools, he declared that "the Democratic Party is captive to the unions and not captive to the children."



In the 2018 gubernatorial race in Illinois, J. B. Pritzker, a billionaire himself, defeated the incumbent, Bruce Rauner, a former private-equity manager whom Griffin had supported. Griffin told me, "When J.B. became governor, I sat down with him and said, 'If you'll do pension reform, I will publicly support you for a tax increase.' " I asked Griffin whether Pritzker thought about it. "No," he said. "He more or less told me to pound sand." (Pritzker's office declined to comment.)

David Greising, the president of the Chicago-based Better Government Association, told me that Griffin and Pritzker engaged in a "blood feud" for years. (A spokesperson for Griffin said that his disagreements with Pritzker were "rooted in concerns about the state's future, not personal animosity.") Griffin won the first battle, in 2020, by spending more than fifty-four million

dollars to defeat Pritzker's plan to institute a progressive tax increase. But Griffin—who last year told his employees to be “hardball” players who seek to win not in a squeaker but in a rout—also sought to defeat Pritzker's reelection bid, in 2022. In the run-up to the election, Greising recalled, Griffin issued public warnings about Citadel potentially leaving Chicago while also conducting a “beauty contest” of Republican candidates who could challenge Pritzker. Griffin ultimately backed Richard Irvin, the Black mayor of a Chicago suburb, giving fifty million dollars to the campaign. But, Greising said, Griffin “made such a feeble choice that all the money in the world couldn't buy him” a winner. Griffin announced Citadel's move to Miami five days before Irvin—as predicted—was routed in the primary. The financier spent more than four hundred dollars on each vote that Irvin got. Pritzker won reelection easily.

“No one was surprised” when Citadel left Chicago, Griffin told me. After all, he'd publicly called the city “like Afghanistan on a good day.” He and Beeson emphasized to me that crime was the main cause of their departure. Beeson told me that an employee had been stabbed near the office. Griffin talked publicly about bullet holes in the façade of the building where he lived. (Last year, Chicago recorded the fewest murders since 1965.)

Griffin's attempts to influence politics have gone well beyond Chicago. Between 2020 and 2024, he spent four hundred million dollars on public campaign contributions in Florida and Illinois, and in federal elections. OpenSecrets lists him as one of the top five donors to federal races in the past three election cycles. (Griffin recently told me that he suspects his overall political giving in 2026 will be less than in the past, noting, “The aperture of where we're focussing our contributions is just narrower.”) Cason Carter, Griffin's top adviser on philanthropy and politics, told me that Griffin isn't a “political socialite” and rarely meets candidates—he's more interested in their policy agendas. Griffin emphasized to me that a lot of his money went to Republican congressional candidates who were “different than historical voices,” such as “women of color” and “ex-military” types. But he also supports the Old Guard. In late May, he made his largest reported contribution of this election cycle, two and a half million dollars, to support Susan Collins, the Republican senator from Maine. Collins's left-populist opponent, Graham Platner, has proposed a five- to six-per-cent annual federal wealth tax. Platner disparaged the gift to Collins in an online video,

saying that Griffin's goal was "helping her buy this election," and that such gifts should "be illegal." (Griffin dismissed the critique, telling me, "The Mamdani tweet was sent to me by countless friends and acquaintances. Platner's tweet was sent to me by no one.")

Griffin seems to consider his pulpit to be as important as his checkbook. He speaks on more topics, and in more venues, than any of his financial peers, almost always at such cozy forums as Davos. His commentary is measured, and he often comes across as a shadow Secretary of the Treasury. Sometimes he can be a bit more tart. Last year, when he was asked about Trump's One Big Beautiful Bill Act at a publicly broadcast Citadel Securities conference, he answered, "I don't think there's a nice way to put lipstick on that pig." After pausing for home-field laughs, he returned to form, calling the bill a "pro-cyclical tax cut late in the economic cycle."

In Miami, Griffin told me, "I'd like to keep the Republican Party the party of small government, personal freedom." In contrast to *MAGA* nihilists, he frequently talks about the value of government: "I think your best private philanthropy is philanthropy that encourages the public government to do things that are necessary for the common good that would otherwise not be on their radar." During the pandemic, he called up Jared Kushner with the outline for what became Operation Warp Speed—the plan to create a *COVID* vaccine as quickly as possible. "Jared just ran with it," Griffin told me.

Last year, Griffin said on CNBC, "Every single policy in Washington should have one focus and one focus only—how do we grow our economy?" This, he has noted, should not be at the expense of "equity and fairness," adding that tax increases must be "on the table." (According to *ProPublica*, between 2013 and 2018 he paid an average tax rate of 29.2 per cent—much higher than, say, the 13.7 per cent paid by Mark Zuckerberg.) More often, though, Griffin talks about American debt, competitiveness, and sagging productivity.

He presents his ideas as patriotic advice. For a man the former Trump adviser Steve Bannon once sneeringly called a globalist with "the political instincts of Louis XVI," and whose firm has a hundred and fourteen nationalities on staff, Griffin is surprisingly consistent in saying that his goal

is for America to win. Discussing visas with me, he lamented the possibility of “a gifted student in mathematics and physics that chooses to stay in China.” He said he’d rather immigrants “wear the Team U.S.A. jersey and build great businesses in America than compete by running great businesses in foreign countries.” When our conversation turned to the liberal politics of professors at elite universities, he told me, “All of those guys are anti-United States. This doesn’t mean I don’t have my criticisms. . . . But the starting position should be ‘This is the greatest country in the world.’ ”

Griffin supported Marco Rubio in the 2016 Republican Presidential primary and Nikki Haley in 2024. He’s never given a campaign contribution to Trump. (He donated a million dollars to Trump’s Inauguration in 2025, but he also gave half a million to Joe Biden’s.) He decided to vote for Trump in 2024, although, as he said before the election, it was “not with a smile on my face.”

Griffin’s most frequent complaint about the Biden Administration was what he calls its “endless onslaught of pointless litigation and pointless regulation.” (That being said, in the Biden years his estimated net worth doubled.) The new Administration hasn’t made him much happier. At last year’s Citadel Securities conference, Griffin said that the Trump Administration has done “a lot that we love and a lot that we hate.” He has condemned most of Trump’s major economic initiatives: tariffs, meddling with the Federal Reserve, nostalgic favoring of the manufacturing sector. Although Griffin supports tighter enforcement of immigration at the border with Mexico, he said in 2021 that Trump’s “willingness to attack people on the basis of where they came from or the color of their skin was completely inappropriate.”

That was a rare public personal criticism of Trump—and one he dared make only when it seemed that Trump was permanently out of power. Nowadays, instead of naming the President, he prefers to say, for example, that “the U.S. government’s” favoritism toward political allies and interference in the economy are “incredibly distasteful.” Griffin likely had mixed feelings when, last fall, the *Wall Street Journal* anointed him “Wall Street’s Loudest Trump Critic.” He has made a point of saying that Trump’s “choices come from a good place,” and that the President is “very different in a small room,” something that is “quite touching” to behold.

This carefulness is clearly strategic. In 2024, a CNBC interviewer at a conference exclaimed, to applause, “You need to run for President, Ken!” To many in finance, Griffin has taken the slot formerly held by the JPMorgan Chase C.E.O., Jamie Dimon: an outspoken king of Wall Street who could become a technocratic moderate in the White House. Griffin has encouraged these speculations. At a conference in February, he said, “I’d like to believe that at a future point in my life, I will be involved in public service.”

Griffin told me last week that he has no current plans to run for anything: “There’s not been a meaningful shift in my position over the last six to twelve months.” One reason might be that he is never interested in losing. None of his predecessors who tried to parlay Wall Street success into a shot at the American Presidency—from Hamilton to Harriman to Romney to Bloomberg—ever won.

Moreover, if Griffin stepped into public life now, the cynical wags in finance would declare the reason obvious—his hedge fund’s returns have been sagging. As a senior investment professional at a large institution told me, it’s axiomatic that a hedge fund’s performance is “inversely proportional to the amount of exposure the head guy or gal is getting on TV.” Although Citadel Securities has reported record revenue so far this year, the hedge fund delivered a return of just 10.3 per cent last year—worse than the industry average for only the second time since 2008. Through May of this year, it’s up only 3.9 per cent, according to *Business Insider*. Griffin portrayed this to me as the consequence of intentional caution, given that so many potential Wall Street bets are “being driven by a singular question, which is: how long will the Strait of Hormuz be closed for?” Perhaps, but H.F.R. has reported that the industry average is up 7.1 per cent over the same period.

Griffin admitted to me that running the hedge fund could be wearying: “There are parts of it I love and parts of it I hate.” He certainly seems to enjoy mixing it up with Mamdani, and buying a Constitution or two. But, ever since high school, the first order of business for Griffin has been business. He expressed confidence to me about his ability to get Citadel traders to stop “waiting for softballs.” Many current employees, no doubt, will not last long. His task is “getting people to really get back in—I hate to say it—the grind-it-out reality that defines most of the life of an investment

firm. . . . You have to see the details the competition hasn't seen." He promised, "This won't take us long to do." ♦

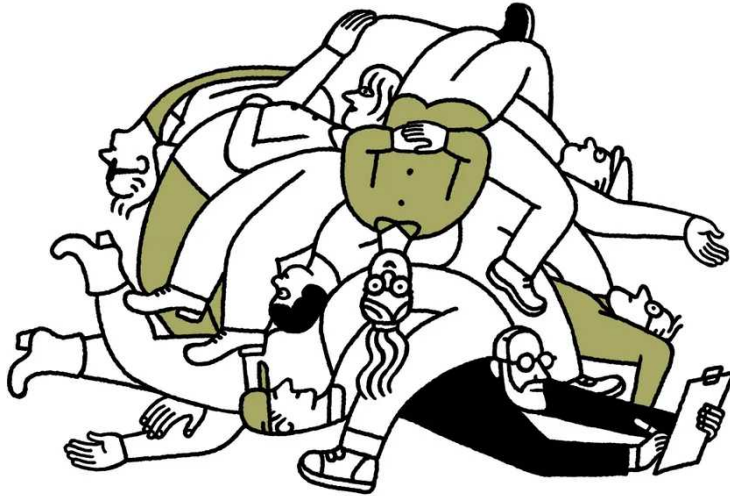
Shouts & Murmurs

- [Meet Russ Freud](#)

Meet Russ Freud

By Ian Frazier

June 15, 2026



It used to be called the Roberts Institute for Living, but everybody knew that it was the insane asylum, and that's what people called it. A few years ago, its board decided to accept reality and change the name to Bob's Insane Asylum. In the past, patients generally came to the asylum themselves. They would become insane and show up on their own, or a relative or somebody would bring them in. Unfortunately, that business model stopped working, and facilities like this one had to get more involved in outreach. We now live in a country with more than seventy million completely insane people. Bob's Insane Asylum decided to go and seek them out, rather than just sitting back and waiting for them.

You've probably heard that the real crazy people are the ones walking around on the street, and the ones locked up in insane asylums are the only people who are sane. The first part is correct, if you include those driving around in pickups with huge flags fluttering insanely behind them, but the second part is not, because some of the people inside insane asylums are also

insane. The other day I caught up with Russ Freud, the interim director of Bob's Insane Asylum, to find out more about the new program. As it turned out, I caught up with him only briefly, because insane people were chasing him. Suddenly a crowd of them appeared from around the corner of a building and he had to start running again.

Well-informed consumers may know Russ Freud from his recent best-seller, "Russ Freud's Interpretation of Dreams," in which he applies a commonsense approach. Say you have a dream about speaking to a large audience while dressed in your underwear. His take on it is: if you dream that, you are seriously nuts, or "crazy as a road lizard." His diagnosis refers to the way road lizards in the desert along Route 66 in Arizona or New Mexico used to stand there in the heat staring at the passing traffic with eyes not quite in synch—i.e., totally crazy-looking nutso. Generally, the lizards would just stand there as if counting cars until they got run over or went away. Step one of the outreach program, Russ Freud said, panting heavily as he ran, is to bring in any of those lizards still remaining and treat them, too.

"But forget lizards for the moment. Tens of millions of human beings in this country are more out of their minds than they are," Russ Freud went on, having temporarily slowed his pursuers by toppling a pile of wood pallets in their path behind a Target. "Listen to some of the insane things they think—and I'm supposed to fix it?" He drank from a thermos he was carrying and set out again at a jog. "You hear these crazy people talk, and you have to wonder what my grandfather, the realist painter Lucian Freud, might have said about them."

He sped up even more, to try to put some extra distance between himself and the lunatics, and I needed to catch up with him again to continue interviewing him. On a tight deadline to file, I was writing my article even as I interviewed him. I began the second paragraph: "I caught up with Russ Freud again just past the Target," etc.—carrying my open laptop while I ran alongside him.

Finally, after he pulled ahead and I caught up with him for the third or fourth time to continue the interview, my excess weight, drinking, and smoking caught up with *me*, and I keeled over and did a face-plant right into the pavement of the parking lot of a Dick's Sporting Goods, not far from Target.

I painfully lifted myself to my knees, and was then trampled flat by the crowd of nut jobs chasing Russ Freud. A mall cop came over, pried me off the parking lot with a tire tool, and helped me to my feet.

In the mall cop's little E.V. patrol car, as he kindly drove me around, I got caught up on some unfinished reporting (calls, etc.) and then, with the mall cop's help, outstripped the running crowd of insane people once again and caught up with Russ Freud for what would be the last time. My editor, who was monitoring my computer remotely and clearing what I wrote with the D.O.J., texted me, "There is no story here." But then I lucked into a scoop, when Russ Freud confided that Bob's Insane Asylum was about to go national and would be selling franchises. Now there would be a locally owned Bob's Insane Asylum in every mall and commercial strip in the U.S.A.! Corporate management would supply the logo, training, and supplies, and the franchisees would do the rest. "We know the potential customer base is out there," Russ Freud said.

Sadly, it was all too late. During a moment of inattention, an enormous wave of insane people rolled over us and buried us deep beneath them. I regretted that I had ever caught up with Russ Freud in the first place. ♦

Fiction

- [Mutter](#)

Fiction

Mutter

By Esther Yi

June 14, 2026



I'm waiting for my mother at the airport, holding a strip of cardboard above my head that says "*mutter.*" An older German lady emerges from the sliding doors and wanders up to me with a dazed look, relieved that she can finally drop her bags to the floor. But I tell her she is not my mother—never was and never will be. I add that I don't love my mother just because she's my mother, though being my mother certainly helps, since it means she's always been around, and so I got to know her, and it was only then that I came to love her.

With a sigh, the German lady picks up her bags and waddles away. At that moment, my mother comes marching out of the doors. In lieu of a greeting, she informs me that she doesn't have any checked luggage and impatiently waves us away from the airport, from all of this. She's carrying only a tote bag, but it's so heavy—taut and bulging, like there could be a bowling ball inside—that it's making half her body sag.

“I’ve seen that word before,” she says, pointing at my sign.

“You’ve probably seen it in English. But I mean it in the German way.”

I pronounce it slowly in German. My mother imitates me, then converts the word into a pair of Korean syllables that sound most like the German. She tells me that this Korean verb refers to when a splotch of something sticks onto something else, and it shouldn’t have. The offending splotch is frequently moist, leading to the possibility of a stain, but the Korean “mutter” could also turn out to be a surface-level affair.

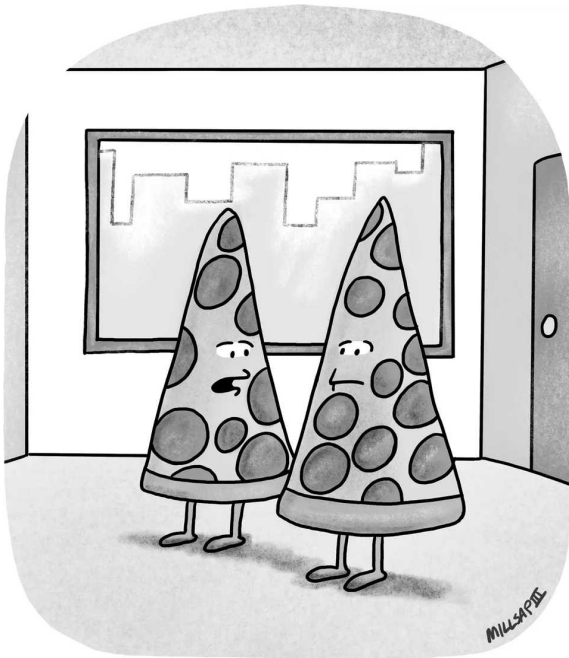
My mother, who probably would’ve become an eccentric schoolteacher had she never left Korea for America, asks me to imagine a shooting spree at a shopping mall: “Let’s say the gunman plugs you squarely in the chest and blood drenches your shirt—that’s not ‘mutter.’ Now, imagine you’re sitting in the food court, close to the main action. It wouldn’t be ‘mutter’ if a drop of a stranger’s blood flew over into your cup of soda, but it would be ‘mutter’ if that droplet landed on your shirt. Understand?”

“I think so,” I say. “When something ‘mutters,’ there’s a chance it won’t penetrate deeply enough to leave a stain. Such a ‘muttering’ thing shows up where it shouldn’t, but it’s pretty easy to get rid of.”

As we take the bus into the city, I try to think of a word in English that describes the entire concept in reverse, that is, when something shows up where it should and is impossible to get rid of. Interestingly, there are nouns for this something (soul, God, etc.), but there seem to be no verbs capturing what this something does (“to soul,” “to god”?). Meanwhile, I can think of far too many nouns for something that shows up where it should but is pretty easy to get rid of, and they all have verbs. That would make sense, because, if something can disappear, then it’ll need a verb to call itself back into existence. By contrast, something like the soul, God, etc., in being impossible to get rid of, knows no such shift. It can’t be made to happen, since it’s always already there. What’s more, if the soul, God, etc., can’t be made to happen, then it never has happened, actually, which makes me wonder—does it happen by *not* happening? Might it happen by *not* showing up where it should? In that case, perhaps everything I hold dear—e.g., my mother, her voice, both rattled by this bus—can be understood as being in an

unrelenting state of abandonment by the soul, God, etc. Beauty, then, arises from the pain and struggle of experiencing oneself as a site of divine truancy, and ugly is that which pretends to be directly equivalent to the soul, God, etc. Might this be why I find cockroaches endearing, while kindly know-it-alls make my skin crawl?

The next day, I bring my mother to work with me. When I first started working at the zoo, its inhabitants were organized by taxonomy (birds here, wildcats there). Not long afterward, the animals were organized by continental regions (African birds here, Asian birds there), reflecting the popular celebration of cultural differences, particularly in the anodyne areas of fashion and food, which made animals—plumaged, etc., frequently eaten, etc.—ideal subjects. Now the park’s animals are organized by their degree of endangerment. The idea among management is something like “save the best for last”: instead of viewing the precarity of a species as an allusion to what’s not there, why not treat it as a substantial trait that imbues an animal with pathos, even a soulful intelligence?



I encourage my mother to walk the zoo’s entire course, from the species that exist in plenitude to the species that are so much on their own that even if their calls were to be broadcast around the world, not one living creature would know how to respond. I work as a security guard in the latter section.

When my mother finally reaches my station, she joins a group of schoolchildren and their teacher standing before the metal enclosure in which the crown jewel of our park lives: Zelzah, the only California condor left in the world.

A trainer is inside the cage feeding Zelzah. Meanwhile, my job is to stand guard on the other side of the footpath. Unlike the trainer, who holds Zelzah on his arm and does all sorts of things with her so that she becomes stronger, faster, and smarter, I'm on the lookout for anything that could weaken, decelerate, or retard her. I'd like to be up close and personal with Zelzah, too. But I'd never make it long as a trainer, because I'd have no desire to acquaint myself with her "machinery" so as to coordinate aerial or biological feats out of her. I'd be too busy staring at Zelzah and growing increasingly troubled. I'd let her stay on my arm for as long as she liked, even if that meant sleeping standing up inside her cage. All I want, really, is to fall within her line of sight for long enough that a little pile of information about me forms in her brain. It can be a messy pile, unsorted, just sitting there like dirty laundry.

As the trainer explains the complex evolutionary history of Zelzah's species, she looks around with unspent savagery. She wants to do something, anything, but she doesn't know what there is to do. She doesn't even know how to want to leave her cage. If only I could move all my feelings into her! She'd know how to draw my contradictory human impulses into a single irrevocable act, and this despairing but living instant would be magically commensurate with the rambling span of our conjoined life.

"Zel—zah," I pronounce slowly. "Last not just once, but twice."

The trainer informs the schoolchildren that Zelzah was born in the zoo but that her "real home" is a stretch of shrubland north of Los Angeles. She's "supposed" to have been born there, he says. I don't understand this matter of supposedness. It seems to me that Zelzah isn't supposed to be anywhere or anything. The trainer thinks he's confronting a painful idea, namely that there exists a home Zelzah can't return to, when he's actually distracting himself with a painful idea that's false in order to avoid the more painful idea that's true. Still, I can sympathize with the desire for a firm peg or two on which to drape the amorphous fabric of one's existence so that it can

approximate a picture with meaning. As much as I can't stand to be told who I'm supposed to be or what I'm supposed to want, I secretly need some guidance at all times. It's even better when there's brute force involved, because then I do everything in my power to break free, a task sufficiently preoccupying that I don't have to decide what I actually want to be free for. I want freedom but not too much of it. For example, while I have no wish to belong to any particular place or group of people, I wish to belong to myself. So I, too, believe in supposedness: I think I'm supposed to be myself. This may be even more mistaken than thinking I'm supposed to be someone else.

The trainer holds out a piece of raw chicken, the sun striking it as though it were the moisturized pink cheek of an obviously beautiful woman. Zelzah snaps it up. Stuffed with chicken from the top, she has no choice but to eject a violent rash of feces from below. In symbolic timing, I'm selected at that moment for a visit by a trainer at the elephant pond who's infamous for his uncontrolled extroversion. The prevailing interpretation among my co-workers is that he's arrogant and thinks himself unduly interesting, but my feeling is more that he's so burdened by his own banality—his “cross to bear”—that he has to cast off bits of it everywhere, like rotten apples out of a sack.

“Mary was such a good girl today,” he announces. The elephant must've been asked to endure something. “Ah,” he goes on, catching sight of my mother, “ha ha, it's your mother,” and then, preëemptively, “hey, take it easy, I'm just poking fun at people who would say such a thing.” I wait for him to finish talking to himself. Then I confirm that the woman is my mother. But he only laughs some more, mirthlessly. “You can always tell there's something broken about the older folks who come alone. Oh it's just so sad. You'll find them talking to the animals, saying things like ‘You wouldn't fit in my oven.’ It's obvious they haven't had any real human contact in a while. That woman's husband is probably dead, and I bet her children don't call her.”

From my position on the other side of the footpath, I try to see my mother as he sees her. She's shaking her head in awe at Zelzah. The children, meanwhile, are turning around to stare at her, having gathered that she isn't a mother to any of them and that this makes her solitude weird.

“She looks fine to me,” I say uneasily.

After the demonstration, the children move on, but my mother remains standing before the cage. As I cross the footpath in her direction, I feel like we really could be strangers, and, in that suspension of our lifelong history, she strikes me for the first time as lost and confused. Zelzah spreads her wings wide. My mother anxiously turns her head left and right, scanning the wingspan as if a message awaits her there, but the bird, with an air of displeasure, promptly folds her wings back up, and what I used to see as a posture of relaxation now strikes me as the tense withholding of a secret. When I lay a hand on my mother’s shoulder, she looks up at me in alarm, eyes void of recognition—but then they soften, become mild and indifferent. Flooded with relief, more because I want to be than because I am, I hug her.

“I’m so tired,” she says. “I hate your time zone.”

I take her home as soon as I can. After I finish showering, we sit on the floor in the middle of my apartment so that we can have dinner while she combs my hair. I’m surprised she doesn’t ask if I’ll ever come back home, or make her usual solicitous observations about my apartment’s chairless austerity. Now she sits cross-legged behind me on the parquet beside our dinner of discounted baked cheese and seems perfectly resigned to the way I live.

“You used to have so much more hair,” she observes from behind. “Now when I gather your hair into my hand, it has the dimensions of a chewed-up plastic straw.”

“Whenever you get older, I get older, too.”

I tell her it’s never made any sense to me that more and more hair falls out with age. Shouldn’t my hair, dead as its cells are, actually multiply over time, while the juicy living parts of my body fall out, with my death being the exact moment when nothing that’s alive about me is left? Rolling around inside my coffin would be a gigantic ball of hair trussed by a Möbius strip of fingernail.

“The older I get, the more I love you,” I say. “Does that mean my love is more dead than alive?”



I tell my mother that sometimes it feels like an emergency: she must know that no one else can ever be what she is for me. I don't care who other people are and what they think they can do for me, I wouldn't care even if my mother were dead—in fact, they better leave my sight so that I can focus on the gaping hole she's left behind.

My mother says nothing and keeps the comb trundling across my scalp.

“Hello?” I say. “Are you there?”

She stops combing. I turn around to look at her.

“I came here to tell you something,” she says. “I’m starting to forget things, and it’ll only get worse. Thankfully, at a certain point I won’t know it’s happening. As a matter of fact, I’ll probably be the happiest and freest I’ve ever been. But you won’t be happy and free. My greatest fear is that I’ll do something in my brand-new life as an idiot that’ll make you laugh and cry at the same time. I don’t want to confuse you like that; I don’t want to make your joy and sadness hard to tell apart. I know this wicked mixture is the truth, but still, I don’t want it for you. So treat me as if I were no different from that impressive bird you watch over at work. I know it’ll be hard to see me as an animal. I was your human mother for so long, after all. But understand that I’ve transformed. Understand that your human mother has

gone away. Don't try to find her in what I become. Only then is there a chance you might love me still. You might even be tempted to cuddle me, post pictures of me, spend hundreds of dollars to buy me so that you can keep me at home and play with me."

I touch my hair. It's silky until I reach the ends, which are so viciously knotted that I'll have to cut them off with scissors later.

"But who will take care of you?" I whine. "Live with me. Stay with me."

"I would never do that to you. Things would get so bad that you'd be relieved when I die. No, it's healthier to catapult you into grief."

I weep as she resumes combing my hair. Ignoring my breakdown, she tells me a story I've already heard before, about how, when she was a girl, she had thick beautiful hair all the way down to her butt and wore it in a flamboyant braid as long and heavy as a rope. She lost her balance whenever it swung, and, in that sense, it functioned nothing like an animal's tail. But her mother, who found it unseemly for a little girl to be swinging such a thing about, chopped it off one night while my mother was asleep. The next day, what made my mother even sadder than the braid's disappearance was how amazingly light she felt as she walked down the street, like she might float right up into the sky. ♦

This is drawn from "[To God](#)."

The Critics

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- [When Did White-Collar Work Start to Look So Bleak?](#)
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- [The Hell-Raising Rocker Who Conquered Country Radio](#)
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Books

How Did American Christianity End Up Like This?

History helps explain the particular faith that now rules our religious marketplace.

By Michael Luo

June 14, 2026



Jeremiah Moore was an irritant to the Crown. Colonial authorities in Virginia apprehended him repeatedly for being, as one magistrate put it, in 1773, a “preacher of the Gospel of Jesus Christ.” This was a true statement, but incomplete. Moore was a Baptist evangelist, admired for his knowledge of the Scriptures and for his satirical edge from the pulpit. Brook Wilensky-Lanford, the author of “[A God-Shaped Nation: Five Hundred Years of Religion in America](#)” (Atlantic Monthly Press), describes Moore as “large and gregarious, and always spoiling for a fight.” He ranged all over Fairfax County and, at one point, pastored in a place called Difficult, in between Falls Church and Leesburg. His alleged crime was preaching without the authorization of the Church of England, the colony’s official church. An

exasperated judge told him, “You shall lay in jail until you rot.” Yet Moore, imprisoned in Alexandria, remained full of zeal, preaching through latticed windows to crowds outside.

Moore played an early role in the making of American Christianity. At the time of the country’s founding, the church was experiencing an ebb tide, as the rejection of organized religion became more commonplace. Nevertheless, Christianity was enmeshed in public life. Most of the new states mandated that officeholders be Protestant; many still had officially recognized churches, sanctioned by the government. Moore and his fellow-Baptists were religious dissenters. In the fall of 1776, a petition complaining of the “Burden of an ecclesiastical Establishment,” signed by ten thousand men, arrived at the newly constituted Virginia House of Delegates. Moore later said that he’d presented the petition directly to Thomas Jefferson, who at the time represented Albemarle County. Around this period, Jefferson was closely studying the political philosopher John Locke’s arguments for religious freedom. He drafted a pioneering bill that barred the punishment of individuals for their religious beliefs, but failed to get it through the legislature. In 1786, Jefferson’s protégé, James Madison, successfully passed a slightly modified version of the measure, enshrining a watershed idea in America: the withdrawal of state control of religion.

Madison went on to become one of the principal architects of the Constitution and, later, the primary drafter of the Bill of Rights. His proposal for the First Amendment was sweeping, and included barring the abridgment of civil rights “on account of religious belief or worship,” prohibiting “any national religion,” and guaranteeing “equal rights of conscience.” The final language approved by Congress, however, was more ambiguous, a product of conflicting desires to protect religious freedom and to curb the influence of the irreligious: “Congress shall make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof.” Jefferson later argued, in a letter to a Baptist group in Connecticut, that the amendment established “a wall of separation between Church & State.”

Reality turned out to be more complicated. The First Amendment insured that faith in the United States would be voluntary. It would be up to the people to decide “how much religion they wanted in their government, institutions, and communities,” the historian Matthew Avery Sutton writes in

his book “[Chosen Land: How Christianity Made America and Americans Remade Christianity](#)” (Basic). Many clergy feared what this would mean for their congregations, but the outcome upended all expectations. The great deregulation of religion led to a thriving marketplace, forcing churches to innovate and to compete for customers. The question, then as now, was how the winners would seek to imprint their values and beliefs on the nation.

The harvest field is a metaphor in the Bible which speaks to people’s openness to the Gospel. In the years after the American Revolution, many clergy believed that the harvest field had become barren. Then, in the spring of 1800, remote regions of Kentucky became the setting for strange, otherworldly scenes. At a Communion service near the Red River, attendees “were thrown into wonderful and strange contortions of features, body and limbs,” one observer said. Soon after, during a gathering at Gasper River, the “prostrate bodies of penitents” covered the floor of a meeting house and had to be carried outside and laid out on the grass. The following year, in Logan County, in the southern part of the state, a Presbyterian minister named Barton Stone attended a revival meeting on the edge of a prairie. He saw people fall down and lie still for hours before suddenly rising and shouting words of deliverance. “It baffled description,” he later said.

The gatherings culminated in early August, 1801, in Cane Ridge, a tiny settlement whose name came from the dense bamboo that covered the region. A log meeting house, about fifty feet long and thirty feet wide, served as Cane Ridge’s Presbyterian church, where Stone had been serving as pastor. It was his task to administer the summer Communion, typically several days of fasting, prayer, and sermonizing. Thousands of people arrived on foot, on horseback, and by wagon. Preachers mounted tree stumps and worked different parts of the encampment. Multitudes fell down and lay motionless. “The falling exercise was very common among all classes, the saints and sinners of every age and of every grade, from the philosopher to the clown,” Stone later wrote. Some attendees shrieked and jerked; others laughed uncontrollably, or emitted grunts that resembled barking. One participant likened the cacophony to “the roar of Niagara.”

The Cane Ridge Revival would become an epochal moment in American religious history, one of the most visible manifestations of what historians would later refer to as the Second Great Awakening. (The first began in the

early eighteenth century.) In 1803, after the Louisiana Purchase effectively doubled the size of the country, religious entrepreneurs gained access to a vast new market. Settlers streamed into the American frontier. Revivalist preachers followed them. For the most part, these were not ministers with formal theological training. They were farmers, shopkeepers, and artisans who forded streams, ascended valleys, and endured rain, wind, and snow in order to bring the Gospel to people eking out livelihoods in the wilderness. Francis Asbury, a young Methodist missionary, raised up an army of “circuit riders,” preachers who travelled constantly; many of them died young. Asbury himself would traverse some two hundred and fifty thousand miles and preach more than sixteen thousand sermons in the course of forty-five years.

The historic European Protestant traditions that were the forebears of the American church placed great emphasis on learning and on doctrine, but the result was a faith that tended to be aristocratic and élitist. Revivalism democratized Christianity. It elevated a new class of spiritual leaders—people who could hold a crowd in their thrall. They preached that salvation was open to all and exhorted congregants to forge their own moral destinies. Sutton argues that the effect of this movement was a distinctly American faith, one in which “the ideals of political democracy and religious democracy went hand in hand.”

Over time, some preachers sought to systematize these tactics for winning converts. Charles Grandison Finney, who became renowned for his wildly popular revival meetings, honed his “new measures,” which included addressing listeners in forthright, accessible language and incorporating an “anxious seat” for the spiritually undecided. He encouraged preachers to think of themselves as marketers, insisting that a revival was “not a miracle, nor dependent on a miracle,” but a “right use of the constituted means.”

Mark Noll, a historian of religion, argues that revivalism in America brought vitality to the church but left it intellectually impoverished—a “scandal of the evangelical mind.” Nevertheless, the revivalists got their results. Religious adherence surged in the nineteenth century; by the twentieth, the majority of Americans belonged to a church.

In “Chosen Land,” Sutton identifies four streams of Christian belief which emerged as the nation matured: conservative, revivalist, liberal, and liberationist. Christians who drew from the conservative stream emphasized tradition and historic creeds; revivalists prioritized the conversion of souls and the transformation of individual lives; liberals sought to adapt Christian theology to the latest intellectual currents; and liberationists saw faith as a vehicle for social justice. The streams occasionally flowed together in a single, mighty river. At other times, they split and moved in opposite directions.

In the nineteen-twenties, the topology of faith was dramatically shifting. Acceptance of Charles Darwin’s theory of evolution, along with loosened sexual mores and technological progress, threatened to dislodge the church’s primacy in American life. The journalist Walter Lippmann noted the “dissolution of the old modes of thought” and the way the “circumstances of life” had conspired with “the intellectual habits of the time to render any fixed and authoritative belief incredible to large masses of men.” The needs of religious consumers were changing, and church leaders scrambled to adapt.

On Sunday, May 21, 1922, the First Presbyterian Church in Manhattan became the site of a fork in the river. The church’s parklike campus took up an entire block on Fifth Avenue, and its high pulpit was occupied by Harry Emerson Fosdick, a bespectacled liberal Baptist minister. Fosdick had acquired renown as the author of a series of devotional books on prayer, faith, and service. At First Presbyterian, his irenic, empathetic sermons became public spectacles. On Sunday mornings, lines extended outside the sanctuary doors, and ushers seated worshippers in every nook of the church, even on cushions on the altar stairs.

Fosdick was part of the modernist movement in American Protestantism, which grappled with the implications of evolution and with new scholarship about the Bible’s origins. Liberal clergy abandoned certain tenets of Christian orthodoxy—the Virgin Birth, Christ’s miracles—for a more literary and historical approach to the Bible. Many were proponents of the so-called Social Gospel, arguing that believers’ obligations to the poor and needy were just as important as the project of soul-winning. In response, an

alarmed cohort of theological conservatives pledged to defend the “fundamentals” of the faith and root out liberalism in their denominations.

Fosdick’s sermon on that fateful spring day had been advertised in the city’s newspapers: “Shall the Fundamentalists Win?” From the pulpit, he argued that “new knowledge and the old faith had to be blended in a new combination.” He castigated fundamentalism as “illiberal and intolerant.” He suggested that there was room for a spectrum of theological views in the church. “Opinions may be mistaken,” he said. “Love never is.” Fosdick later insisted that he had intended his message as a “plea for good will.” He instead succeeded in starting a war.

A group of conservative Presbyterians, including William Jennings Bryan, the populist firebrand and thrice-failed Democratic Presidential candidate, tried to force Fosdick from the pulpit. The fracas played out in heated sermons, editorials, and denominational meetings. In 1924, Fosdick finally resigned. The following year, however, the fundamentalist advance stalled in Dayton, Tennessee, when Bryan took the stand as a “Bible expert” during the trial of John Thomas Scopes, a teacher who had been arrested for violating a state law that prohibited the teaching of evolution. Bryan’s stumbling responses, under questioning from the legendary defense lawyer Clarence Darrow, left him humiliated. The fundamentalist movement became a national laughingstock. Lippmann later wrote that fundamentalism’s ideas no longer appealed to “the best brains and the good sense of a modern community.”

The market had seemingly chosen. Fundamentalists found themselves excluded from the nation’s major denominations, but they were hardly defeated. They threw themselves into establishing their own Bible schools, independent churches, and mission organizations. They experimented with new forms of media, founding radio programs that combined upbeat hymns and accessible messages. They made a point of minimizing denominational differences, lowering barriers to entry for newcomers. Even in exile, the dynamism of the fundamentalist movement enabled it to grow.

In the fall of 1949, Billy Graham, a thirty-year-old evangelist with a square jaw and swept-back hair, began preaching under a giant tent in downtown Los Angeles, dubbed the “canvas cathedral.” Graham was a product of

fundamentalism's wilderness period. He'd graduated from Wheaton College, in Illinois, the preëminent fundamentalist institution of higher learning, and honed his skills as a revivalist travelling the country for Youth for Christ, an evangelistic ministry for teen-agers. In Los Angeles, Graham catapulted to national prominence, preaching for eight consecutive weeks to some three hundred and fifty thousand people.

Graham went on to hold mass meetings, or crusades, as he called them, in dozens of American cities. He became the avatar of a burgeoning "new evangelical" movement whose adherents were deeply influenced by fundamentalism, even as they eschewed the label. As Wilensky-Lanford explains, the new evangelicals hoped to build a more inclusive faith that engaged the broader culture and demonstrated how "Christians could be both modern and conservative." In Graham, they found an ideal ambassador. His media savvy and relentless focus on an unadorned Gospel message helped him build a diverse coalition that crossed denominational lines.

In the turbulence of the sixties and early seventies, when racial, gender, and sexual norms were upended anew, American churches underwent a "great re-sorting," as Sutton puts it. White evangelical churches—revivalists, under Sutton's classification system—experienced remarkable growth, while liberal mainline Protestant churches withered. Sutton points to, among other factors, a gap between the progressive stances adopted by mainline clergy and the more conservative views of the average mainline churchgoer. Sensing an opportunity, many evangelicals—particularly those with what the historian George Marsden has called "fundamentalistic" attitudes—began shifting their attention to the political realm. "They positioned race, gender, and sexuality at the center of their resurrected and refashioned crusade to once again remake the United States as God's chosen land," Sutton writes. The result was the rise of the modern religious right. By the end of the twentieth century, this fundamentalism-inflected evangelicalism, with its muscular politics, was the unequivocal winner in America's religious economy.

Many of the most prominent entrepreneurs in the American church today straddle the spiritual and the political. In the late nineteen-eighties, David Barton, a former youth pastor and math and science teacher, founded WallBuilders, an organization in Aledo, Texas, "dedicated to teaching

America's forgotten history and heroes, emphasizing the moral, Christian, and constitutional foundation on which our nation was built." Barton was not a trained historian—his degree, from Oral Roberts University, was in religious education—but he had developed a hobbyist's interest in the Founding Fathers. In 1989, he published his first book, "The Myth of Separation," which promised to reveal to readers "what the Founders and early Courts *really* said" about the separation of church and state. He went on to write more than twenty books, becoming the leading salesman for a cottage industry of historical misinformation that reached deep into the world of evangelical churches, home schools, and advocacy organizations. Barton's work has been eviscerated by scholars, but this has hardly dented his popularity. In "[One State Under God: A History of Religion in Texas](#)" (University of Texas Press), the historian Joseph L. Locke notes that readers of Barton's books weren't looking for rigorous research. "Instead, they wanted a weapon," Locke writes. "And Barton was handing them one."

The fusion of Christianity and nationalism that Barton promotes is not new, though it has taken different forms in the course of American history. The First Amendment's ambiguity means that, as Sutton points out, "Americans have never really separated church from state." Activists of all kinds, from Frederick Douglass to Jerry Falwell, have wielded the Bible and sought political power. It's inarguable, however, that Donald Trump's ascendance has nourished a darker, more volatile version of the phenomenon. Tapping into the lineage of white evangelicalism, with its charismatic leaders, anti-intellectualism, and political militancy, the *MAGA* movement has placed a nostalgia for a Christian past at the center of a grievance-based politics.

Barton's pseudo-scholarship furnished Christian nationalists with valuable ammunition, but the movement needed foot soldiers. In 2012, an eighteen-year-old named Charlie Kirk founded Turning Point USA, a nonprofit organization meant to promote fiscal conservatism among young people. Kirk had been a Christian since childhood, but he was initially circumspect about his faith, arguing that religious conservatives had erred by imposing their beliefs "through government policy." In 2019, however, Kirk met Rob McCoy, a pastor who challenged Kirk to more aggressively bring his Christian world view into the public arena. The following year, at the Conservative Political Action Conference, Kirk lauded President Trump for understanding "the seven mountains of cultural influence"—an evangelical

vision, dating to the nineteen-seventies, that calls on believers to influence the realms of family, religion, education, media, entertainment, business, and government. Kirk embraced the idea himself, building a media empire and organizing a grassroots army to turn out Trump voters during the 2024 election. Last year, after a gunman shot and killed Kirk at a campus event in Utah, his wife, Erika, a former Miss Arizona who started her own ministry organization and a faith-based clothing company, vowed to carry on her husband's legacy, "fighting the good fight for our country."

She's doing so at an opportune moment for the American church. Although only about two-thirds of Americans now identify as Christians—compared with just under ninety per cent in the nineteen-nineties—a recent Pew Research Center survey concluded that the erosion in belief has likely levelled off. New data from Gallup show a surge of religiosity among young men. It seems possible that Christianity is once again on the upswing in America.

As in the past, its form will be determined by the religious marketplace. The First Amendment's "disestablishment and free-exercise clauses do not dictate outcomes," Sutton writes. "They offer choices." The sociologists Roger Finke and Rodney Stark have argued that, historically, the most popular religious bodies tend to exert a countervailing force on the culture at large. They demand sacrifice from their adherents but also promise temporal and eternal rewards. Expecting churches that preach a distant, unresponsive God to be attractive to new believers is akin, Finke and Stark write, to believing that soccer fans would buy tickets to matches with "players who, for lack of a ball, just stand around." In this way, they explain the extraordinary rise of evangelicalism.

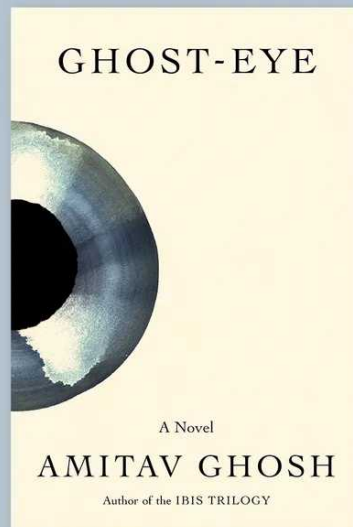
Could these churches, which have dominated the marketplace for a half century, change? Or could an upstart that prioritizes love and mercy, say, over dominion lure away their customers? Plenty of evangelical pastors, writers, and advocates have called for and modelled a more compassionate and inclusive faith. The issue is one of scale. Can a rivulet turn into a river? It would demand charismatic religious entrepreneurs championing a countercultural, supernatural faith that encourages its followers to love their neighbors and grow in grace. Perhaps such a gospel could flood the nation. ♦

Books

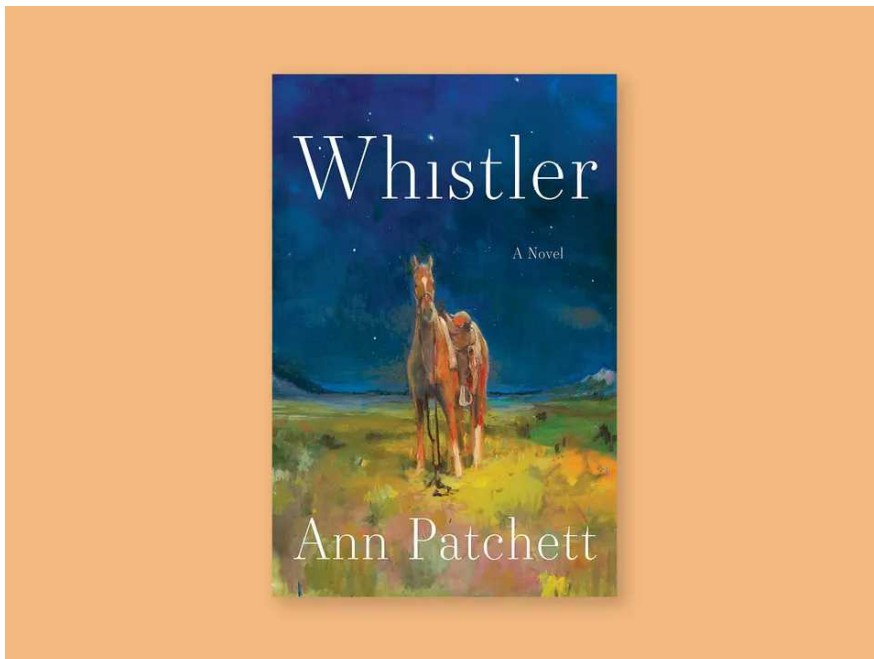
Briefly Noted

“Ghost-Eye,” “Whistler,” “Newcomers,” and “Fires in the Night.”

June 15, 2026



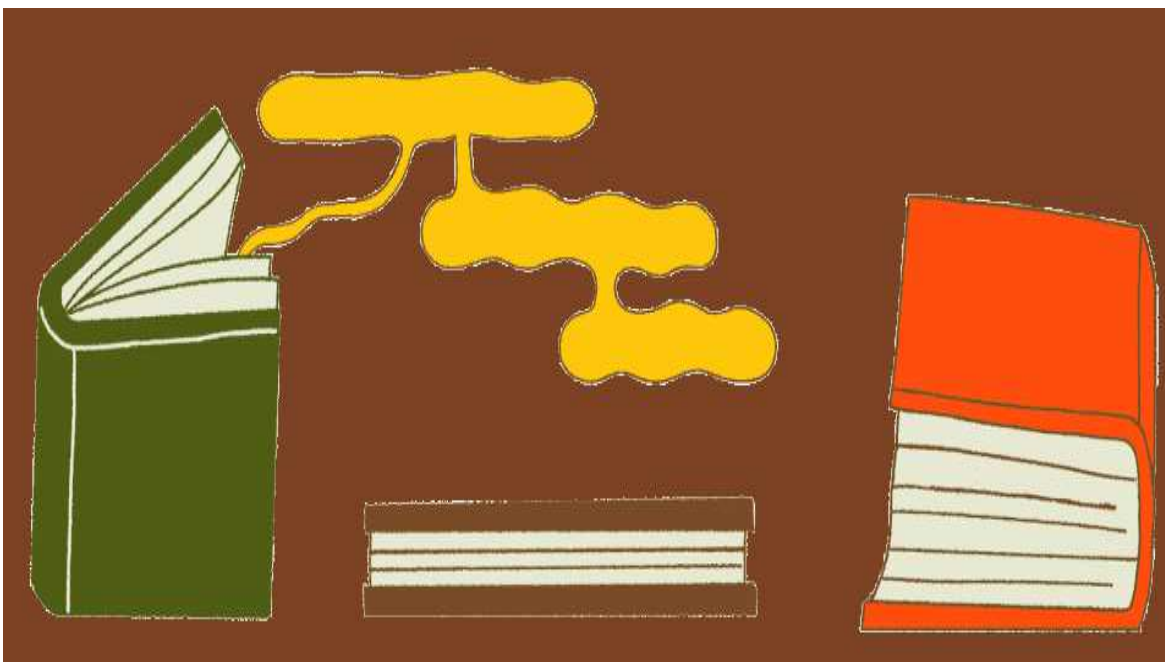
Ghost-Eye, by Amitav Ghosh (*Farrar, Straus & Giroux*). This sweeping novel opens in nineteen-sixties Calcutta, when a three-year-old girl demands to eat fish, shocking her family of Jains. Disturbed, her parents summon a psychologist, who concludes that she is the reincarnation of a person who grew up in a fishing village in the Sundarban forests, to the southeast. Fifty years later, an energy corporation announces plans to build a plant in that area, threatening ecological devastation. The psychologist's adult nephew has been recruited by an environmentalist who believes that the psychologist's case files hold the key to saving the forest. The story—replete with history and science, spiritualism and synchronicities—suggests that to find salvation, we must “remind ourselves of the old ways.”



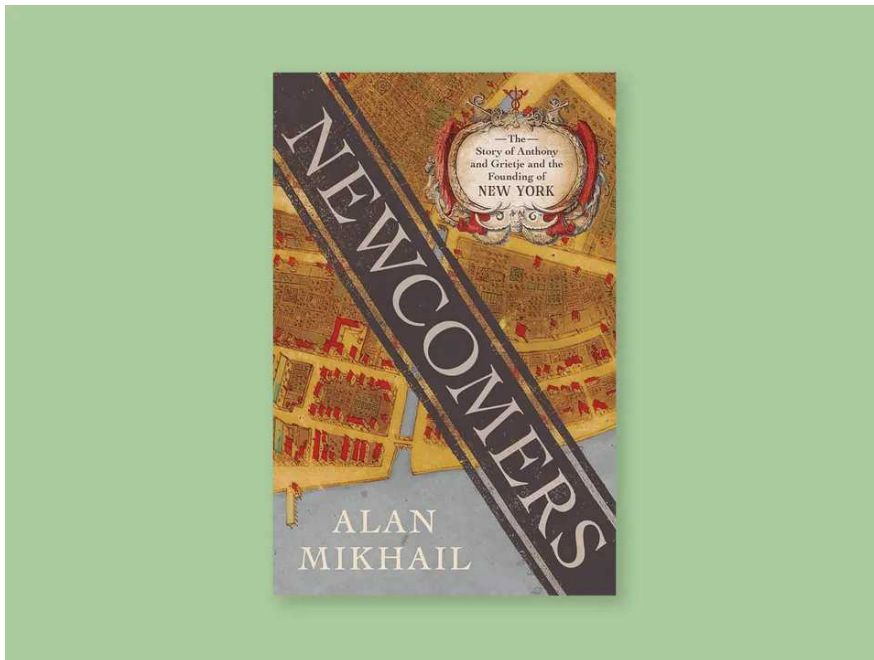
Whistler, by Ann Patchett (*Harper*). When Daphne, the middle-aged narrator of this pensive novel, was a child, she developed a precious bond with Eddie, her stepfather. But, after the pair got into a car accident, Daphne's mother divorced Eddie, alleging that he was negligent, and then cut him off entirely. Daphne “put the whole thing”—her memories of Eddie, and of that night—“in a box.” For nearly half a century, she left those thoughts untouched. Then Daphne and Eddie run into each other, and, despite all the time that has passed, Daphne finds that the two are still profoundly connected. Together, she and Eddie face their respective pasts,

untangling the feelings of betrayal, regret, and love that emerge in the process.

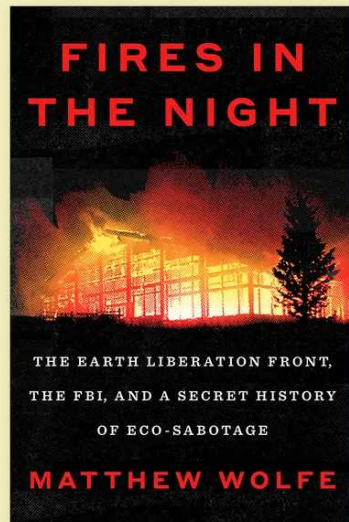
What We're Reading



Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



[Newcomers](#), by *Alan Mikhail (Liveright)*. In this short but powerful biography, Mikhail investigates the lives of Anthony Jansen van Salee and his wife, Grietje Reyniers, who rose from obscure origins—Mikhail speculates that Salee was a freed slave; Reyniers was a barmaid and sex worker—to become one of New Netherland’s founding families. Regarded by their fellow-colonists as “sinful moral outsiders,” van Salee and Reyniers were banished from the colony’s mainstay on Manhattan and forced to live on Long Island. It was there, by means of a war that the colony waged on Native people, that the couple forged new reputations as defenders and “anchors” of Dutch settlement, accruing property, hiring laborers, and joining the ranks of the landed élite.



[Fires in the Night](#), by *Matthew Wolfe (Viking)*. During the nineties and two-thousands, a decentralized activist group known as the Earth Liberation Front set fire to “prominent symbols of ecological destruction” and freed animals from labs and farms. For a time, their actions inspired many climate and environmental activists who were disillusioned with nonviolence. Then, just as the F.B.I.’s antiterrorism efforts rapidly grew in the wake of 9/11, the arsons got out of control—one activist wondered whether they had become “a kind of addiction” that “gradually took on its own independent momentum while producing diminishing effects.” As Wolfe recounts E.L.F. missions, he also details the F.B.I.’s pursuit of its members, in an interplay that allows difficult moral questions to emerge.

Books

When Did White-Collar Work Start to Look So Bleak?

In the nineteen-eighties, an office job promised security and fulfillment. For graduates starting careers today, the prospect is often tinged with dread.

By Molly Fischer

June 15, 2026



This spring, across the nation's auditoriums and quadrangles, members of the class of 2026 took their seats to receive remarks from distinguished guests. The graduation speech is a thankless form: generalized, impersonal exhortation/congratulation is almost guaranteed to be forgettable, if all goes well. But this year, on at least a few American campuses, all did not go well.

At the University of Arizona, Eric Schmidt, the former C.E.O. of Google, told the crowd that artificial intelligence “will touch every profession, every classroom, every hospital, every laboratory, every person, and every relationship you have,” a sweeping promise that landed like a threat. The graduates booed—just as they did at the University of Central Florida, where

the real-estate executive Gloria Caulfield called A.I. “the next Industrial Revolution,” and at Middle Tennessee State University, where the record executive Scott Borchetta responded by telling them to “deal with it.”

It wasn’t so long ago that you could address a commencement-weekend crowd and largely sidestep A.I.—even last year, the subject had not yet assumed quite the same aura of inevitability that it projects today. Jodi Kantor’s new book, [“How to Start: Discovering Your Life’s Work”](#) (Little, Brown), arrives as an artifact from this slightly different era. A slim volume published in time for graduation gift-giving, “How to Start” began as a 2025 Class Day keynote speech at Columbia University. Kantor, a reporter at the *Times*, touches briefly on A.I. in the book, but she is less interested in the forces changing work than in changing the way students feel about it. She herself graduated from Columbia in 1996 and (as she explains in the speech and the book) attended Harvard Law School before dropping out to pursue her dream of being a journalist. “Imagining that anyone would want to read stories that I wrote or edited—who did I think I was?” she recalls thinking. “I was a kid from Staten Island and New Jersey.” She’d go on to edit the *Times*’ Arts & Leisure section before the age of thirty, and to win a Pulitzer for her investigation of Harvey Weinstein. “How to Start,” intended as a guide for young people just beginning their careers, offers advice drawn from her years both working and reporting on working conditions. “I have documented some of the worst of the workplace, and still I am telling you: Do not give up on it,” she implores.

Kantor is an unabashed company woman (“Thank you to all the bosses,” she writes, in a section of the acknowledgments devoted to her employer), but, more than that, she is a partisan of Work writ large. “Cancer therapies, new commercial aircraft, winning political campaigns, and every television show you’ve ever enjoyed were all made by groups of former strangers who labored together in shared discovery, discipline, and purpose,” she writes, as if scripting a public-service announcement for the concept of jobs. But, as much as anything, her cheerleading underscores the ambient dread and despair that she feels obliged to counteract, the same sort of desperation that came into view with this year’s graduation boos. How, exactly, did the prospect of white-collar employment—the future presumed to unfurl before a newly minted college graduate—start to look so bleak?

Kantor's career outlook, her office romance of ambition and fulfillment, harks back to the nineteen-eighties. It's the type of fantasy seen onscreen in Mike Nichols's 1988 movie, "Working Girl," which tells the story of Tess McGill (played by Melanie Griffith), a Wall Street secretary from Staten Island with aspirations as towering and improbable as her hair. She longs to stop covering the phones and to start making deals.

Tess has good ideas—serving dim sum at a cocktail party, for example—but she doesn't have the expensive pedigree or wardrobe of Katharine Parker (Sigourney Weaver), her boss in mergers and acquisitions. Katharine professes a wish to see hard work rewarded; in practice, though, she steals one of Tess's ideas (for averting a hostile takeover) and passes it off as her own. Through a series of cinematic contrivances, Tess borrows Katharine's skirt suit, claims due credit for her business sense, and wins the affections of Katharine's financier boyfriend (Harrison Ford). It's clear, though, that the real reward is an office of her own. The movie ends with the camera pulling back from her window to show the countless others alongside it, a skyscraper's worth of office dwellers filling the screen.

In an earlier era, this panorama might have communicated the puny anonymity of corporate life. A viewer would have understood that the workers within were gray-flannel-clad drones—each one a "small creature who is acted upon but who does not act, who works along unnoticed . . . never talking loud, never talking back, never taking a stand," as C. Wright Mills puts it in the 1951 book "[White Collar](#)." Needless to say, such a scene would not have been set (as it is in "Working Girl") to the swells of Carly Simon singing about dreamers in silver cities. But what Tess wants isn't to be any ordinary white-collar worker. What Tess wants is to be a yuppie, one of the young strivers establishing themselves as media main characters while reshaping the American economy.

Of course, the word "yuppie" never appears in the film. In an appraisal of the type for *Esquire* magazine published the year Nichols's film came out, Hendrik Hertzberg notes that "yuppie" was "understood almost universally as a term of abuse." The young urban professionals—with their Gucci briefcases and their fitness crazes—were pop-sociological punching bags, recognizable enough that anyone could roll their eyes and vague enough that everyone could assume "yuppie" meant someone else. In "Working Girl,"

Katharine is the yuppie as seen from the outside, all cutthroat ambition, finicky taste, and moral vacuity. Tess, meanwhile, suggests a more vulnerable reality behind that brittle exterior—a faith that talent and perseverance can pay off, a desire for agency amid dispiriting circumstances.

The historian Dylan Gottlieb, in his new book, [“Yuppies: The Bankers, Lawyers, Joggers, and Gourmands Who Conquered New York”](#) (Harvard University Press), considers his subject with an eye to this interior view. Gottlieb is no yuppie apologist, but he offers a portrait of yuppie motivations with more nuance than simple consumerism. He does so by focussing on the thing that defined yuppies more deeply than their fondness for Chardonnay or sushi: their work.

“Yuppies” examines the men and women employed in the intertwined fields of finance and Big Law in nineteen-eighties New York—a world then in the midst of transformation. Before the yuppie era, a certain staid gentility prevailed. Banks maintained long-standing relationships with corporate clients; white-shoe law firms didn’t compete for business; hostile takeovers and the like were regarded as somewhat unsavory. All that was about to change. Gottlieb writes that his book’s “precipitating event” is “the unshackling of Wall Street during the Carter and Reagan administrations.” Finance became the center of the American economy, and its gravitational pull drew legions of high-achieving young people to New York.

A proliferation of complicated new financial instruments required more employees to sell (and to explain) them to customers, and more lawyers to hash out the deals. Banks expanded their recruiting efforts on college campuses, with dramatic success. “In 1979, only one in thirty seniors at the University of Pennsylvania headed to Wall Street,” Gottlieb reports. “By 1987, it was one in three.” These recruits differed from their predecessors: they weren’t all men, and they didn’t all come from the field’s traditional hiring pool of Wasp and German Jewish élites. Higher education had diversified in the preceding years, and, when banks ramped up recruiting, they were drawing on a new population’s talent. Even if a Cinderella story like Tess McGill’s was a fairy tale—and even if the upper ranks of power remained stubbornly white and male—the presence of driven outsiders burnished the industry’s preferred image of itself as a meritocracy.

Career, for Gottlieb's yuppies, was a life style: the ethos of hard work and competition which defined their lives on the job pervaded their leisure hours as well. Long-distance running was the most blatant case in point—a punishing feat of endurance that held out the promise of quantified individual success. Marathon-training regimens were the subject of office bonding; lunch-hour jogs supplanted a previous generation's golf and Martinis as occasions for networking. But even pursuits that might appear more obviously indulgent—dining, say—attained gruelling rigor in yuppie hands. Eschewing rote fine dining, Gottlieb writes, the yuppie “accrued more status by consuming omnivorously” (and thus dim sum earns Tess credibility with Katharine). The Zagat restaurant guide began as the hobby of a husband-and-wife pair who'd met at Yale Law, and soon became a popular business gift—one that, in Gottlieb's telling, affirmed giver and receiver alike as “knowing members of the meritocratic elite.”

The flip side of believing that you've won your place through hard work is believing that you need to keep working hard to maintain it, a need that was particularly acute among the newest arrivals in the yuppies' professional milieu. “High starting salaries were an obvious draw for those with large student loans,” Gottlieb notes. Careers in finance had begun to follow a set course—an undergraduate degree, two years as an analyst, an M.B.A., then a mid-level position at a bank—which also meant that recruiters could promise “a well-defined path for students who couldn't rely on familial or class ties to the upper strata of the business world.” Meanwhile, at the law firms that handled Wall Street clients, work grew simultaneously more abundant and less likely to lead to professional advancement. Being an associate had once involved direct mentorship from a firm's partners, and a reasonable chance of becoming a partner oneself, but, with the business deluge of the eighties, firms began hiring young associates in bulk. These associates regularly put in seventy-five-hour weeks on work that had been broken down into tasks requiring little skill and offering little legal education. Because of the associates' sheer numbers, few would ever make partner. “It was no accident that these firms were diversifying in terms of gender and race at the very same time they were making life increasingly miserable for their associates,” Gottlieb writes.

At least some of the yuppies claimed the pace as a point of pride, even a thrill. Gottlieb quotes a onetime associate at the then ascendant law firm

Skadden Arps—which rose to prominence with its handling of mergers and acquisitions—who remembers feeling “electricity pulsing down the hallways.” But the adrenaline accompanied an undercurrent of anxiety. “If anything,” Michael Kinsley wrote in *The New Republic*, in 1984, “yuppy culture is permeated with a sense of *downward* mobility, of couples struggling with two incomes to achieve a middle-class life that their parents enjoyed with one.” Barbara Ehrenreich, in her 1989 book, [“Fear of Falling,”](#) notes that “the female yuppie, whose odd uniform of skirted suit and sneakers symbolized the compromise between capitalism and feminism,” had become a particularly potent caricature. Perhaps this was because women’s hard-won presence in the professional sphere was a reminder that, for the yuppies, there was no world outside work. (“Let’s merge,” Katharine purrs, during an amorous moment in “Working Girl.”)



Notwithstanding the gleefully greedy yuppies who frolicked in the popular imagination, Ehrenreich describes grim resignation among the college students she encountered in the nineteen-eighties. They’d “started out wanting to be environmental chemists, special-education teachers, public administrators, or novelists,” she writes, and they “redirected their aspirations to business or law” only later. “They did so, in most cases, out of a sullen sense of necessity, trading off personal autonomy, idealism, and creativity for what they hoped would be safety and possibly comfort.” Of

course, such individual reluctance does little to blunt the effects of their choices. As junior bankers and Big Law associates, they may have been overworked and locked in competition, but they were also “amassing small fortunes chopping up, spinning off, merging, offshoring, or otherwise squeezing short-term value out of companies that had once offered meaningful security to their employees and other stakeholders,” Gottlieb writes. They had become “the authors of a more unequal chapter in American life.”

For the children of yuppies, “there appeared to be only two outcomes,” Gottlieb writes, in his epilogue. “Dogged pursuit of the yuppie ideal or a steep drop into the precariat.” Or, perhaps, both. By the nineties, when such children were in elementary school, “college for all” had become “a national obsession—the way every American could achieve middle-class affluence,” Noam Scheiber writes in his new book, “[Mutiny](#)” (Farrar, Straus & Giroux). Subtitled “The Rise and Revolt of the College-Educated Working Class,” it follows a cohort of young workers for whom the dogged pursuit of meritocratic success has failed to ward off precarity. Among college graduates in the years immediately following the Great Recession, according to a 2024 analysis, more than half took a job that did not require a degree, and, ten years later, forty-five per cent were still similarly employed. Those graduates at least had jobs; many didn’t. “The new, dramatically negative trend shows no sign of letting up,” Jesse Rothstein, the former chief economist of the U.S. Labor Department, wrote, in a 2020 paper that Scheiber quotes.

Scheiber’s subjects are ambitious, educated, and professionally stymied. They have degrees (and very often tremendous student debt), but the kind of employment that was supposed to be the terminus of their path has failed to materialize. In their frustration, they turn to workplace organizing. Teddy Hoffman was a Starbucks barista and a union leader in his early thirties when Scheiber, a reporter for the *Times*, met him on a Chicago picket line in late 2022. “As we talked, I realized there was something familiar about Teddy’s affect,” Scheiber writes in “Mutiny.” “He had a precise way of speaking, as though sifting thoughts into words, and his manner was both self-effacing and self-assured. He used lots of adverbs.” Hoffman mentions spending time travelling after graduation, and Scheiber asks whether he was backpacking. “I had gotten, uh, a Watson Fellowship,” Hoffman tells him.

This is, Scheiber explains, “a post-graduate scholarship that ranks in prestige near the Rhodes and the Marshall, and is more exclusive than its better-known cousin, the Fulbright.”

A mere Fulbright scholar working at a Starbucks you could understand, or so Scheiber’s tone seems to imply. Hoffman’s mother, when Scheiber later speaks to her, is well acquainted with this flavor of incredulity. “The crap we got from other parents—‘Why are you allowing your son to work at Starbucks?’ ” she remembers. Hoffman started there as a stopgap while holding out hope for other pursuits; he didn’t arrive at his workplace with plans to unionize. (Scheiber speaks to other Starbucks workers elsewhere who did come in with that intention, a practice known as salting.)

But the old equations that linked effort, employment, money, and prestige no longer seem to apply. For Hoffman and his expensively educated peers in the service industry, a white-collar job looks like a fantasy, one that companies play to with a patronizing transparency. Starbucks calls its baristas “partners,” as if title alone could compensate for a lack of authority. Apple Stores, another workplace where Scheiber follows union efforts, employ “geniuses” (who provide tech support) and “creatives” (who teach customer classes); Apple’s retail employees can apply for a program called Career Experience—something like an internship within the company, offering a long-shot chance at a corporate position. Chaya Barrett, a “creative” in Maryland, recalls attending a recruiting event “where candidates were told that getting a job at the Apple Store was more competitive than getting into Harvard, at least on a raw percentage basis.”

This is a workplace speaking the language of meritocracy to employees for whom it is a mother tongue. Without much of a professional outlet, such workers channel the habits that they’ve spent a lifetime honing into other less corporate-friendly pursuits. Scheiber makes it plain (to the detriment, perhaps, of his book’s narrative momentum) that organizing is hard and often anticlimactic work—no task for slackers. When Hoffman’s hours are cut, he takes a second job in order to stay at Starbucks and see the union campaign through.

In 2016, a team led by the economist Raj Chetty published research showing that young people entering the workforce could no longer expect to outearn

their parents. For those born in the nineteen-eighties, the odds were roughly fifty per cent, compared with ninety per cent for those born in 1940. But most of that decline had taken place in the years between the mid-forties and the early sixties. Millennials, famously, had it bad, but baby boomers didn't have it so great themselves. The anxious striving they embodied and inculcated in their children wasn't misguided in either case.

The sociologist Arlie Russell Hochschild spent several years in the early nineties interviewing employees at a corporation she pseudonymously called Amerco. As she documented their efforts to balance work and family life, television provided a context and a backdrop. There were cartoons while dressing children, evening news while cooking dinner, and, before bed, families watched mutely as onscreen families laughed and talked. "Ironically," Hochschild writes, "this entertainment may even show viewers a 'family life' that, as in the sitcoms *Murphy Brown* and *Ink*, has moved to work."

Workplace TV is a stalwart genre. But workplace TV is itself the product of a workplace, and, lately, it's not hard to see evidence of an industry's dim view of office life in a show like "Severance," which depicts employment as a matter of surrendering control of one's mind to the demands of a mysterious corporation. Television writing is one of the white-collar jobs for which the expectation of professional stability has deteriorated in recent years. "Mutiny" connects the struggles of college-educated service workers to new organizing efforts among doctors, architects, and engineers; it also tracks the 2023 strike by the Writers Guild of America.

For years, TV writing was the rare creative field in which work looked a lot like a reliable, even upper-middle-class nine-to-five. Writers found steady employment, steady pay, and health insurance; the industry's business model supported robust staffing for long-running shows and paid residuals as they went into reruns. The rise of streaming services and the growing power of tech companies in Hollywood threatened this prosperity. Like Scheiber's subjects at the Apple Store and Starbucks, young writers "had left college with certain career ambitions, only to find themselves laboring in a different kind of job for longer than expected." As they tried to gain their professional footing, they were "bouncing back and forth between writing jobs and tours as low-paid assistants or jobs in retail and hospitality." Even established

writers were scrambling for fewer and worse positions, and the prospect of A.I.-generated scripts didn't seem far off.

The studios, Scheiber writes, made some flawed assumptions on the eve of the strike. For one, they underestimated the danger that the writers saw from A.I. They also overestimated how secure the older writers felt (or how many writers felt secure at all)—they assumed they'd be able to play the disgruntled youth off an Old Guard faction that would just want to get back to work. Instead, they met a surprising degree of intergenerational solidarity. After more than five months of picket lines, the Writers Guild won a contract that satisfied its membership.

The way people feel about work is a phenomenon larger than any one job, and it involves a sprawling world of relationships. In Hochschild's research, which she wrote up in her 1997 book, "[The Time Bind](#)," she notices something unexpected. People told her that they wanted more time with their families, and Amerco offered policies that were, on paper, generous. Yet few took advantage of them, and, in fact, many Amerco workers seemed to gravitate toward shouldering ever more work. Sometimes this was the result of unspoken norms that official company policies had failed to counteract: an H.R. department talking up flextime didn't suddenly dissipate the arms-race pressure ambitious employees felt to prove their dedication through long hours. Sometimes it was a response to their families' material needs. In either case, work had come to look like a problem and a solution simultaneously. Work was a place to see friends, to accomplish tasks, to receive recognition; it was a place that promised a sense of control, which was particularly seductive because control was so frequently lacking at home. "People wonder: Where do we feel the safest?" Hochschild writes. "Even among those with lousy jobs, the answer is sometimes 'at work.' "

This sense of control is the crux of Jodi Kantor's ode to jobs. "For many of us, work is the route to satisfaction over which we often have the most agency," she writes. "In a healthy work setting the rules of the game have clarity: if we are hard-working, strategic, skilled, and collegial, we maximize our results." But "many of us" and "often" are hedges that are (as they say) doing a lot of work. The workplace's sense of control can prove illusory—as it did in the era of yuppie-wrought corporate consolidation, and as it does now for graduates entering an economy destabilized by new uncertainties.

Kantor expresses an empathy for young people that the more callous of this year's graduation speakers seemed to lack. (Pull up YouTube, and you can watch Eric Schmidt smile while dismissing the fear "your generation" has of the future.) A call for cross-generational collaboration is where Hochschild arrives at the end of "The Time Bind." Perhaps, she muses, factory workers and frazzled yuppie parents could "find common cause in their children"—children, that is, of the eighties and nineties. "In fact, the most ardent constituency for a solution to the time bind are those too young as yet to speak up." They were then, but they aren't anymore. ♦

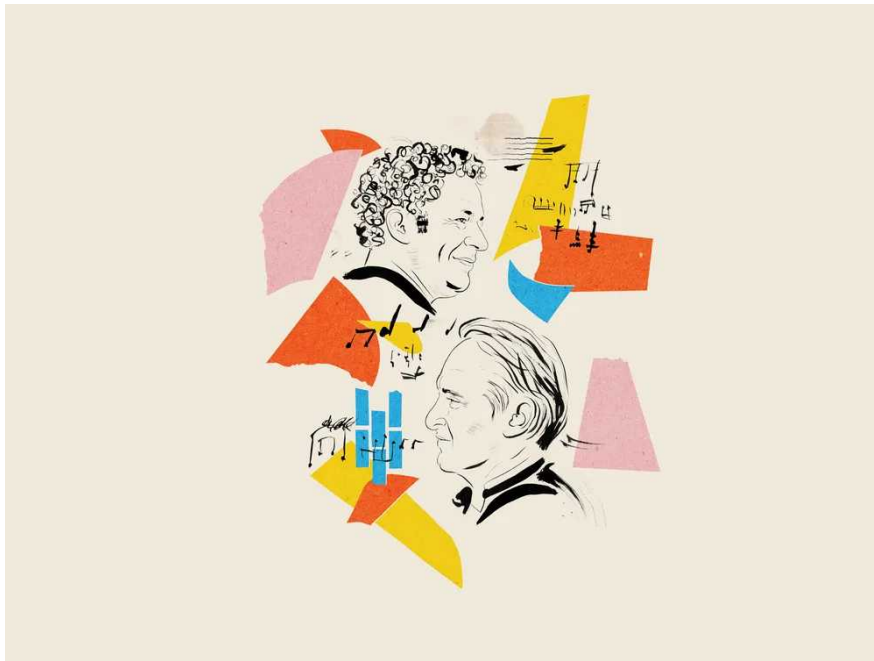
Musical Events

Gustavo Dudamel and James Conlon Bid L.A. Goodbye

Two progressive conductors depart, but Frank Gehry's legacy to the city is growing.

By Alex Ross

June 15, 2026



Frank Gehry died on December 5th of last year, at the age of ninety-six. My father had passed away five days earlier, at the same age, and under the circumstances I was unable to write the tribute that Gehry's death demanded. The gist of it would have been that Gehry was the greatest builder of concert halls of modern times. Recently, the architect has been on my mind again, as I've been making weekly visits to Disney Hall, his silver-winged masterpiece, to hear some of Gustavo Dudamel's final concerts as the music director of the L.A. Philharmonic. Other halls may have a richer, more reverberant acoustic, although Disney's is still uncommonly fine. Certainly, many have a longer, grander history; Disney opened in 2003. But it is a place where tradition and modernity achieve equilibrium—where both

Beethoven and Meredith Monk feel at home. The space encourages boldness; at the same time, it possesses, as the architecture critic Christopher Hawthorne has commented, a “warmheartedness,” a “small-d democratic sensibility.” It’s the hall I’ve come to love more than any other: music’s mellow citadel.

A few years ago, I visited Gehry at his studio, in Santa Monica. When I blurted out my fondness for Disney, he responded, in his impish way, “Tell them to let me do more concert halls!” Aside from Disney, he had built the Beckmen *YOLA* Center, for the Youth Orchestra Los Angeles; the Fisher Center, at Bard College; the New World Center, in Miami; and Pierre Boulez Saal, in Berlin. Gehry showed me a model of a new hall, which was then in the planning stages and is now nearing completion: a music-and-dance complex for the Colburn School, down the hill from Disney. The other day, I received a hard-hat tour of the site. The exterior is less theatrical than Disney’s, its shape rectilinear rather than curvaceous, yet a pink hue adds the requisite Gehry jazz. The main auditorium, which will seat up to a thousand people, promises to replicate the vertiginous intimacy of Boulez Saal, with an oval balcony encircling the orchestra level and cloud-shaped panels floating above. Yasuhisa Toyota, Gehry’s wizardly acoustical collaborator, is looking after the sonics; Craig Webb, the partner at Gehry’s firm who specializes in concert halls, is overseeing the design. When the Colburn center opens, next year, it will complement the big space up the hill, presenting local and touring groups alongside the school’s own artists.

The L.A. Phil paid tribute to Gehry in January with a concert titled “Music for Frank.” The pianist Víkingur Ólafsson played the aria from Bach’s Goldberg Variations, nodding to the fact that Gehry was born Ephraim Goldberg, in Canada. Esa-Pekka Salonen, Dudamel’s predecessor as the orchestra’s music director, offered his own score “Wing on Wing,” in which Gehry’s voice is heard rumbling in the background. Herbie Hancock conjured what sounded like a lost Debussy *Prélude*. Dudamel led “Wild Nights,” from John Adams’s “*Harmonium*,” and the final movement of Mahler’s Third Symphony. These choices reflected Gehry’s own enthusiasms in music old and new; he was a great builder of concert halls not least because he spent a good part of his life in them. Since December, I’ve missed seeing him in his usual seat in the front-orchestra section, with his wife, Berta, at his side. Yet he has been present all the same. To adapt

Christopher Wren's epitaph at St. Paul's Cathedral: If you seek his monument, look and listen.

When Dudamel was announced as Salonen's successor at the L.A. Phil, in 2007, he was only twenty-six, and aglow with a celebrity that is bestowed on just a handful of classical musicians. I spoke to him on the day of the announcement and got the sense that he knew how much work lay in front of him. He told me that he needed to absorb swaths of repertory and find his relationship with the progressive musical organism that Salonen had brought into being—one that had been infused with the modern energy of Gehry's structure. At the same time, Dudamel made clear that he was not exactly a neophyte. Since the age of eighteen, he had been conducting up to ninety concerts a year with the youth orchestras of Venezuela, where he was born.

Dudamel's most conspicuous legacy to L.A. has been his devotion to music education. It was at his behest that the Youth Orchestra Los Angeles was launched and a home for it found. (Gehry repurposed an old bank building in Inglewood.) *YOLA* players have regularly come to Disney to participate in L.A. Phil events. Some of them were on hand for Dudamel's final concert at Disney, which paired Adams's cosmic "Harmonium" with Antonio Estévez's pungent "Cantata Criolla." (Dudamel's official farewell to the orchestra will take place in August, when he leads Beethoven's Ninth at the Hollywood Bowl.) Thousands of young people have benefitted from free *YOLA* programs, not only at the Inglewood center but also at satellite sites across the city. The challenge will be to insure that *YOLA* stays strong after Dudamel has moved on. Late last year, the L.A. Phil announced that it was curtailing *YOLA* activities at Esteban E. Torres High School, in East L.A. After a local uproar, the program was temporarily reinstated.

The L.A. Phil's bias toward the new remains in force: Dudamel has presided over more than sixty world premières. From the outset, he proved a committed interpreter of such complex scores as Adams's dramatic oratorio "The Gospel According to the Other Mary," Thomas Adès's evening-length ballet "Dante," and Kaija Saariaho's song cycle "True Fire." But these composers were already well known in L.A. Dudamel's engagement with contemporary music kicked into a higher gear about a decade ago, when he began commissioning Latino composers en masse. His championing of the Mexican composer Gabriela Ortiz, in particular, resulted in a procession of

large-scale works, including the choral ballet “Revolución Diamantina,” which honors Mexican protests against misogynist violence. Having introduced that fiercely luminous piece in 2023, Dudamel brought it back in March, placing it on the second half of a concert that began with Beethoven’s Seventh. He accorded a similar prominence to Adès’s roiling “Inferno,” the first part of “Dante,” putting it alongside Beethoven’s Sixth. He thus reaffirmed the local rule that new music is not a sideshow but the main event.

With that contemporary bent has come a degree of political boldness. In February, the L.A. Phil played Beethoven’s incidental music for Goethe’s play “Egmont,” and Dudamel brought in the playwright Jeremy O. Harris and the actor Cate Blanchett to fashion a modern meta-commentary on Goethe’s tale of rebellion against despotism. The resulting spectacle won no points for coherence or subtlety—at one point, Blanchett referenced recent demonstrations against *ICE*, and at another she yelled, “Fucking bitch!”—but it had the virtue of being chaotic and jolting, which is something you generally cannot say about American orchestral events. (Next year, the production will be mounted at the New York Philharmonic, where Dudamel becomes music director in the fall.) Themes of environmental crisis figured in several commissions, notably Ellen Reid’s “Earth Between Oceans,” which, back in September, filled Disney with an apocalyptic roar.

What still puzzles me, amid all these noteworthy projects, is Dudamel’s way with the standard repertory. Although his skill and discipline are never in doubt, he tends toward a bustling sameness. Dynamics often peak too early, robbing tension from later stages of a score. This going-to-eleven syndrome surfaced both in the “Egmont” Overture and in Beethoven’s Seventh. (By way of contrast, Manfred Honeck, in a guest appearance in April, elicited an extraordinary Tchaikovsky Fifth that proceeded from fraught murmurs to thunderclaps of passion.) Dudamel displayed a surer sense of narrative in Wagner’s “Die Walküre,” in May—a final collaboration with Gehry, who had designed evocative sets for the opera, playing off Disney’s twisty forms and earthy tones. Act I passed in a noisy blur, but Act III created real momentum. “Ride of the Valkyries” began in understated fashion, with sprightly, dancing rhythms. The intensity increased stepwise until, with nine Valkyries singing at full force, Dudamel unleashed a climactic storm of sound. It felt like another salute to Frank.

Dudamel leaves an orchestra in excellent technical shape, though it still has room to grow. He has hired more than fifty musicians during his tenure, and his penultimate event at Disney featured many of them in a whirlwind program of short concertante selections. Pride of place went to the woodwind principals, all Dudamel picks. The clarinetist Boris Allakhverdyan exhibited spectacular jazz chops in Artie Shaw's Concerto for Clarinet. The flutist Denis Bouriakov and the bassoonist Whitney Crockett applied pinpoint dexterity to Paganini and Rossini, respectively. The oboist Ryan Roberts, who joined the L.A. Phil this season, was wrenchingly songful in the Adagio from Alessandro Marcello's Oboe Concerto. John Williams served up a feast for the trumpet section in the form of a vibrant new miniature titled "Bravo Gustavo!" The brass are generally much sturdier than they used to be, with two first-rate horn players, Andrew Bain and David Cooper, anchoring the section. The strings lag a little behind. The musicians are individually superb, yet the ensemble sometimes lacks tonal weight and richness. I'd expected Dudamel to make more progress in this area than he did.

Such tasks now fall to Daniel Harding, who has been announced as Dudamel's successor. A British former protégé of Simon Rattle and Claudio Abbado, Harding has lately come into his own as a conductor with an exacting ear for balance, nuance, and structure. In 2024, I heard him lead Strauss's "Ein Heldenleben" at the L.A. Phil, and it was a more persuasively plotted interpretation of the piece than one that Dudamel offered in May. Harding has less of a reputation as a new-music advocate, but Salonen, who has maintained ties to L.A., will apply his expertise, presenting around six concerts a season. Dudamel, too, plans to return often, and the young German conductor Anna Handler has been given a curatorial role. In essence, the L.A. Phil is backing away from the model of a dominant music director and instead trying out a multi-baton system. It's a risky move, but perhaps a wise one: the Dudamel era has shown both the power and the limits of superstar charisma.

Even if most of the hoopla has surrounded Dudamel, with "*gracias gustavo*" banners festooning the city, L.A. is losing another major conductor this summer. James Conlon, the music director of L.A. Opera, is departing after a twenty-year tenure. If Dudamel's track record with the mainstream repertory has been irregular, Conlon's has been remarkably consistent. This

season, he was on the podium for Bernstein's "West Side Story," Verdi's "Falstaff," Britten's "Noye's Fludde," and Mozart's "The Magic Flute," and in each case he delivered the kind of performance that feels idiomatic at every turn without calling attention to itself. A veteran who has been active in opera for more than five decades, Conlon knows how to adjust tempos, phrasing, and sonorities to the style at hand. His Bernstein had visceral, vernacular punch; his Verdi was ardent and spry; his Britten had the right textural grit; his Mozart unfurled with complicated grace. This kind of agility is sorely lacking these days at the Metropolitan Opera. Conlon was once a regular there, but, for whatever reason, he has been rarely seen of late.

Conlon arrived at L.A. Opera with grand ambitions to expand its repertory, some of which went unfulfilled. His early years were marked by the financial fiasco of Achim Freyer's production of Wagner's "Ring"—a hieratic, cryptic affair that somehow cost thirty-two million dollars and struggled at the box office. Aspirations for a staging of "Die Meistersinger" came to naught. Conlon also launched Recovered Voices, an initiative to revive operas by composers who had been murdered or driven into exile during the Nazi era. Having acquired a near-scholarly grasp of the material and its historical context, Conlon presented vital readings of such shadowy early-twentieth-century masterpieces as Franz Schreker's "Die Gezeichneten" and Alexander Zemlinsky's "Der Zwerg." In 2007, he led Kurt Weill's "Rise and Fall of the City of Mahagonny"—a rugged tour de force starring Audra McDonald and Patti LuPone.

One aspect of Conlon's tenure at L.A. Opera deserves special mention, though it may seem trivial at first glance. Before almost every performance he conducts, he gives an introductory talk. These lectures start an hour before curtain and often finish with only a few minutes to spare. His remarks on "The Magic Flute" drew listeners' attention to Mozart's Masonic numerological games, such as his groupings of notes and chords in threes and fives. Conlon throws in quips and personal details, revealing, for example, that when he led "The Magic Flute" in his student days he fell in love with the singer portraying Papagena—Jennifer Ringo, to whom he has been married since 1987. I can't think of a conductor today who works harder to communicate with the public. It's no surprise that hundreds of people turn out for Conlon's talks, and that the ovations for him in recent

weeks have been no less passionate than the ones for Dudamel at Disney. Rejecting the nonsense mystique of the maestro, Conlon demonstrates that only two things matter in the end: knowledge and conviction. ♦

Pop Music

The Hell-Raising Rocker Who Conquered Country Radio

Koe Wetzel, who broke out with a song about driving drunk to Taco Bell, reintroduces himself on a new album, “The Night Champion.”

By Kelefa Sanneh

June 12, 2026



About a decade ago, an aspiring rock star from Texas named Koe Wetzel had the mixed fortune of writing a song that stuck to him. The verses chronicled one of the most miserable nights of his life, which involved a handle of cheap vodka and an ill-advised food run in his pickup truck; it ended with him face down in a field, where he was arrested for public intoxication. In the refrain, a drunken question from that night was reborn as a surprisingly euphonious lyric, one that crowds now howl back at him at every show he plays: “Who is sober enough to drive me to Taco Bell?” Wetzel called the song “February 28, 2016,” after the text under his mug shot. It became a fan favorite, helping Wetzel and his band sell out increasingly large halls, especially but not only in Texas. And his fans began

observing Koe Wetzel Day every year, sending him messages in early March to tell him about the hell they'd raised in his honor.

"I fucking hate that song, dude," Wetzel told me, sitting on his tour bus. "On a craft level, I like it. But what it represents—like, I'm not the same person anymore." It was February 27th, the day before his holiday, and he had returned to his home town for a surprisingly wholesome celebration. Wetzel grew up in Pittsburg, in East Texas, where his father ran highway-construction crews, and this year a good chunk of the local population turned out to honor him. At a ceremony downtown, the mayor presented Wetzel with a key to the city and unveiled a mural depicting him in a cowboy hat, flanked by a guitar and his old high-school football jersey. "We're doing this for tomorrow, for the *uniqueness* of February 28th," the mayor said—a delicate way of acknowledging that the day of civic pride had been inspired by a night of debauchery. After the ceremony, Wetzel led a procession to Pittsburg Hot Links, a beloved sausage restaurant, trailed by high-school cheerleaders and a marching band. He held his baby daughter, Woods, who, he said, inspired him to avoid the kind of night that might require police intervention. "I've got responsibilities now," he told me. "Back then, I didn't have any."

Wetzel's personal evolution has accompanied a professional one. His group, which was originally called Koe Wetzel and the Konvikts, started out as a bar band, known for giving local audiences what they wanted, which was a mix of Texas country music and bare-bones rock and roll. He found ways to maintain this no-frills approach even as the stages got bigger. One of his songs is called "FGA," which is an exhaustive list of the chords it requires: F, G, and A minor. Bar bands in Texas have been playing rowdy rock music for generations, but Wetzel's brawny and sometimes bleak version of it reflected the influence of Nirvana and other grunge bands he loved as a kid. Often, he wrote songs about melancholy outlaws. "Forever" begins by introducing us to an antihero—"Well, I left town with a chip on my shoulder / Toting twenty-seven dollars' worth of cheap cocaine"—but ends up more interested in the woman who tells him, in the chorus, "If you want, I can just stay with you forever."

As Wetzel's audience grew, he signed to Columbia Records, and occasionally found himself booked to play festivals alongside country

singers who were popular in a different way: they didn't sell as many tickets as he did, but their songs were much better known. This is the power of country radio, and Wetzel began to wonder whether he, too, might find a way to harness it. He knew that fans back home might not like the change. "Whenever Texas artists make that jump to mainstream, it kind of deteriorates them a little bit in Texas," he said. But he began travelling to Nashville, and eventually fell in with Gabe Simon, a songwriter and producer who is best known for his work with the folk-pop star Noah Kahan. Wetzel came to see collaborative songwriting as a way not to mute his point of view but to sharpen it. "High Road," a scornful breakup song, was written with a team that included Simon and the pop songwriter Amy Allen, and featured a verse by the country-influenced pop singer Jessie Murph. It's a rock ballad, but it was so popular online that label executives thought it could become a country hit, and Wetzel agreed to make a small but significant revision, recording a radio-friendly version in which "I don't need a ticket to your shit show" became "I don't need a ticket to your freak show." This experiment worked better than anyone could have predicted: in late 2024, the song went to No. 1 on country radio and stayed there for five weeks; it was the most-played song on country radio in 2025.

Wetzel's new album, "The Night Champion," is his chance to introduce himself to some new fans and maybe reintroduce himself to his old ones. It was mainly produced by Simon; he also helped write most of the songs, along with Carrie K, a Nashville songwriter, and Josh Serrato, Wetzel's longtime guitarist and friend. "The Night Champion" is a recognizably country album, and Columbia Records is encouraging radio stations to play "Hurts Like You," a country-rock song about a man who realizes he'd rather suffer a tumultuous relationship than suffer alone. The Nashville approach prioritizes clear story lines and catchy refrains. Wetzel sings, "Drag me through the dirt like you always do / I can take the pain if it hurts like you," and the brisk tempo suggests that this might be a love story, after all. (As it happens, Wetzel announced his engagement to his longtime girlfriend this past April.) Fans who miss the old Koe might be somewhat mollified by "Nowhere Fast," a snarling rock song that gives Wetzel a chance to hyperventilate into a harmonica and sing about being sick of just about everything: "Maybe try something new / Fuck a bitch with a face tattoo / Anything right now will do / 'Cause I'm bored straight outta my mind."

Perhaps Wetzel is already thinking about a radio-friendly alternate line. *Make a friend* with a face tattoo?

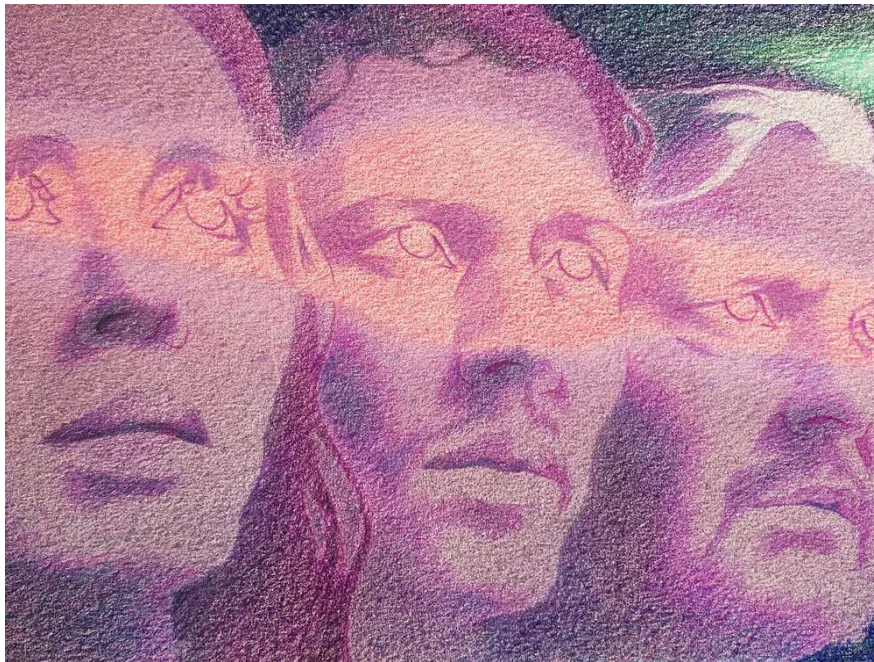
It is a good moment, apparently, for Texas rock and roll. One of the TikTok accounts celebrating Koe Day this year belonged to Dexter and the Moonrocks, a band from Throckmorton, west of Dallas, which has cited Wetzel as an influence and is responsible for perhaps the year's most viral rock hit: a fuzzy, slow-motion song called "Freakin' Out." (The band has described its sound as "Western space grunge.") Last month, Dexter and the Moonrocks released a song titled "12 Steps," featuring another Texas act, Treaty Oak Revival, from Odessa, known for a strikingly pretty combination of loud guitars and twangy singing; the band spent part of 2024 as the opening act for Wetzel, who, at the age of thirty-three, is starting to seem like an elder statesman of this scene. He celebrated February 28th this year in Fort Worth, at Koe Wetzel's Riot Room, a bar he owns. (There is also one in Houston.) It's big, but not nearly big enough for the crowd that Wetzel draws, so he shut down the street and built a stage on it, and fans filled the block. "Ten years is a long time to be doing this shit," he told them, with a smile. "Thank you for coming out to celebrate the night that I went to jail." Wetzel told the audience that he had recently spoken with the police officer who'd arrested him that night, and that he'd turned out to be "a really great guy." And then he headed offstage and downstairs to a private basement bar, where dozens of family members and friends seemed ready to celebrate with him for as long as he could keep the party going. ♦

In “Disclosure Day,” Steven Spielberg Replays the Hits

His new alien thriller has shades of “Close Encounters of the Third Kind,” “Minority Report,” even “The Post”—but the retreads yield diminishing returns.

By Justin Chang

June 10, 2026



It’s been nearly four years since we’ve had a new Steven Spielberg picture—an unusually long, but understandable, wait. Spielberg, though as nimble an entertainer as we’ve got, will turn eighty this December, and the halcyon overachieving years of “Jurassic Park” and “Schindler’s List” (1993), “Minority Report” and “Catch Me If You Can” (2002), and “War of the Worlds” and “Munich” (2005) seem far behind him. His most recent feature, “The Fabelmans” (2022), was the kind of piercingly confessional work that might have put a lesser filmmaker out to pasture (not that a lesser filmmaker could have made “The Fabelmans”). After digging deep into his formative memories—chief among them his childhood surrender to the movies, which

would define him, and which he would forever redefine—where, exactly, could Spielberg go next?

The opening scenes of his new blockbuster, “Disclosure Day,” offer up a hilarious answer: a pro-wrestling match, of course, for a rejuvenating dose of adrenaline. It’s a more pummelling kind of Spielberg spectacle than we’re used to, and also a canny diversion; in the bleachers, a far more consequential clash of wills is secretly playing out. Daniel Kellner (Josh O’Connor), a sharp-witted cybersecurity expert, plans to blow the whistle on the sinister non-government agency *wardex*, short for Waived Reporting, Development, and Extraction. His former boss, Noah Scanlon (Colin Firth), is determined to stop him from exposing the group’s secrets: namely, that alien life-forms exist, and that the agency has concealed evidence of their visits for decades.

Soon, Daniel has fled with his girlfriend, Jane (Eve Hewson), and a device loaded with incriminating evidence, which they plan to make public if Scanlon and his minions don’t kill them first. Explaining his Snowdenesque attack of conscience, Daniel insists that the truth isn’t proprietary but, rather, “belongs to eight billion people.” He’s not alone in his conviction. Several other *wardex* employees have also gone rogue, led by Hugo Wakefield (Colman Domingo), who helps Daniel remain (barely) one step ahead of his pursuers. They also have a potent, if unknowing, ally in Margaret Fairchild (Emily Blunt), a meteorologist from Kansas City, Missouri, who abruptly finds herself over the weather. Delivering her morning report, she begins emitting guttural click-click noises, as if she’s been possessed by a Predator. What does this mean? And how, for that matter, can she suddenly read people’s minds?

Before long, Margaret and her nonplussed partner, Jackson (Wyatt Russell), are also on the run, and although the destination is uncertain, we find ourselves in vintage Spielberg terrain. The cross-country crosscutting is propulsive, and the many chase sequences are filmed with breathtaking agility; at one point, a car tussles with a freight train and loses, in predictable yet spectacular fashion. Spielberg shifts tonal gears with practiced ease, a sense of awe going hand in hand with an ebullient comic anarchy. An early confrontation between Scanlon and Daniel encapsulates these extremes: Firth has seldom looked more malevolently grizzled, whereas O’Connor,

even under the direst circumstances, retains his elfin mischief. When you remember that both actors have played British royalty—Firth in “The King’s Speech” (2010) and O’Connor on two seasons of “The Crown”—their characters’ enmity feels even funnier. Not least among the inspired eccentricities of this American road movie is the fact that Spielberg has cast the major roles with English actors (plus Hewson, who’s Irish). This proves a particular coup in the case of Blunt, who here gets to merge her comedy and action chops within a more earnestly emotive register, playing Margaret as a fount of crackpot conviction.

Margaret, following her nutty North Star wherever it leads, would have been right at home in “Close Encounters of the Third Kind” (1977), in which U.F.O. sightings make enraptured believers of a select few. But that’s hardly the only Spielberg joint that gets revisited. A reference to Roswell harks back to the extraterrestrial shenanigans of “Indiana Jones and the Kingdom of the Crystal Skull” (2009), which, like this film, was written by David Koepp. (He also co-wrote “War of the Worlds,” another alien saga.) When Margaret begins using her telepathic powers, you might flash back to Agatha from “Minority Report,” spouting oracular warnings at every stranger who crosses her path. At times, the new movie recalls Spielberg’s journalistic thriller, “The Post” (2017), which likewise hinges on the dissemination of information that, the powers that be caution, would pose a grave threat to national security.

The real menace here isn’t the aliens—prototypically gray-green, pear-headed beings who, in our occasional glimpses of them, look vulnerable, even frail—but, Scanlon suggests, humanity itself, which is far too hubristic and divided to handle the knowledge of their existence. He and his *wardex* colleagues have turned this foul conviction into a self-fulfilling prophecy: for decades, they have subjected aliens to unspeakable acts of torture, and then hidden evidence of those abuses. You may well think of “E.T.” (1982), with its rather rosier vision of an outer-space visitor being held against its will. These close encounters, by contrast, have been anything but kind.

In February, former President Barack Obama made waves when, during an interview with the YouTuber Brian Tyler Cohen, he said that aliens are “real, but I haven’t seen them.” (He later clarified, in an Instagram post: “I saw no evidence during my presidency that extraterrestrials have made contact with

us. Really!’’) Hours after the interview was posted, Donald Trump rebuked Obama for revealing “classified information”—then, not to be out-revealed, said that his Administration would release government files related to U.F.O.s and U.A.P.s, or unidentified anomalous phenomena. Last month, the Pentagon published a tranche of “new, never-before-seen” images, with the promise of more to come, though the initial evidence has been generally deemed too vague to be conclusive.

Reality, then, has provided its share of free publicity for “Disclosure Day,” but it might be equally fair to say that it has let the air out of the movie’s tires. The tread is a bit worn, in any case. Ostensibly set in the present, with many grim, furrowed-brow references to a Third World War on the horizon, the film plays like a throwback to summer entertainments from earlier decades—and not just because the title evokes “Independence Day” and “Terminator 2: Judgment Day,” two foundational science-fiction blockbusters of the nineties. Koepp’s screenplay samples everything from the sinister government conspiracies of “The X-Files” to the crop-circle mysteries of M. Night Shyamalan’s “Signs” (2002). There’s even a certain nostalgia, verging on naïveté, in the prominent narrative positioning of Margaret’s Kansas City news station. It’s touching to think that Daniel and Margaret’s revolution might be televised— or that American broadcast news, a medium as existentially threatened as it is politically polarized, might turn out to be a vital, globally unifying force.

In the end, Koepp’s script exaggerates the best *and* the worst of how humans might respond to such a revelation, and Spielberg struggles to split the difference between paranoid-thriller cynicism and his usual mode of emotional uplift. That waffling ultimately strands “Disclosure Day” on a heartfelt yet fuzzy middle ground, with a generalized plea for cross-species understanding that, even bolstered by the reliable stirrings of a John Williams score, left me dispiritingly dry-eyed. Domingo’s Hugo, saddled with one of the movie’s windier monologues, argues for “empathy as an evolutionary advantage.” Rather more persuasive is a peripheral character, Sister Maura (Elizabeth Marvel), a Catholic nun who articulates a benevolently progressive view of faith. The existence of extraterrestrial life, she insists, does not negate the existence of God; it confirms that God is, like the universe he created, infinitely greater than humans realize. (It could be the script’s most topical and intellectually provocative thread, given what the

Times' Ruth Graham has called the “unsettling theological implications” of Trump’s alien-data dump for the conservative Christians who form much of his base.)

Spielberg may be a self-professed agnostic, but he believes fervently in certain kinds of miracles, and his film overflows with technological signs and wonders. Scanlon’s most lethal weapon is basically a dental chair, albeit one that allows him to drill into, and control, the minds of his enemies. Margaret, at one point, acquires the ability to turn herself and her comrades invisible, a piece of Houdini-level trickery so pleasing that it threatens to transform “Disclosure Day” into the last thing it needs to be: a commentary on the magic of movies. The metaphor is sealed, I fear, by a bathetic sequence that guides a character into an exact replica of her childhood house—a film set, more or less—so that the traumatic events that once unfolded there can be excavated and exposed. “The Fabelmans” made a rich feast of domestic angst, but even an artist as innately self-reflexive as Spielberg shouldn’t merely repeat himself. Though “Disclosure Day” teems with intelligent life, it also blurs the line—not the one separating us from them but the one between phoning home and phoning it in. ♦

Poems

- [Sectioned](#)
- [American Pokeberry](#)

Sectioned

By Meghan O'Rourke

June 15, 2026



So much of writing looks like nothing,
a nothing that gathers dough-like
in the fingers, slipping away, if you are a mother
not often at your desk:
days of lunch assembly, housecleaning, camp-form filling,
Pokémon-card getting, Lego assembling—
my mind felt the way my body did,
after the C-section, when C was born:
as if it would slip apart,
just fall apart, in two halves.
I don't remember standing
after he was born. I don't remember much—
thirty-six hours of labor, botched anesthesia,
passing out from the pain.
I recall only my mother saying of her own, years ago
(to a friend? to me? before my first surgery?):

When I stood up, I felt I had been hit by a truck.

I stood up in the room.

Moving around, I could tell my body
had been cut in two.

I thought about Rothko, somehow:
segmented pieces.

I answered e-mails, sent the birth announcement
while he was sleeping—his father gone
home to bed—and I stayed
up with the baby, nightmarishly waking
whenever it cried.

I wanted to sleep,
having been cut in half;
having been turned from one to two.

I didn't want the nurses to take the baby away—
after nursing, I fell asleep with the infant
in my arms (six hours of sleep
over three nights of labor),
and the night nurse, checking on me,
shook me and scolded:

“Mom, you cannot do that.

You cannot do that.”

As if I were acting out a choice.

An entire apparatus of “care”

(\$47,561 of it)

and no one could think to help me
put the baby back in its plastic bassinet,
wrapped so all one could see was
the warm tender head.

Then I asked and they took him
to the nursery. And I slept.

When I woke, I gulped for air.

He was not there. I noted, within,
that I had already placed him
in an institution's arms, away from me,
for my own convenience.

Somehow, I made it across the floor

with my walker, each step sending
waves of nausea and pain and dizziness,
a whole-body *No*—
and there he was, being washed
and tended to by the nurse,
who cooed at his length, the way he
instinctually kept curling into a C.
Not me, but a piece of me,
ripped out and sectioned into life.
These days that look like nothing
gather to something
not in the notebook,
a life split in two
spent helping the little thing
come to be.

Poems

American Pokeberry

By January Gill O'Neil

June 15, 2026



Thrashers and cardinals dart
through the brush, through
the season. Trees begin their
letting go as we walk

along the Depot Trail.

Bikers and runners pass like pearls
stringing us to this wild
chandelier of a plant—

magenta stalks, purple-black berries.

Cartoonish. Overripe.

Poke salad, you call it. Toxic.

Yet you crush a few

between your fingers,
 streak them under your eyes
like war paint. A boy again,
 unafraid.

For the rest of the day I live
 inside that gesture, a small delight
in the age of grief.
 Runners waving

good morning, a fawn
 feeding in the woods, a black cat
crossing the path.
 Weed of old spells

and sweet poison
 keeps me from myself,
from the thing that calls me
 to sorrow.

I must have called to it once,
 to its yellowing
heart-shaped leaves,
 and it remembered.

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Tuesday, June 9, 2026](#)

Crossword

The Crossword: Tuesday, June 9, 2026

A moderately challenging puzzle.

By Will Nediger

June 09, 2026





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